

NOT A POTATO

NINETY DAYS



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Chapter 1 — Landing on the Floodplain

The thing about a swindle is that it has good posture.

I'd learned to spot it in airport lounges and ministry waiting rooms — the way a man stands when he's about to tell you something is *for* you, when really it's about to be taken *from* you. Easy shoulders. Open hands. The face arranged into the kind of sincerity you can't manufacture without practice. I read it the way other people read weather, which is to say I've never once managed to turn it off, not at dinner, not in church, not at my own father's funeral, where the man from the insurance company had it too.

So at five forty in the morning, standing on a ridge that had been here three thousand years, I should have been at peace. There was nobody to swindle me. There was only the dark and the cane and the smell of wet earth, and the first grey light coming up over a floodplain so flat it looked like the world had been ironed.

I was not at peace. I'd read the consortium's proposal on the plane. Good posture, every page of it.

"You're standing on it," said a voice behind me.

I didn't jump. I want that on the record. The archivist swears I jumped, but the archivist was forty metres back photographing a trail marker with the devotion of a man cataloguing relics, so the archivist can keep his testimony.

The woman who'd spoken was maybe fifty, in a field shirt gone soft from washing, a state-issue lanyard, and boots that had clearly given up arguing with the gumbo years ago. She had a travel mug and the

stillness of a person who'd watched a great many people arrive at this place and arrive at it *wrong*.

"Standing on what?" I said.

"The ridge." She nodded at the ground, which to me looked like ground — a low, broad swell of grass running off into the murk in a long, patient curve. "Concentric C, second from the inside. People walk it for an hour looking for the monument. They're on the monument. They want a wall. They want a pyramid with a sign."

"And there isn't one."

"There's six of them." She sipped the mug. "You just have to be willing to be unimpressed before you're impressed. Most folks can't do it in that order." A pause that was not unfriendly and not friendly. "You're the film people."

"We're the —" I considered the words *documentary crew* and how they sit on the ear of someone who has spent her life watching documentary crews drive up. "We ask questions. We try to ask them honestly. We don't always succeed."

She looked at me for a moment longer than was comfortable, and I had the genuinely novel experience of being read back. I'm the one who reads the room. It is not, I'll be honest, an entirely pleasant thing to be on the receiving end of, like hearing your own voice on a recording.

"Dr. Aubin Castille," she said. "I'm the site archaeologist. My people have been in this parish a long time. Longer than the state office, longer than the road." She let that sit. "I'll show you what we show everybody. The rest we'll see about."

The rest we'll see about. I filed it. She'd just told me, in seven words, exactly where the boundary of the conversation was, and that she'd drawn it before I got here, and that it wasn't mine to move. I've negotiated with people who took a week to communicate less.

The official story is a marvel, and the state staff tell it well.

By six-thirty there were three of them — two young interpreters from the office and a regional fellow with a clipboard — and they walked us

out along the inner ridge while the light came up grey-gold and the thunder muttered somewhere south, the way it does here all summer, threatening and never quite delivering until it delivers all at once.

The young engineer was already crouched in the wet grass with her hands flat on the ground like she was taking a pulse.

“Late Archaic,” the regional fellow said. “We’re talking roughly seventeen hundred to eleven hundred before the common era. The bulk of these ridges go up between sixteen and thirteen hundred BCE.” He had the cadence of a man who’d said it a thousand times and still meant it. “Six C-shaped ridges, nested. The outermost is about one-point-two kilometres across. You’re inside the largest earthwork construction in North America for its time, and it’s built by people with no agriculture. No farming. Hunter-fisher-gatherers.”

“No crops,” said the archivist, half to himself, already nodding. He’d read the footnotes on the plane the way I’d read the proposal.

“No crops. No grain stores. No granaries to defend, no fields to tie you down. And — this is the part people don’t believe — no kings.”

“No ranked chieftdom,” Castille said, from a little behind us. Correcting the register, not the man. “No archaeological evidence of one. No palace. No rich burial. No one who got the big house and the big grave.”

“So who’s in charge?” I asked. It’s my reflex question. Follow the authority, follow the money — the two are usually the same trench.

Castille looked at the ridge running off into the cane. “Nobody we can find. The reading is that leadership here was *situational*. Something to do, you gather, you sort it out, you do it, and when it’s done the thing that organized you dissolves.” Her mouth did something that wasn’t quite a smile. “People hate that answer. They keep digging for the boss. There’s no boss.”

I thought about the consortium proposal, with its organizational chart, its “project lead,” its tidy hierarchy of who reports to whom about a place built by people who, as far as anyone could prove, had no one to report to.

The young engineer hadn’t moved. “Mound A,” she said. Not a question. She’d done the homework on the flight and she’d done it the

way she does everything, all the way down to the bottom with no light on. “Where’s Mound A.”

The regional fellow pointed west, into the murk, and there it was — I’d been looking at it for ten minutes and reading it as a tree-covered hill, because that is what it looks like, because there was never going to be a sign.

“Twenty-two metres,” he said. “Two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic metres of fill.”

Here is where the easy version starts to weigh something.

Two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic metres. The number means nothing standing up; it’s just syllables. So the young engineer made it mean something, which is what she’s for.

“Baskets,” she said, still crouched, looking at the mound like it had personally insulted the laws of physics. “No wheel. No draft animals. The microstrat shows it’s all hand-carried. Loads of —” she glanced at the regional fellow.

“Thirty to fifty pounds. We can see it in the fill. Different basket-loads of different soils, dumped and dumped and dumped.”

“Okay.” She stood, finally, and her hands were doing the thing they do when the math is happening somewhere I can’t see. “So say fifty pounds, generous. Wet loess, packed, that’s — call it a bit under a tenth of a cubic metre per load if you’re not spilling it, and you’re spilling it. So you’re looking at, conservatively, two and a half, three million basket-loads. To make the mound. Just the mound. Not the ridges. The mound.”

The thunder said something to the south.

“Walk it,” she said. “You don’t dig where you build, you’d undercut yourself, so you’re hauling from a borrow pit, call it a couple hundred metres there and back, loaded one way. Three million trips. Even if you’ve got a thousand people going dawn to dark, even if every one of them is fit and fed and nobody quits and it never rains —” She stopped. She looked at the sky, which was a flat sheet of bruise-grey and getting lower. “It rains here.”

"It rains here," Castille agreed, mildly.

"So you've got a mudslide for a worksite for, what, half the days? And loess turns to soup. And you're carrying soup uphill in a basket on a slope you yourself made slick, and the slope gets taller and steeper every single day you succeed at it." The young engineer pressed her lips together, which is as close as she gets to swearing. "The faster you go, the worse it gets. The easy story gets *harder* the better it works."

I have been doing this a long time, and I have learned to love that exact moment — the moment the official version stops being a number on a placard and becomes a thing that would break your back. Nobody had lied to us. Everything the state staff said was true and sourced and modest. And it was, standing here in the wet at dawn, completely insane. Beautifully, provably, *humanly* insane.

The LENS had not said a word. He hadn't lifted the camera, either, which is its own kind of statement from him. He stood at the edge of the ridge with the strap slack in his hands, looking at the mound the way he looks at things he's not sure he's allowed to keep, and the grey light sat on his face, and I left him to it. You don't hurry the LENS. You especially don't hurry him at dawn.

"Here's the part that should be impossible," Castille said, and now she was the one talking, and the state staff went quiet, because it was hers.

She walked us to a cut where an old core had been taken, where you could read the mound's insides like a book somebody had jammed shut.

"Tristram Kidder, out of Washington University, cored this and read the layers. Microstratigraphy." She crouched, and the young engineer crouched with her, and for a second they were just two people who liked dirt for the same reasons. "When you build a big mound slow — and most big mounds in the world went up slow, generations, your granddaddy starts it — you get *surfaces*. Pauses. The top of one phase sits open to the weather. It rains. There's wash. Leaf litter. A little soil forms. Bugs. You can read the gaps like rings on a tree."

"And here?" I asked.

“No surfaces.” She said it flatly, the way you say a thing you’ve made peace with and other people haven’t. “No weathering between the fill episodes. No rain-wash horizons. No pause.” She put one finger on the cut, on a join I couldn’t even see. “They put this much earth up so fast that the layers never got a chance to sit out in the rain. Kidder’s read is a matter of months. Thirty to ninety days.”

Ninety days.

I said the number out loud, because sometimes I need to hear my own mouth disbelieve a thing to start believing it. “Ninety days. A mountain. By people with no kings to make them, no crops to feed them, no writing to plan it, and no animal to carry it. And then —”

“And then they walked away,” Castille said. “And it’s *held*.” She stood, brushed her hands. “Three thousand years. The Mississippi’s twenty-five miles off and moving. Hurricanes. A summer here will rot a fence post in a season. And this mound has barely eroded, because they didn’t just pile dirt. They *mixed* it. On purpose. Different soils, layered to fight the shrink and swell, to shed water instead of holding it. Kidder compares it to Roman concrete. To Chinese rammed earth.” She let me sit in it. “Foragers. No farms. Engineering soil to outlast empires that hadn’t been thought of yet.”

The young engineer had gone very still, which with her means the opposite of calm.

“That’s not the impressive part,” she said quietly.

“No?” said Castille, and there was the first real warmth in it, the first flicker of *maybe these ones*.

“The impressive part is the rain.” The engineer looked back up at the cut. “To get no weathering surfaces, they didn’t just build fast. They built without a single bad stretch of weather stopping them long enough to leave a mark. In Louisiana. In summer.” She shook her head, once. “You can’t *plan* that. You can plan the baskets. You can plan the soil. You can’t plan ninety dry-enough days in a row in a floodplain. So either they got the single luckiest season in three millennia, or —”

She stopped.

“Or,” Castille said.

And she did not finish it for us. That, I would come to understand, was the whole posture of the woman, and the whole posture of the place. She would give you every measurement. She would hand you the cut, the cores, the basket-loads, the citation. She would walk you right up to the edge of the question and then she'd take a sip of her coffee and watch you stand at it, because the edge was hers, and what was past it was hers, and she had decided long before our plane landed how much of it she was going to let strangers walk out of West Carroll Parish carrying.

The fish — there's always a fish, the part of me that heckles the part of me that wants to believe — the fish said: *or they had a hundred-year forecast and a god who owed them a favour, sure*. The fish is not helpful. The fish is, however, usually right that the answer is more boring and more astonishing than either thing you wanted it to be.

"So what was it for," I said. The other reflex question. The one underneath the money.

Castille looked at me for a long, level moment.

"That's the question, isn't it," she said. Not an answer. A door, with her hand on it.

The thunder finally arrived, low and rolling, and the light came up enough to flatten the magic out of everything, the way day always does — and that was when I saw the trucks.

Three of them, white, immaculate, turning off the parish road in a line, and behind them a flatbed, and on the flatbed the rolled tubes of banners stood up like a stack of cannon. One had come unfastened and flapped loose in the wet wind so I could read it from the ridge, four hundred metres off, in letters designed to be read from exactly that far.

HERITAGE DEVELOPMENT CONSORTIUM.

And under it, smaller, in the warm reassuring serif of money that wants you to trust it:

Unlocking the Wonder.

I felt the proposal go cold in my memory, every well-postured page

of it. *Unlocking*. As if the wonder were a thing behind a door, a thing you could charge admission to, a thing with an owner and a key — instead of what it actually was, which was a hill of mixed earth that ten thousand strangers had carried up out of the mud in a single fevered summer and then left, freely, in the rain, for everyone and no one.

The LENS lowered the camera he had finally, just now, raised.

Castille didn't look at the trucks. She'd known they were coming; she'd probably known the hour. She just turned her coffee mug slowly in her hand and looked at the mound, three thousand years old and holding its shape against everything that had ever tried to wash it away.

"Well," she said, to nobody, to all of us, to the floodplain. "Here's the part of the story I can't show you on the tour."

The first banner went taut against its pole. Down on the flat, doors opened. And a man in good boots and an open, easy face got out of the lead truck and lifted a hand to us, friendly, across the great curve of the oldest earthwork in North America, like a host welcoming guests to a house he had every confidence was already his.

Chapter 2 — The Official Story

The map at the trailhead had it all laid out like a thing you could understand.

Eleanor stood in front of it with both hands wrapped around a paper cup of state-office coffee gone lukewarm in the heat, reading the placard the way she read everything — not for the headline but for the small print, the credit line, the date in the corner that told you who had paid and when. *Poverty Point World Heritage Site*. A diagram in tasteful greens showed the six ridges nested one inside the other, opening west toward the bayou like a hand half-closed. A red star marked Mound A. A scale bar at the bottom claimed the whole arc spanned three-quarters of a mile across.

Three-quarters of a mile. She did the arithmetic without meaning to, the way some people hum. If a person walked the outermost ridge end to end, they'd cover more than a kilometer and a half. And there were six of them. And every spoonful had come up out of the ground in a basket on somebody's back.

"You can stop doing that," Dawi said beside her. The fixer had their sunglasses pushed up into their hair, eyes already moving over the parking lot — two state trucks, a rental sedan that didn't belong to anyone on the tour, a coach bus from a church group in Monroe. "I can hear the math."

"It's a comforting math," Eleanor said.

"It's never comforting when you do it."

The custodian came across the lot to meet them, unhurried, a

clipboard tucked under one arm she clearly didn't need. Dr. Reine Boudreaux had a state lanyard and a sun-faded ballcap and the particular walk of a person who had given this tour four hundred times and meant it every time anyway. She shook hands all the way down the line. Took the photographer's last — looked at the camera, then at the face behind it, and held the handshake a beat longer, the way you hold a door.

"Y'all came a long way to look at some dirt," she said.

"We came a long way to look at the *right* dirt," said Theo, the engineer, who had not yet learned that this was the kind of line you let sit. He was already crouched at the edge of the lot where the mowed grass gave way to the first slope, pressing two fingers into the soil like he was taking its pulse.

Reine watched him do it. Something passed over her face that Eleanor filed and didn't name.

"All right," the archaeologist said. "Let me tell you the story. Then you can tell me which parts you don't believe."

The story, told straight, went like this.

Three thousand years ago — call it 1600 before the common era, give or take, when the pyramids at Giza were already a thousand years old and dusty — people came to this rise above the floodplain of Bayou Maçon and they built. Not a king's people. Not farmers. Hunter-fisher-gatherers, the deep-archive name for folks who ate what the river and the woods and the wild cane gave them, who did not plant a single domesticated seed, who left behind not one grain silo, not one palace footprint, not one body buried with the loot that says *this one was in charge*.

"No agriculture," Reine said, walking them slowly up onto the first ridge. The ground gave under their shoes — not soft, but *kept*, a crown of earth two and a half feet high that the centuries should have flattened and hadn't. "No corn, no squash, nothing in rows. People want to argue the edges of that — were they managing wild stands, encouraging the good plants — fine, argue it. But nobody's found a field. You raise a city like this, conventional wisdom says you need a farm to feed it and a boss to run it. We've got neither."

“And yet,” said the archivist, because someone had to.

“And yet.” Reine turned and swept her arm along the curve of the ridge, where it ran away from them and bent, patient and enormous, toward the next one out. “Six of these. Concentric. The outer one’s about three-quarters of a mile end to end. Between them, the swales — that’s where the houses sat, we think, up on the dry crowns. You’re standing on what may be the largest earthwork of its age in North America, and it was built by people the textbooks called simple.”

“Who called them simple?” Dawi asked. Mild. The fixer’s voice was always mildest right before it wasn’t.

“The textbooks,” Reine said, and let a beat go by. “Not me.”

The fish — Eleanor’s private name for the heckling voice in her own skull, a holdover from a childhood she didn’t discuss — surfaced and said: *No kings, no crops, no problem. Just a really good group project. Three thousand years before anyone invented the wheelbarrow.*

She kept walking.

The math went sideways at Mound A, the way it was always going to.

They came up on it from the south and it stopped being a thing on a placard. It rose out of the flat like weather — twenty-two meters, seventy-two feet, a green hill with a long ramp tailing off to one side so that from the right angle, the archaeologists liked to say, it looked like a bird with its wings spread. Maybe it did. Eleanor couldn’t see the bird and didn’t pretend to. What she could see was the bulk of it. The sheer freight.

“Two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic meters,” Reine said, stopping at the base. She let the number stand there in the wet air. “That’s the fill. All of it carried up here in baskets.”

Theo had gone very still, which was how the engineer got loud. “Thirty to fifty pounds a load.”

“Thirty to fifty.”

“So.” His lips moved. He was doing it the honest way, the slow way, the way that didn’t let you round off into wonder. “If you call it forty

pounds, and you call the soil — what, ninety pounds a cubic foot, dry, more wet—”

“It was wet,” Reine said. “It rains here like the sky’s got a grudge.”

“—then you’re moving something like fifteen, twenty million basket-loads. Up a hill that’s getting taller, so the carry gets longer, every single trip.” He looked up at it. His hand had stopped on his chest where his heart was. “How many people.”

“That’s the question, isn’t it.”

Dawi was already walking the base of the mound, eyes down, reading the ground the way they read a balance sheet — looking for where the numbers stopped adding up and somebody hoped you wouldn’t check. The fixer crouched, picked up a small object from the spoil at the edge of the path, and held it out on a flat palm. A baked lump of dirt, roughly molded, fist-knuckle size, grooved where fingers had pressed it three thousand years before it landed in Dawi’s hand.

“What’s this,” Dawi said.

“Poverty Point Object.” Reine’s voice warmed by a degree. “Cooking ball. You dig a pit, you heat these in a fire, you bury them with your food, you’ve got an earth oven. We find them everywhere out here. Thousands. They’re the dishes that didn’t get washed.”

“People had to eat,” Dawi said, turning the object over. “Thousands of people. For however long this took. Somebody fed them. Somebody hauled the food in, or fished it out, or—”

“Somebody,” Reine agreed, and didn’t finish it for them.

The fish, again: *No farm. No king. But a crowd big enough to raise a mountain, all of them eating three meals a day in a swamp, and somehow nobody starved, nobody mutinied, and nobody carved their own name into anything so we’d know to thank them. Hell of a potluck.*

The part Eleanor had come for — the part she’d read about on the long flight, three different papers open on her tablet, footnotes followed down into footnotes — Reine saved for the top.

They climbed the long way, up the ramp, and it took longer than seventy-two feet of hill had any right to take, and that was the first

lesson and nobody said it out loud. At the summit the floodplain opened all the way to the tree line, green going gray-green going to the haze where the river hid.

“Now,” Reine said. “Here’s what gets the archaeologists out of bed.” She crouched and put her hand flat on the grass. “When Dr. Kidder’s team cut into this mound — careful, thin slices, reading the layers like pages — they were looking for the thing you always find in a big earthwork. The pauses. You build a season, you stop, the rains come, the surface weathers, a little rain-wash, a crust, a skin of mud and leaf. Then next season you build again, and there’s that old surface, sealed in like a line between chapters.”

“And?” The archivist already knew. She wanted to hear the local say it.

“There aren’t any.” Reine looked up at them. “No weathering surfaces. No rain-wash between the fills. No crusts, no pause-lines. Layer on layer on layer, all the way up, and not one of them sat open long enough to feel the weather.” She stood, brushing her palm on her jeans. “Which means they didn’t stop. This whole hill — all two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of it — went up in one push. Kidder will tell you it could be a matter of months. Thirty to ninety days.”

Theo made a sound like the air had gone out of him.

“Ninety days,” he said.

“Maybe less.”

“You can’t—” He stopped. Started again, in the voice he used for problems that had insulted him personally. “We modeled a build like this. Before we came. With trucks. With a *plan*.”

“I bet you did,” Reine said, and there was the sidelong look again — quick, amused, gone, a look that said she’d watched a great many clever people arrive at exactly this number and stagger.

And here was the thing Eleanor had flown across an ocean to stand on top of, and it was worse — better, worse — in person. Because the soil itself was the second miracle and nobody but Kidder seemed to lead with it. The fill wasn’t just dumped. It was *recipe*. Different soils mixed deliberate — the swell-prone clays cut with the silts, the loess

folded in, engineered so the whole mass wouldn't crack itself apart in the heat or slump itself flat in the wet. Three thousand years of Louisiana weather, of that grudge-holding sky, and the hill had barely moved. Kidder, in print, compared it to Roman concrete. To Chinese rammed earth. To the things empires built with engineers and slaves and centuries.

These people built it in a season. With baskets. And then they smoothed the top, and climbed down, and as far as anyone could find — they left.

"They walked away," Eleanor said. It wasn't a question.

Reine was quiet for a moment. The wind moved the grass on the summit and somewhere below a kid from the church group whooped, running down the ramp, the way kids had probably run down this ramp for thirty centuries, the only continuity anyone could swear to.

"They stopped building," the custodian said, carefully. "That's what I can tell you. *Why* they stopped." She looked out over the plain, and then she looked at the crew — all four of them, one slow pass, Dawi to Theo to Eleanor to the photographer with the lowered camera — and Eleanor had the distinct sense of being counted, and weighed, and not yet decided about. "That's a longer conversation. And it's not mine to have with strangers on the first afternoon."

Nobody pushed. Even Theo didn't push, and that was something.

The fish was silent. The fish had nothing. *No kings, no crops, no farm, no pause, a mountain in a summer, a recipe in the dirt, and then the lights go out and everybody goes home.* The official story, told straight by the one person with the standing to tell it, and every single word of it true, and at the bottom of it a hole you could lose a city into.

What did they gather *for*.

Eleanor wrote nothing down. You didn't write down the part that mattered. You held it, and you let it weigh you, the way Reine had let it weigh them.

The rental sedan was still in the lot when they came down.

Dawi clocked it before the rest of them — Dawi clocked everything in a parking lot, it was the wiring, the gift, the thing the schools had once tried to grind out of them and failed — and went quiet in the particular way that meant *work, not wonder, from here*.

The man leaning against it was maybe fifty, in the good linen that reads as casual until you price it. He had a state official on either shoulder, the kind in pressed shirts who carried no clipboards because other people carried clipboards for them, and he was talking with his whole open face, the way a man talks when he has never in his life expected to be told no.

“—not a museum, that’s the *mistake* everybody makes,” he was saying, warm, generous, sweeping a hand at the whole sacred mile of it like a host showing off a kitchen. “You bury it in a museum, you bury it. We *activate* it. Visitor flow, hospitality, an interpretive experience worthy of a World Heritage property — you’ve got the dirt, gentlemen, we bring the *story*. Jobs in a parish that needs them. Preservation that pays for itself. The community wins, the state wins—”

He saw the crew. The smile widened, found a new gear, was genuinely, disarmingly glad to see them.

“Reine!” he called, and the archaeologist’s face did nothing at all, which Eleanor noted, which Eleanor filed. “You giving the famous tour? Don’t let her undersell it, folks — she’s the best there is.” He came off the car with his hand out, and the lanyard turned at his chest, and the archivist read the card the way she read everything, first the small print: *Heritage Development Consortium*. And under the name, a title, and under the title, in letters meant to reassure: *Partners in Preservation*.

“You must be the people who flew in,” he said, and his handshake was dry and warm and good. “I’ve heard wonderful things. We should *talk*.”

Behind him, the green hill held its three-thousand-year shape against the grudge-holding sky, and said nothing, and kept its reasons, and waited to see who’d come to read it and who’d come to take it.

Dawi shook the offered hand. Smiled back, just as warm.

“Yeah,” the fixer said. “We should.”

Chapter 3 — Basket Math

The basket weighed nothing.

Théo turned it over in his hands at the edge of the borrow pit they weren't supposed to call a borrow pit — *Dr. Reyes had said, mildly, that the Late Archaic people who dug it might have a different word, and that we don't get to know it* — and felt the weave give and spring back. Split river cane, doubled at the rim, a thing some intern had made from a museum pattern over two evenings while watching a documentary. It held maybe a peck. Empty, it was a held breath. He liked it. He liked things that did exactly what they were for and nothing else.

“Forty pounds,” he said. “We’ll load it to forty.”

“We will load it,” said Mara from the spoil heap, “to whatever it takes to make a Frenchman stop talking about it.”

The morning was already wrong with heat. Northeast Louisiana in June doesn't warm up so much as close over you, a wet hand on the back of the neck, and the cicadas had started their saw before seven. Out past the fence the great ridges lay under their mown grass like the swells of a sea that had decided, three thousand years ago, to stop. Six of them. Nested Cs opening east toward the bayou, the outermost arc better than a kilometer across. From the ground you could not see them as rings. You could only walk them and feel your feet rise and fall, rise and fall, and trust the survey that said the shape was there.

The plan was simple, which was the first lie.

Théo had built the plan the night before in the field-station kitchen, on the back of a printout, with the engineer's clean joy of a problem

that closes. Mound A was 238,000 cubic meters of fill. Set that aside — *we are not building Mound A, Théo, we have a long weekend and four backs*. Set aside the mountain. Take a meter. One cubic meter of this gumbo, moved from the pit to a stake forty meters off, carried in baskets, by hand, by people, the way it was actually done. No wheel. No barrow. No animal. Time it. Multiply later, in the cool, where multiplying belonged.

A cubic meter of dirt is about 1.5 metric tons. At forty pounds a load — eighteen kilos, call it — that was something like eighty-three basket trips.

Eighty-three trips. He'd written the number and circled it and felt the small clean click of a thing understood. Eighty-three trips, four people, that's twenty-one apiece, eighty meters round each. Under two kilometers of walking, total, per person, carrying. An afternoon. A long one. Doable.

"Doable," he said now, out loud, to no one, and bent to the first basket.

The pit had a skin on it. That was the first thing the plan hadn't known.

Two days of sun had set the top six inches of clay into something between leather and brick, and under the skin the gumbo waited, dark and grey-blue and faintly sulfurous, with the specific malevolence of soil that has decided it is now soup. The mattock bounced off the crust. Théo leaned on it, drove it, and the crust let go all at once so the blade went deep and the gumbo took it and held, a wet mouth closing, and he had to rock the handle and lever and feel the suck release with a sound like a kiss from something you didn't want kissing you.

He filled the basket. It took longer than he'd budgeted, because the spade didn't cut the clay so much as carve and abandon it, and what came up came in plastic lumps that smeared rather than fell. He scraped the blade on the rim. He scraped it on his boot. The basket, when it was full, was not full of forty pounds of soil. It was full of soil and the will to be heavier.

He lifted it.

The thing he would remember, later, telling it at the diner with his hands open in the air, was that the weight was not in his arms. The

weight went straight down through him into his heels, and his lower back came alert all at once the way a phone lights when you don't expect it, and the forty pounds was not forty pounds because forty pounds in a basket against your hip with the load sloshing toward the down-slope of your own walk is a live thing, a passenger that leans when you lean, and the cane bit into his fingers where he'd bunched the rim.

Forty meters.

He counted them. The grass was slick under last night's dew that the sun hadn't found yet down in the troughs between ridges, and his boots, gummed already with the pit, found no edge on it. At meter thirty the basket shifted and he corrected and the correction cost him a half-step and the half-step cost him, somewhere, more than he could name. He tipped the load at the stake. It came out reluctantly, in the same plastic lumps, and sat in a shape that was already, visibly, not a mound. It was a smear with ambition.

"One," he said.

"One!" Mara called back, delighted, vicious. She was sitting on the spoil heap with the clipboard and the stopwatch and a posture of complete physical economy. "How are we feeling about eighty-three?"

"It's hot," said Théo, which was not an answer to the question and was the only answer he had.

Dr. Reyes had come down from the office at some point — Théo hadn't seen her arrive, and that was its own data, that a person could cross open ground in a place this flat and simply be *there* when you next looked, the way the ridges were there, the way the mound was there. She stood at the fence in a state-issue ball cap with the brim sweated dark, and she had her arms folded on the top rail, and she watched.

She did not help. She did not advise. She had walked them out here that morning with a courtesy so total it left no handle to grab, and she had said only, *go ahead*, in the tone of a woman who has watched a great many people go ahead.

Behind her, half a kilometer off, Mound A sat on the western edge of the world.

You couldn't, Théo had decided, hold it in your eye honestly. Twenty-two meters. Seven stories. It rose out of the floodplain with no hill to lean on, no quarry, no rise of bedrock under it — Kidder's cores went down and found *fill*, all fill, the whole seven stories of it carried, and the bird-shape of it, if it was a bird, if the wings were wings, blurred up close into just *slope*, just the steady green tonnage of it against a sky going white. He found, working, that he stopped looking at it. It was easier to dig if you didn't.

He filled the second basket. The third. By the fourth he had a system, and the system was the engineer's small triumph — wet the blade, undercut, *lift* the lump don't *cut* it, swing your hips not your back on the lift, walk the high ground between the troughs even if it was longer. By the seventh basket the system had broken, because the pit had gone to standing water at the bottom where he'd dug it down, and the lumps now came up as slurry, and slurry doesn't carry. It pours. It poured down the side of the basket and down his arm and into his boot, where it would stay all day, a private wet, intimate and cooling and disgusting.

Wei had started on the math out loud, the way Wei did, reading it off the printout in the flat affectless voice that meant *here is a true thing whether or not you want it*.

"Forty pounds was wet weight," Wei said.

Théo set down basket eight. "What?"

"Forty pounds is what the basket holds. The fill weighs what it weighs at the moisture it's at. You weighed it dry, from the pattern card. It's not dry." Wei held up a phone, a calculator on it, the cursor blinking. "Your eighteen kilos of soil at field capacity is closer to twenty-three, twenty-four. Your eighty-three trips is now sixty-four. But each trip is heavier and slower, so." Wei stopped. Wei was scrupulous about the so. "I don't have a number for slower. Mara has the stopwatch."

"Three minutes forty a trip," said Mara, "if you count the dig and the dump. You're slowing. Last one was four-ten."

Théo did the arithmetic without wanting to. Four minutes a trip, even sixty trips, was four hours for one person to move one cubic meter —

and that was him fresh, in the morning, on the easy ground, before the pit went to soup, before his hands. One meter. One.

The mound behind Dr. Reyes was 238,000 of them.

He looked, against his rule, at the mound. Then he looked at his hands, which had opened a blister across the second knuckle of his right ring finger so cleanly it didn't even hurt yet, just gleamed, and he understood with the specific cold of a sum that comes out wrong that the plan had been a plan for moving dirt and the mound had not been built by moving dirt.

"The official version," Mara said, into the long quiet of basket eleven, "is that this is *easy*."

She said it the way she said everything, sideways, with the edge in it that meant she was reading something none of them could see yet — the way she'd read the consortium's slide deck three days back, going still over a single line about *visitor throughput optimization* the rest of them had skated past, and saying afterward in the rental car, *they don't want the site, they want the gate*.

"Not easy," said Wei. "Within capacity. Different word."

"It's a beautiful version," Mara went on, ignoring this, because the version genuinely was, and she was a connoisseur of beautiful versions and what they were built to hold. "No kings. That's the part everybody loves. No pharaoh, no whip, no slaves. You don't need a tyrant to raise a mountain — you just need a big enough crowd that *wants* to. Thousands of them. Coming in from up and down the rivers, hauling chert from a thousand kilometers off, and somebody calls them and they come, and they dig, and they carry, and there's no boss, and it goes *up*." She let the stopwatch dangle. "It's the nicest story archaeology has. It's the one I want to be true."

"It is true," said Dr. Reyes.

It was the first thing she had said in an hour. She said it without heat, leaning on the rail, watching Théo bleed quietly into a basket.

"The no-kings part is true," she said. "We've looked. Forty years of looking. No palace. No throne. No big house with all the imported

goods piled in it and the little houses with nothing. No granary, because no grain — these people fished, and hunted, and gathered, and they came here and they built this and there is nothing in the ground that says one person owned the rest.” She tipped her head at the mound. “And no rain-wash. No weathering between the loads. Kidder cut into it and looked for the surface you’d get if they’d stopped — a dry season, a wet season, a generation, anything — a crust, a wash, a skin like the one you just broke with your mattock. There isn’t one. The fill just goes up, and up, with no pause long enough to leave a mark.”

Théo had stopped. He was listening with the whole of himself, the way he listened when a system finally showed him its true shape.

“How long,” he said.

Reyes shrugged, and the shrug was generous and merciless at once. “He says months. He’ll write *thirty to ninety days* and put a hedge on it because he’s careful. A summer. They raised that” — the mound, the seven stories, the bird — “in something like a single summer.”

The cicadas sawed. Somewhere out on the ridge a mockingbird ran through four other birds’ songs and got bored.

“That’s not possible,” said Théo, and heard how it sounded, and corrected, because he was careful too. “I mean — with this. With the baskets. With this dirt.” He held up his right hand, the blister, the gumbo dried grey to the wrist. “I’ve moved eleven baskets. I’ve moved a tenth of a cubic meter. It’s nine in the morning and I’m done. To do the mound in ninety days you’d need —” He stopped, and his eyes went unfocused, and Wei watched him do the thing he did, the run of the numbers behind the face. “You’d need thousands of people moving baskets every daylight hour for three months without a single one of them quitting. And feeding them. Out here. With no farm.”

“Yes,” said Reyes.

“Where does the food come from?”

“Yes,” said Reyes again, and smiled for the first time, a small private thing, not unkind, the smile of someone who has watched many clever people arrive at exactly this fence in exactly this heat and ask exactly this question, thinking it new.

Wei was still on the phone, still in the flat voice, but something had come into it now, a tension like a wire taking load.

"It doesn't add up," Wei said.

"It adds up fine," said Reyes. "It got built. You're standing in it."

"No — the *labor* adds up, if you have the bodies. That's just multiplication, you scale the crowd, fine." Wei turned the phone around, though no one could read it from where they stood. "It's the *food* that doesn't. A working adult carrying baskets in this heat burns through it. You can't store fish. You can't store deer. There's no maize, no beans, no granary you can crack open to feed a thousand people in July. They're hunter-gatherers — they have to *get* it, daily, fresh, from the country around here, *and* dig *and* carry, every day, for ninety days, and it's the same ninety days the country is hottest and the game scatters." Wei looked up. The literal mind had hit the literal wall and could not pretend the wall was elsewhere. "You'd strip the floodplain bare in a week. The math eats itself. Either they didn't do it in ninety days, or —"

Wei stopped.

"Or," said Mara softly, "they brought the food with them. The way they brought the chert. From a thousand kilometers."

"That's not a thing forager bands do," said Wei.

"No," said Mara. "It isn't."

Théo had set his basket down. He was looking at the mound and he was not, this time, looking away. Behind it the levee held back the bayou the way it had held it for three thousand years against every flood that should by every rule have taken this soft made thing back into the river, and had not, because somebody who didn't write and didn't farm and didn't kneel to a king had known how to mix grey clay and brown silt so it would shrink and swell together and never come apart, and had built a hill that outlasted Rome, and then —

"And then they left," Théo said.

"And then they left," Reyes agreed.

She straightened off the rail. She picked up the empty basket from the top of the spoil heap, the one nobody had filled, and she turned it over in her hands the way Théo had at dawn, feeling the weave, and for a moment she was just a woman holding a basket in a hot field, and the whole of it — the ridges, the mound, the missing king, the missing food, the missing crust between the loads — sat in her two hands and weighed exactly nothing and exactly everything.

“You’re asking the right question,” she said. “But you’re asking the easy one. *How*.” She set the basket down, rim-up, careful, the way you’d return a tool to its place. “How’s just sweat. You’ve got the sweat now.” She looked at his hand, the blister, and her face did something complicated and closed. “Come up to the office when you’re done bleeding. I’ll show you what they fed the crowd, since you can’t stand not knowing.” She turned for the path. “The question that’ll keep you up isn’t *how*.”

She was twenty meters off before Wei called after her, because Wei could not bear an open parenthesis: “Then what is it?”

Reyes didn’t turn around.

“Who calls a thousand people to the middle of nowhere,” she said, to the ridge, to the mound, to the sawing air, “to build something nobody owns — and what does it cost them to all say yes?”

She walked up the rise and over it and was, again, simply gone.

Théo looked down at his one-tenth of a cubic meter, the sad bright smear of it drying grey in the sun, the eleven baskets that had cost him a morning and a finger, and he started, helplessly, against every instinct of a man who liked sums that closed, to laugh.

Chapter 4 — Reading the Layers

The trench was a clean wound in the side of Mound A, and Renny had her face six inches from it before anyone told her she could.

“You can come closer,” Dr. Adeline Boudreaux said, which Renny — the LENS, the camera the crew kept asking to lower — heard a half-beat after she’d already done it. The custodian didn’t seem to mind. She had the patience of someone who had watched a hundred visitors lean in too fast and step back too slow, and had decided long ago which was the worse sin.

The cut face was maybe two meters of exposed earth, braced with plywood and lit by a work lamp on a tripod that hummed in the wet morning air. Above them the mound climbed and climbed — twenty-two meters of it, a green hill with the wrong silhouette, too steep on one flank, broad-shouldered, the body of a bird if you’d been told it was a bird and the wing if you hadn’t. Below, the floodplain ran flat to the tree line, and somewhere past that the river did what it always did, which was wait.

Renny lifted the camera. Then she didn’t. She’d been doing that for three days now — the lift, the second thought, the lowering. The mound did not photograph the way she wanted. The eye made it a hill. The lens made it a hill. The thing that was not a hill lived in the soil itself, and you couldn’t shoot soil and get it to confess.

“What am I looking at,” said Marisol.

The MONEY in the crew, the fixer, stood with her arms crossed against the damp, reading the trench the way she read a contract

— for the clause nobody wanted you to find. She wasn't being rude. She was being Marisol. She needed the load-bearing sentence before she'd let the pretty ones in.

Dr. Boudreaux took a trowel from the bucket by her boot and used the flat of it as a pointer, not touching the face. "You're looking at the question that pays my salary." She let that sit, dry. "And the one I don't answer."

Theo had crouched at the base of the cut with the silent total absorption that meant he'd stopped hearing the rest of them. The young engineer ran a fingertip a half-inch off the dirt, tracing something, lips moving. Behind him the archivist, Wren, had a notebook open and was already writing — Wren wrote before they spoke, always, footnotes first.

"Tell us the easy version," Marisol said. "The one in the brochure."

Boudreaux smiled at that, the smile of a woman who'd read the consortium's brochure too. "The easy version is beautiful. Want it straight?"

"Straight," Renny said. It came out lower than she meant. She wanted it straight. She wanted, just once, to hear the official story told by someone who loved it and had nothing to sell.

So Boudreaux gave it to them straight.

Three thousand years ago, give or take, people came to this bend of bayou and stayed long enough to move a mountain. They had no kings. There's no palace in the dirt, no big house with the good pottery, no burials loaded with grave goods that say *this one mattered more*. No throne. They had no farms — no corn, no maize agriculture, none of the engine that everywhere else in the human story is supposed to come *first*, before the monuments. They fished and they hunted and they gathered and they knew this country the way you know a face.

And they built six ridges in great nested C's, the outermost over a kilometer across, embankments raised by hand. And they built this — Mound A — twenty-two meters tall, two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of fill.

No wheel. No animal to pull a load. No metal in the tools. Every gram of it carried.

"In baskets," Boudreaux said. "Thirty to fifty pounds a load. We've got the impressions, the fabric weave pressed into the fill where a basket dumped and the next one came down on top before it dried. We know the size of the loads because the dirt remembers the basket." She tapped the air over a band in the cut. "Men carried. Women carried. Children carried — you can read it in the load sizes, the little dumps mixed in with the big ones. Everybody. All at once."

"How many people," Marisol asked.

"That's the brochure's favorite word. *Thousands*. And the brochure's right, probably. You don't raise this with forty." She set the trowel back in the bucket. "Skeptics like to say — and they're not wrong, I want to be careful — you don't need a god-king to do this. You don't need writing or wheat or a standing army. You need a big enough crowd and a good enough reason. Organized foragers, motivated, fed. That's it. That's the whole trick."

"That's a lot of trick," said Wren, not looking up.

"It's a lot of trick," Boudreaux agreed.

Renny lowered the camera again. She'd taken nothing. The work lamp hummed.

And here's where the fish would heckle, she thought, because there was always a fish, the part of her that had survived three wars by refusing to be moved by a good speech. *Lovely. A crowd and a reason. Show me the crowd. Show me the reason. Show me lunch.*

So they tried.

It hadn't been Boudreaux's idea — she'd just allowed it, the way you allow children to find out for themselves the stove is hot. The day before, on the cleared ground past the visitor center, the crew had marked off a square and decided, with the confidence of the well-fed, to move some dirt. Theo had run the numbers the night before, and the numbers were friendly. A basket, a back, a distance, a day. Multiply by a crowd. The crowd did the rest. The math closed. Theo

had shown Renny the spreadsheet with the particular joy of a man whose patterns had behaved.

Then they'd done it with their hands.

The gumbo clay of West Carroll Parish does not want to be a basket-load. Wet, it is a living thing that grips the trowel and the boot and the soul. Dry — it had not been dry — it would have been brick. Theo had filled a basket to what he swore was forty pounds and carried it forty meters and dumped it and gone back, and on the eighth trip the friendly math had begun, quietly, to come apart. Not because the arithmetic was wrong. Because the arithmetic didn't know about the heat, or the way the clay clung to the weave and refused to let go clean, or the way a back that has carried seven loads negotiates with the eighth.

By noon they had a pile you could trip on. By the real count — Wren had kept it — they had moved, between four adults, something on the order of a few cubic meters in half a day, in good light, with plans, with cold water and granola bars and the absolute certainty they could quit whenever they liked.

Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters.

Theo had stood at the foot of their embarrassing hillock and looked up at the real mound and said nothing for a long time, which for Theo was a kind of scream. The pattern hadn't lied to him. It had just left out the body. The body always got left out of the spreadsheet.

"You felt the gap," Boudreaux said now, watching his face at the trench. "Everybody feels the gap. The number's true and the number's nothing. The number doesn't know about your shoulders."

"So how long," Marisol said. "The honest range. To put up the whole mound."

And this — Renny would remember this — was where the custodian stopped being a docent.

Boudreaux turned back to the cut and looked at it the way Renny looked at a face she was about to photograph, which is to say she stopped performing.

"There's a man named Kidder," she said. "Washington University. He read this — *this* face, and faces like it, all through the mound. And the thing about Mound A, the thing you have to understand, is what *isn't* in it." She raised the trowel again, hovered it over the bands. "Look at the layers. Different soils. Light, dark. Sandy, clayey. They didn't dig from one borrow pit — they pulled from all over, and you can see it, the colors stack up like —"

"Like a slice of something," Theo said.

"Like a slice of something." A flicker of approval. "Now. When you build slow — when you stop — what happens to the top of a dirt pile between work seasons?"

Wren answered without looking up, because Wren had the footnote. "It rains."

"It rains. The wind gets at it. Things grow. A surface forms — a weathering horizon, we call it. The rain washes the fines down, makes a little crust, a stain, a hardpan. Worms come. Roots come. If you leave a dirt pile alone for a winter, the dirt tells on you. It writes down that it sat." She lowered the trowel. "Every monument like this that we know got built in stages. Generations, sometimes. A king dies, the next one adds his layer. You read the seasons in the soil like rings in a tree. The pauses are *right there*. The dirt keeps the calendar."

She let it hang.

"And here," Marisol said. The fixer's voice had changed. She'd found the clause.

"And here," said Boudreaux, "there are no pauses."

The work lamp hummed. Out past the tree line the river kept doing what it did.

"No weathering surfaces," Boudreaux went on, quieter. "No rain-wash horizons between the fill episodes. No worm churn that says a year went by. No crust. You go up two meters of this mound, basket-load on basket-load, soil on soil, and the dirt never once gets a chance to sit down. It never rains on the same surface twice. It never *stops*." She touched the air an inch from the face, moving her hand up the bands, smooth, no hitch. "It's one motion. From the bottom to the top, it's one held breath."

“How long is a held breath,” Marisol said.

“Kidder’s number.” Boudreaux looked at her. “Months. Possibly thirty to ninety days.”

Renny had the camera up before she decided to. The reflex won.

She did not shoot the mound. She shot the cut — the work lamp raking across the bands, the little shelf where the dirt changed color, the trowel-shadow Boudreaux’s hand threw across three thousand years of held breath. Through the viewfinder it was, still, only dirt. The frame refused the meaning. That was the honest thing about a camera; it would not lie for you. It gave you the surface and made you carry the rest yourself.

Thirty days, the fish said, very quietly, no longer heckling. A mountain. With no king to make them. No farm to feed them through the lean part, because there is no lean part, because they didn’t stay. In one summer. And then —

She didn’t let it finish. She’d learned not to let the questions finish, in the field. You finished a question and it ate the day.

But Marisol let it finish, because Marisol’s whole gift was finishing the dangerous question out loud.

“Ninety days,” she said. “Feed thousands of people who don’t farm. Get them all here at once. Carry a mountain. And nobody’s in charge. There’s no —” she searched for it, the contract-word — no *enforcement*. No one to dock your pay. No one to whip you. You can leave whenever you want.” She looked at the mound. “And nobody left until it was done.”

“That’s the part the brochure can’t sell,” Boudreaux said. “Because the brochure needs a hero. A consortium needs a hero — somebody to put on the interpretive panel, somebody whose vision *unlocked* the site.” Her mouth went flat on the word; she’d been read that word too. “There’s no hero in the dirt. There’s just everybody, all at once, not stopping.”

Theo was still at the base of the cut. He hadn’t moved. When he spoke it was to the soil, not to them, in the flat literal voice that meant he’d seen the actual thing under the words.

"It scales the wrong way," he said.

"Say it," Boudreaux said.

"When it's hard, you go slower. We went slower yesterday. Eight loads and you slow down. That's how it's supposed to work — the work gets heavier so the building gets slower, the curve flattens out, you get a hill that grows slow." He put his finger near the topmost band. "But this didn't flatten. It got *faster* the higher it got, or at least it never let up, and the top of a mound is the hardest part, you're carrying everything *up* —" He stopped. The pattern had no body in it and the body was the whole story and he knew it now, he'd carried eight baskets and he knew it in his shoulders. "It shouldn't speed up under load. People don't. Unless —"

He didn't finish either.

Boudreaux waited to see if anyone would reach past it — reach for the word that wasn't allowed, the lost-civilization word, the they-had-help word, the easy magic that closed the wonder down. None of them did. Renny noted that the way she noted light. The crew held the gap open instead of filling it, and the custodian noticed them noticing, and something settled between them that was close to trust.

"You want to know what it was *for*," Boudreaux said. It wasn't a question. "Why they came. Why they all stayed. Why they stopped." She picked up her bucket. The interview was ending on her clock, not theirs. "That's mine. That part's mine to tell or not, and I haven't decided you yet."

"Fair," Marisol said.

"I'll give you the dirt." Boudreaux gestured at the cut, at the bands, at the held breath. "The dirt I'll give anybody who'll read it with a cold eye and not make it a circus. The dirt's already in the journals — Kidder, two thousand nine, then again later. Go read it. It'll tell you exactly one thing for certain, and the one thing is the whole problem."

Renny lowered the camera. Asked it, finally, plainly, into the humming morning, the question that the soil had answered and the rest of it had not:

"What's the one thing?"

Boudreaux was already turning toward the trail, the bucket swinging,

the bird-shaped hill above her holding its impossible single breath the way it had held it for three thousand summers without weathering, without pause, without telling.

“It wasn’t built slow,” she said, and left them with it.

Chapter 5 — The Consortium's Pitch

The community center in Epps had the kind of air conditioning that wins arguments. Outside, the heat sat on the parish like a wet dog. Inside, the room hummed cool and blue, and somebody had set out coffee in a forty-cup urn and a pyramid of store-bought cookies still in their plastic shell, the way you do when you want people comfortable but not so comfortable they stay all night.

Devra took the back row. She always took the back row. From the back you could read the whole room — who leaned toward the front and who leaned toward the door, whose arms were crossed before anything had even been said. Money and grift announced themselves the same way: in the body, before the mouth. She'd learned that watching other rooms, years of them, the rooms where she was the only one who seemed to notice that the smiling man's hands didn't match his voice. Her wiring wasn't a gift anyone had thanked her for, back then. It was just the thing that kept her watching when everyone else relaxed.

She was watching now.

The consortium's man was good. She gave him that immediately, the way you'd give a card sharp his quick fingers. His name was Carrick, and he wore the field uniform of the well-funded — chinos, a quarter-zip with a small embroidered logo over the heart, boots that had clearly been bought for this exact slide deck. He didn't talk down to the room. That was the first impressive thing. He shook hands first, learned names, asked after somebody's mother by name like he'd done his homework, which he had.

"I'm not here to tell you what you have," Carrick said, and the projector threw Mound A onto the pull-down screen, that great green back of earth rising out of the floodplain. "You know what you have better than I ever will. I'm here to talk about what the *rest of the world* doesn't get to see yet."

Across the aisle, Theo — the engineer — had his notebook open and was already sketching the building's HVAC ducts because he couldn't help it. Pilar, the archivist, sat very still with a folder of photocopies in her lap that she had not been asked to bring. Mara had her camera down at her side, not raised, the lens cap on, which was its own kind of decision. The LENS lowering the camera was always a decision.

Carrick clicked. The screen filled with an artist's rendering: a long low building of glass and rust-colored steel, nestled tasteful into the ridges, a parking lot you could land a plane on.

"Interpretive center," Carrick said warmly. "Climate-controlled. A theater — fourteen minutes, immersive, the build of Mound A in real time. You walk in, the lights come down, and you *feel* what it was to be one of those thousands hauling a basket up that slope. You feel the gathering."

Devra noticed who in the room leaned forward at *gathering*. Old word. Loaded word, here.

"Now." Carrick set down the clicker, which was a tell — *I'm done selling, here comes the part where I'm honest with you*. "I've read your visitor numbers. With respect — you're a World Heritage Site since 2014, same list as the pyramids, same list as the Great Wall, and you get a fraction of the people a roadside dinosaur park gets. That's not a knock on this place. That's a *wound*. The story isn't getting out. Nobody's *carrying the basket*."

He let that land. He was a man who knew the value of a good silence.

"The official story of this place," Carrick went on, "is honestly one of the great stories on the continent. And it deserves a stage."

He wasn't wrong about the story. Devra had spent the week with it, and it had gotten under her skin in a way that grift never did and wonder sometimes still could.

Here was the thing they were all sitting on, polite in the air conditioning. Three thousand years ago, give or take, people came to this exact ground — hunters, fishers, gatherers of wild things, no farms, no granaries, no wheat or maize stacked against the winter. No king. Pilar had said it three times because nobody believed it the first two: *no chief*. No palace under the dirt. No throne room, no royal burial fat with grave goods, no ledger of who owed what to whom. The archaeologists had looked. Generations of them had put trowels in this ground precisely *hoping* to find the boss, because that's what makes the story easy. A boss explains a mountain. A boss says *do this* and the dirt moves.

And they hadn't found him.

What they'd found was the dirt itself. Six C-shaped ridges nested one inside the next, the outer arc better than a kilometer across. And Mound A — twenty-two meters, a bird shape if you stood far enough back, two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of fill. All of it carried. Every grain. No wheel turned at Poverty Point. No ox leaned into a yoke. No iron bit the ground. Just baskets, thirty to fifty pounds a load, hauled by hand — and the microstratigraphy, Kidder's work, said something that still made the back of Devra's neck go cold in the cold room.

The layers had no skin.

That was how Pilar had put it, and it stuck. When dirt sits, it weathers. Rain beats a crust onto it. Roots take hold. Worms work it. You get a *surface*, a line in the stratigraphy that says *here we stopped, here we waited out a season*. Mound A didn't have those lines. The fill went up wet on wet, basket on basket, no rain-wash between the episodes, no pause for the world to touch it. Built, the man from Washington University said, in a matter of months. Possibly thirty to ninety days.

A mountain. In a summer. By a crowd that answered to no one anybody could find.

The skeptics, bless them, had the sensible answer and Devra respected it. *You don't need a king*, they said. *You need a big enough crowd and a reason. People will move heaven and earth for a reason. Look at a barn raising. Look at Burning Man. Look at any festival that puts up a city in a week and tears it down.* True. All true. The achievement was extraordinary, the consensus said, but it sat inside

the capabilities of organized people who *wanted* to. No magic. No lost super-race. Real hands, real backs, real baskets.

Devra liked that answer. She'd tried to live inside it. And then Theo had ruined it for her with arithmetic.

They'd run the potato two days back, out on the edge of the ridges where the state let them, with permission and a witness and a stack of actual baskets. Theo had done the math first the way Theo did everything, completely and out loud whether you wanted it or not. Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters. Call the dirt a ton and a half a cube, wet. Baskets at, say, forty pounds. He'd filled a legal pad.

"That's millions of loads," he'd said, in the flat, delighted way he had with numbers that should have horrified him. "Tens of millions, if they're carrying it any distance. And the borrow pits aren't right next to the mound. So everyone's *walking*."

So they'd walked it. Four of them, healthy backs, daylight, a plan, a cooler of Gatorade. They'd dug from a designated spot, packed the baskets, carried them across, dumped them, walked back. They'd done it for two hours and built — Theo measured — a heap you could've stepped over. Mara had photographed the heap, then photographed their faces, then put the camera down.

The gumbo clay was the part the math didn't tell you. The math didn't tell you that the soil here grabs your boot and keeps it, that a forty-pound basket is forty pounds for the first trip and ninety by noon, that the borrow pit fills with water at the bottom and you're scooping mud, that the sun comes down on the floodplain like it has a grudge. Devra had carried maybe forty loads before her hands quit cooperating. She'd looked at the heap, and then looked east at Mound A standing there twenty-two meters into the haze, three thousand years old and barely eroded — *barely eroded*, because they'd mixed the soils on purpose, Kidder said, mixed them to fight the shrink and swell, engineered them to shed water and hold their shape, the way Rome made concrete, the way China rammed its earth.

And she'd thought: *ninety days*.

Four of us, two hours, a heap you could step over. And somewhere in

that haze, thousands of strangers with no boss had thrown up a mountain between two floods and walked away from it, and the mountain was *still here*, and they were not, and nobody had written down why.

The hole didn't close. She'd turned it every way she knew, and it would not close. Not *how* — they knew how, baskets, the how was almost the whole marvel. The hole was the part Carrick had said out loud without knowing he'd said it.

The gathering.

How do you summon thousands of people who answer to no one? How do you feed them — no farms, remember, no surplus grain, just the river and the woods and those baked loess cooking balls they made by the hundred-weight to heat their earth ovens? How do you keep that many strangers fed and aimed and willing, for a single relentless season, with no one who can make anyone do anything — and then how does it *end*? How does everybody put down the basket on the same day and go home, and not come back to finish, and not fight over who keeps it, and not leave a single line of writing or one royal grave to tell you whose idea it was?

You don't. That's the thing. You shouldn't be able to. And the mountain is right there.

“—which is why,” Carrick was saying, and Devra came back to the cold room, “we'd handle interpretation. Professionally. A unified narrative. Visitors get *confused* by ambiguity, and forgive me, but this place has a lot of it. Was it astronomical? Some say the ridges line up to the solstice—”

“Some say they don't,” said a voice from the front, mild as milk.

Dr. Lemoine hadn't stood up. She didn't need to. She was the state's site archaeologist, and she was from here — three generations of *from here*, kin scattered through every other pew in the room — and when she spoke the room turned the way a field turns to weather.

“Haag picked one center and got an alignment,” she said. “Purrrington picked a different center and got a different one. Two good scholars, two solstices, one mound. That ambiguity you'd like to clean up — that's not a smudge on the glass, Mr. Carrick. That's the honest state

of the question.”

Carrick recovered well. “Of course. And we’d present the leading theory—”

“Whose?”

“—with appropriate caveats, in a way the public can—”

“Whose theory leads,” Dr. Lemoine said, “in your fourteen-minute movie?”

He smiled, and it was a real smile, and that was what made Devra’s stomach drop, because he *believed* it. There was no cabal in this man. He wasn’t hiding a knife. He thought he was bringing this place a gift, the gift of being *understood*, of being *finished*, of being made legible to a man in a minivan who had forty seconds before his kids needed the bathroom.

“With respect, Doctor,” Carrick said gently, “the public doesn’t come for the open question. They come for the answer. We can give your people that. We can give them the gathering, the build, the *wonder* — packaged so it travels. That’s not taking anything from you. That’s putting your story on the map.”

And there it was. Devra felt it click into place the way it always did, late and cold and certain, the read arriving in her body before her words caught up. Theo was still sketching ducts. Mara’s camera was still down. Pilar’s folder was still closed.

She knew this shape. She’d seen it in a dozen other rooms, in pitch decks and term sheets and the soft mouths of men who genuinely meant well. They never came for the dirt. The dirt was protected; nobody was bulldozing Mound A; the deal didn’t need the earth.

The deal needed the *story*. That was the asset. The fourteen-minute answer, the unified narrative, the leading theory with appropriate caveats — that was the thing being bought, and the price of it was the thing Dr. Lemoine had just defended with one quiet question. The ambiguity. The hole. The right of the people in this room to stand on their own ground and say *we don’t know what called them here, and we hold that not-knowing, and it is ours*.

You sell the answer, you’ve sold the wonder. And once the wonder’s been packaged so it travels, it doesn’t belong to the back pews any-

more. It belongs to whoever owns the theater. The cost of the interpretive center wasn't the parking lot. It was access — to the question itself. They'd be tenants of their own *maybe*.

Devra leaned over to Pilar and said it low, so only she heard.

"He's not buying the mound. He's buying the part nobody knows."

Pilar didn't look up from her closed folder. "I know," she said. "I brought the deed restrictions."

At the front, Dr. Lemoine had let the silence go long, the way she'd let it go long out at the borrow pit when the crew had asked her *why* and she'd looked at the bird-shaped mountain and the borrow pits full of water and said only, *Ask me how, and I'll talk all day*. She did the same thing now. She let Carrick's good, sincere smile sit out in the open until it began, very slightly, to age.

"Thank you for the slides," she said. "We'll have questions."

She did not say what the questions were. She didn't have to. She reached down, picked up her own folder — thicker than Pilar's — and set it on the table in front of her without opening it, and the cool blue room understood that the meeting had just changed hands, and that the changing had been hers to do, and nobody else's.

Outside, somewhere past the AC's hum, the thunder started up over the floodplain, the way it did most afternoons, building toward a rain that the mountain had been shrugging off for three thousand years.

Chapter 6 — Mud and Memory

The thing nobody tells you about gumbo clay is that it has opinions.

Dapo had been reading about it for three days — the soil reports, Kidder's papers, the section drawings with their hairline divisions of fill — and on paper the clay was data. Munsell colors. Shrink-swell indices. A material so plastic that a society without metal or wheels had nonetheless engineered it to outlast the empires that came after them. On paper it was a marvel you could admire from a clean chair.

In the trench it was a substance with a personal vendetta. It took the young engineer's trowel and would not give it back. It took her boot and held the boot and let her foot keep going.

"It's *grabbing* me," Sena said, with the wonder of a person discovering a new physical law. She had hyperfocus the way other people had weather systems — total, climatic, arriving without warning. Right now the whole front had moved into the mechanics of her own sinking foot. "Dapo. It's not slipping. It's *adhesive*. The cohesion's higher than the — this is why it holds the mound shape. It doesn't shear, it *clings*."

"Try not to leave a leg in the World Heritage Site," Dapo said. He wrote it down anyway. Cohesion. Clings. The footnotes were always in the body.

They were in the long shadow of the second ridge, where the state had opened a study cut the width of a kitchen table, walled with corrugated steel, the spoil heaped neat under blue tarp against the afternoon's promised thunder. Above the cut the ridge ran off east and

west in its great patient curve — one arc of six, nested like ripples someone had frozen, the outermost a kilometer and a fifth across, so wide that standing inside it you could not feel its shape at all. From the air it was a target, an eye, a thing built to be *seen by something*. From the ground it was simply a field that rose a little under your boots and you would never have known unless someone told you, and people had to be told, for three thousand years, *this is not nothing, this is the largest earthwork of its age in the hemisphere, walk gently*.

Marguerite Toussaint told them exactly that, the first morning, in those words, and then she'd watched to see who walked gently.

She stood at the lip of the cut now, the custodian, the state-site archaeologist whose family had been in this parish since before it was a parish. She didn't dig. She watched them dig, which Dapo had come to understand was the more skilled position. She'd point with two fingers — *there, that change, see it* — and a thing that had been mud would resolve into an edge, a floor, a decision someone made when Babylon was young.

"You found one," she said now.

Sena had her hand out of the wall before Dapo registered the change in her breathing. In her palm, brown on brown, a lump the size of a small fist, grooved on one side, faceted on the others — finger-pressed, fired, three thousand years old and warm-looking even in the gray light.

"Poverty Point Object," Marguerite said. "PPO. You'll find them by the wheelbarrow. They cooked with them."

The Lens was already down on one knee with the camera, finding the angle where the grooves caught the light without flattering them. He shot it the way he shot everything — like it might be the last frame before something he couldn't stop. He didn't say anything. He rarely did, in the field. The shutter was his sentence.

"How?" Dapo asked. The archivist's job, mostly, was to ask *how* and then get out of the way of the answer.

"Loess." Marguerite crouched, took the object from Sena without ceremony, turned it once. "Windblown silt, the bluff dirt. They'd shape it wet, press it with their fingers — that's a thumb, that groove, that's

somebody's actual thumb — bake it hard in a fire. Then you dig your oven pit, you build your fire, you fill the pit with these. They hold the heat. Different shapes, different burns. The grooved ones, the cross-grooved, the biconical." She set it back in Sena's palm. "People used to call them 'objects' because they couldn't decide what they were. Turned out they were how you fed everybody. You can't roast a thousand people's dinner over open flame. You can in a pit full of hot clay."

"A thousand people," Dapo said.

"More." She stood. Her knees did not consult her about it. "On a good gathering. We don't know how many. Nobody left a census."

Here is the official story, and it deserves to be told straight, because the people who built it earned the straightness:

The people who made Poverty Point did not farm. There is no maize in the soil, no domesticated seed-cache, no granary, no field. They hunted, they fished the rich braided waters of the floodplain, they gathered the wild bounty of a place where the rivers met and the deer came down and the fish ran thick. They had no metal. No wheel. No beast that would pull a load for them. They had no king — and this is the part the skeptics love, and they are right to love it — no palace under any of these mounds, no throne room, no granary controlled by a strongman, no burial stuffed with the loot of power. Dig where the chief should be and you find more mud.

And with no king and no plow and no wheel, they built *this*. Six ridges. A bird-shaped mound twenty-two meters tall holding a quarter-million cubic meters of earth. By hand. Basket by basket, thirty to fifty pounds a load, every load carried on a human back, and the soil itself shows that the backs belonged to men, women, and children both — the fill is mixed the way only many different hands mix it, not the regimented courses of slave-gangs but the variegated, individual, *everyone-pitched-in* texture of a thing done by a crowd that wanted to.

The skeptics say: you don't need kings to move dirt. You need a crowd and a reason. Give a free people a feast and a purpose and they will out-build any pharaoh's whip. That's not a lesser marvel.

That's a *greater* one. Dapo wrote that down too, and underlined it, because it was true and because the consortium's glossy proposal had used almost exactly those words — *the power of community* — to mean something much smaller.

The thunder came in around three, the way it had every afternoon, building in the southwest like a decision being made. They worked through the first growl of it. Sena had moved from the wall to the spoil pile, sorting — PPOs in one tray, lithic debitage in another, the little stone flakes that fell from someone's tool-making and lay where they fell for thirty centuries.

"This isn't local," she said, of a flake the color of old honey. "The chert. Is this local?"

Marguerite did not even look. "No."

"Where from?"

"Far." She let it sit, then relented, the way she relented — a fragment, never the whole. "They brought stone here from a thousand kilometers off. Gravels from the Ozarks, the Ouachitas. Material from up the rivers, all the way up. Things from the Tennessee Valley, the Appalachians." A small dry pause. "You'll read 'Great Lakes copper' in the old books. Some of that's been walked back — turned out to be southern Appalachian, when they did it properly. The network's real and it's continental. The exact strings of it, who carried what how far — that's still being argued. Be careful which version you write down."

Dapo, who had been about to write down *Great Lakes copper*, did not write down *Great Lakes copper*.

"So they traded across a continent," he said, "with no carts and no roads."

"Rivers are roads." She gestured, a flat sweep of the hand toward the water glittering beyond the trees, the Bayou Maçon, the old course of an old river. "This place sits where the waters gather. That's not an accident. You want to understand why anyone walked here from a thousand kilometers — start with the fact that the water already came here. They built where the rivers already met. People follow water. People and goods and news." She watched a flake of lightning open

the southwest sky. “And then they all went home and brought it back next year. We think. That’s a *think*. Write that as a think.”

“How do you know they went home?”

“Because nobody lived here the way you’d live somewhere you lived.” The answer came fast, worn smooth. “Not enough trash. Not enough of the ordinary mess of staying. Lots of feasting, lots of building, lots of the big rare beautiful things — and then quiet. It reads like a place people *came to*. Came to and left and came back to.” She paused. “Reads like a fair, if you wanted it ugly. Reads like a pilgrimage if you wanted it pretty. We don’t get to pick the word. The ground didn’t leave us the word.”

This is the potato, and they walked straight into it that afternoon, the way they always did, because the House move is to *try the easy version yourself*.

Earlier in the week, before the trench, the crew had run the numbers and then run the dirt. The numbers were Sena’s. The dirt was everyone’s.

Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters in the big mound. Say a basket holds, generously, an eighth of a cubic meter. Say a strong person makes — Sena had timed herself, on a hot day, with a real basket of real fill, carrying it a real distance up a real slope — *fewer* trips per hour than you’d ever guess, because the second hour is not the first hour and the fifth is not the second, and the clay grabs your boot, and the slope you built yesterday is now the slope you climb today, and it rains.

Run it honestly and the mound takes a generation. Run it the way the proposal ran it — clean spreadsheet, fresh backs all day, no rain, no friction, no humans being human — and it still takes years.

And then you read Kidder.

That was the wall Dapo couldn’t climb back over, the one he kept circling at night. Tristram Kidder of Washington University took his cores and his careful blades into Mound A and went looking for the thing that *has* to be there if you build a mountain over years: the pauses. The rained-on surface. The little crust of weathering that

forms on any exposed dirt the moment you stop and let a season pass. The thin dark line that says *here, work halted; here, a winter came; here, the rain washed the top and a skin formed before the next baskets came.*

He found none.

Not “few.” None of the weathering surfaces you would expect between fill-episodes. No rain-wash horizons. No pause long enough to leave a mark. The microstratigraphy reads as one relentless push — basket on basket on basket, fast enough that the next load buried the last before the sky could touch it. Kidder put a number on the thing the official story can barely hold: *a matter of months. Possibly thirty to ninety days.*

Sena had read it three times and then gone very quiet, which for Sena was a kind of shouting.

“That’s not possible,” she’d said, finally, “with the labor we modeled.”

“It happened,” Marguerite had said. “So the model’s wrong, not the mound.”

“So how many people—”

“More than the model lets you have.” And she had smiled, not unkindly, at the engineer’s affronted face. “That’s the marvel, *cher*. Not that they were magic. That they were *many*. Enough hands and there’s no impossible. Just a lot of suppers to cook.”

A lot of suppers. A pit full of hot clay balls. Dapo turned the PPO over in his head all afternoon — *that’s a thumb, that groove* — and tried to count thumbs.

The rain held off until they were packing out, and then it didn’t.

They sheltered in the field station, the four of them and Marguerite, while it came down the way it comes down here, a wall of it, the parking lot a sheet of moving water inside a minute, the bayou somewhere out there fattening on it. The Lens stood at the window with the camera down, finally down, watching the rain do to the world what the people who built this place had spent a season teaching the earth to resist. The mound, out there in the dark, was shedding the storm

the way it had shed three thousand storms — soils mixed on purpose, silt and clay and sand in proportions that controlled the swelling, that gripped, that did not slump. Roman concrete, Kidder called it, when he reached for a comparison a modern reader could feel. Chinese rammed earth. Made by people with no word for either, who had simply learned what dirt would do if you treated it right and then taught the dirt to keep doing it after they were gone.

Sena had the tray of PPOs on the table and was arranging them by groove-type with the absorption of someone for whom the rain did not, at this moment, exist.

Dapo had his notebook open and the thing he wanted, the *real* thing, sitting unasked between them like the storm.

“You keep pointing us at the *how*,” he said. Quiet. Just the rain. “The clay. The baskets. The trade. The cooking balls. You’ll tell us all day how they did it.” He let it sit. “You won’t tell us why they came.”

Marguerite looked at him for a while. Long enough that the Lens turned from the window.

“No,” she said. “I won’t.”

It wasn’t a refusal the way a stranger refuses. It was older than that, and it had a floor under it.

“My grandmother’s people were here before there was a fence around it,” she said. “Before there was a sign. There’s things that came down — not a story you could write in your book. Pieces. A way of saying the place. What it was *for* you’d call it. We have some of that. Not all. The ones who knew the most of it died with the most of it, the way it goes. The way it was *let* to go, some of it — because some of it wasn’t for keeping in a mouth that didn’t earn it.”

The Lens did not lift the camera. The notebook stayed open and unwritten-in. Even Sena had stopped sorting.

“Your consortium fellow,” Marguerite went on, mild as the start of the storm had been mild, “he came in here with a slide that said *unlock the story*. Unlock.” She tasted the word and set it down. “Like the story was a box with a thing inside and the thing belonged to whoever paid for the key. There’s no key. There’s no thing in a box. There’s a place, and the people who walk it, and what the place agrees to

say to who.” She looked at the tray of cooking balls, the thumbprints, the suppers. “The ground gave you those. The ground gives up the *how* all day long — it can’t help it, it’s just sitting there in the dirt for anybody with a trowel and a season.”

She stood, and her knees still did not consult her, and she gathered her hat against the going-out into the rain.

“But the *why*,” Marguerite said, at the door, “some things the ground keeps.”

She went out into it. They watched her cross the flooding lot toward the dark shape of the mound, unhurried, getting wet, a woman walking gently on the largest thing her people ever made, toward an answer she was under no obligation to share with anyone holding a camera.

Behind them, Sena turned a cooking ball over and found the thumbprint again, and pressed her own thumb to it, lightly, the way you’d touch a hand across a long table.

It didn’t fit. Of course it didn’t. It was somebody else’s.

Chapter 7 — The Gathering

Theo had the whiteboard propped against the tailgate of the truck, and the whiteboard was losing.

It wasn't a whiteboard, technically. It was a sheet of corrugated plastic he'd liberated from a campaign sign — VOTE somebody for somebody — and turned to its blank side, and across that blank side he had built a city out of dry-erase marker. A grid. Columns. The columns were the problem.

"Okay," he said, to nobody, which was how he talked when the numbers were going somewhere. "Say a thousand people. That's conservative. That's a Tuesday."

"A thousand people is not a Tuesday," said Naila, from the truck bed, where she was sitting with her back against the cab and her feet up and her phone held the way she held it when she was reading a contract and pretending to read the news. "A thousand people is a music festival. Do you know what a music festival costs to put on?"

"That's what I'm doing." He uncapped a fresh marker. The first one had died mid-equation, which felt like a verdict. "I'm putting on a music festival in 1400 BCE."

Behind them the ridges ran out across the flat in their long, patient arcs, six of them nested one inside the next like the rings a stone leaves on water, except the water had been mud and the stone had been ten thousand baskets and the rings had stayed. From the truck you couldn't read them as anything but landscape — gentle swells of grass, a slight rise underfoot, the kind of ground a farmer would curse for being neither field nor pond. You had to get up on Mound A, or look at the lidar, or have somebody tell you, before the shape

came up out of the green and grabbed you by the collar. That was the thing about the place. It hid in plain enormity.

Theo did not have trouble seeing it. Theo had the opposite trouble. He'd looked at the survey map for an hour the night before and now he couldn't *stop* seeing the grid laid over the world, the C-ridges with their measured spacing, the plaza with its buried rings of post-holes that the magnetometer had pulled up out of the dirt like a developed photograph — circles of vanished wood, twenty-five meters, sixty-three meters, perfect enough that somebody had stood in the middle and turned and marked the turning. He saw the order in it. He always saw the order. The trouble was the order implied a payroll, and there was no payroll.

"Run me the food," Naila said. She'd put the phone down. When Naila put the phone down it meant the thing in front of her had become more interesting than money, which was rare, and which Theo had learned to treat as a kind of weather.

"Right. Food." He found a clean column. "An adult doing hard physical labor — basket-hauling, twelve hours, summer heat — that's, call it three thousand calories a day. Be kind, call it twenty-five hundred. A thousand adults. That's two and a half million calories. A day. *A day*, Naila."

"In deer."

"In whatever. Deer's a hundred and fifty pounds, maybe eighty pounds of usable meat, deer meat's around five hundred calories a pound—" He was writing as he talked, the marker squeaking, and the numbers came down the plastic in his cramped careful hand. "Forty thousand calories a deer. So you need... sixty deer. A day. To feed the build."

"Sixty deer a day."

"For ninety days. If Kidder's right about ninety days." He stopped. He looked at the bottom of the column, where the multiplication had carried him. "Fifty-four hundred deer."

Naila let out a low whistle, the appreciative kind, the kind she used on a particularly clean fraud.

The thing was, Theo loved this part. People thought the engineer-

ing was the marvel — and it was, the soil was a marvel, he'd put his hands in the cut bank and felt how they'd *mixed* it, fine loess against coarser sediment, deliberate, the way you'd cut flour into butter, so the whole mound would breathe through three thousand years of Louisiana shrink and swell and not slough off into the bayou. That was a marvel. But Theo's marvel was the logistics, because logistics was where the official story stopped being a story and started being a problem you could fail. Anybody could say *they built it*. Theo wanted to know who carried the water.

"Sixty deer a day is not a thing the woods just does," he said. "You'd strip the deer out of a parish in a week. You'd have hunting parties ranging out, what, fifty miles? And then you've got to carry the meat *back*, and it's August, and you don't have refrigeration, you've got the cooking balls—"

"The potatoes," said Cole, who had come up the path from the visitor center with the camera down at his side, walking the way he walked when he'd been still too long looking at something and his legs had remembered they existed.

"They are not potatoes," Theo said, automatically. The cooking balls — Poverty Point Objects, the placards called them, PPOs, which Theo found unforgivably bloodless — were everywhere in the dirt here. Baked balls of loess, fist-sized and smaller, grooved and biconical and cylindrical, the world's first appliance. You heated them in a fire and dropped them in a pit and they held the heat and cooked your food in the ground because you had no pots. Cole called them potatoes because the very first day, the archivist had pulled one out of a display drawer and Cole had looked at it for a long moment and said *that's a potato*, and Esi, the archivist, had said, gently, *not a potato*, and now it was a thing, the way things became things on the road.

"They're earth-oven thermal mass," Theo said. "You'd need thousands of them, going constantly. Somebody's job, all day, every day, is making and baking little clay balls so a thousand other people can eat." He capped the marker. "That's a *supply chain*. That's procurement. That's a quartermaster."

"So there's your chief," Naila said.

And here was the hole, and Theo felt it open under him the way he

always felt it, like a stair that wasn't there.

"That's the thing," he said. "There isn't."

He said it flatly, because it was flat, it was just the fact. He laid it out for them the way Esi had laid it out for him, the way the dirt laid it out for everybody who looked: you dig this place down to the bone and you find no palace. No big house at the center where the big man lived. No storehouse he controlled, no tribute pile, no rich grave with the rich man in it and his retainers killed to keep him company, no *anything* that says somebody stood at the top and told everybody else what to do and ate better for it. The houses, such as they were, were the same. The graves were the same. The diet was the same. Men carried baskets and women carried baskets and — the microstratigraphy could see this, the small loads packed in among the big ones — children carried baskets, all of it dumped and tamped and dumped, no weathered surface anywhere in the column, no rain-streaked pause, no winter, no *we'll finish it next year*. One push. All hands. And then nobody in charge of the hands.

"So who orders the deer," Naila said. She had her courtroom voice on now, soft and relentless. "Theo. Walk me through it. You've got five thousand deer to source over ninety days, you've got a clay-ball factory running flat out, you've got — what did you have for water?"

"I didn't do water yet."

"Do water."

"A gallon a day per person, minimum, in this heat, doing this work, probably double. So a thousand to two thousand gallons a day, carried—"

"Carried how?"

"In baskets. Or skins. There's no ceramic here to speak of, so—"

"So somebody coordinates the water carry, the deer carry, the ball factory, the basket weaving — because you're burning through baskets, baskets are consumables, they fall apart — the housing for a thousand people who came from a thousand different bands speaking who-knows-how-many different languages, and they all just *show up* and *agree* and *work* and there's no boss." Naila spread her hands. "Theo, I have run logistics for a forty-person shoot in a country I didn't

speak the language of, and I had a budget and a satellite phone and a guy named Marcus, and I still wanted to die. This doesn't *close*."

"No," Theo agreed, happily. "It doesn't."

That was the part the others sometimes didn't get about him, that the not-closing was the good part. A thing that closed was finished and a finished thing was boring. The wall here, the wall he kept running into, was load-bearing in the actual literal sense — twenty-two meters of load, two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of carefully un-bossed dirt, standing up against everything he knew about how big things got made. Big things got made by hierarchy. Pyramids had pharaohs. Cathedrals had bishops. The interstate had a federal government. You did not get monuments out of a crowd of equals because crowds of equals could not agree on lunch. He knew this the way he knew thermodynamics. And the mound did not care what he knew.

"You're missing it," said the voice from the cut bank, and they all turned.

Dr. Brossette had come up the slope without any of them clocking her, which Cole would later say was a thing she did, the way the place itself did, present before you noticed. She was the state-site archaeologist, and she had grown up forty minutes from where she now stood, and her grandmother's grandmother had walked this ground when it was just the old place, the place out past the bayou, and she carried all of that without ever once making you feel it as a credential. She had a clipboard she never seemed to write on and a way of looking at the whiteboard — at Theo's whole beautiful failing grid — like a teacher reading a smart kid's wrong answer.

"You're missing it," she said again, and crouched, and put two fingers in the cut bank, in the dark band where the old ground surface had been, the line everybody walked over.

"Tell me what I'm missing," Theo said. He meant it. He always meant it.

"You're counting like you'd have to bring it all in." She rubbed the soil between her fingers, a gesture so casual it took him a second to see it was an answer. "You ever stand in this floodplain in spring?" She tipped her head west, toward the bayou, the slow brown water past

the trees. “Bayou Maçon out there. The Mississippi twenty miles thataway. This is the richest fishery for five hundred miles. Drum, gar, catfish, bass — you could feed a town off the backwater without breaking a sweat. The mussel shell’s so thick in some of these middens you could pave a road with it. Fall, the nuts come down — hickory, pecan, acorn — and you can render hickory milk by the gallon, store it, it keeps. The deer come to the mast same as the people do.” She stood, and her knees popped, and she didn’t apologize for it. “You’re sourcing it like a man who lives in a desert. These folks lived in a pantry.”

Theo looked at his column. *Sixty deer a day*. It was still wrong, he could see now that it was wrong, he’d built the whole thing out of the wrong primitive — he’d assumed scarcity because that was what you assumed about the past, that it was poorer than the present, leaner, hungrier, when the truth was these people had picked the one square mile of the continent where the food more or less walked up and offered itself, twice a year, on a schedule.

“Okay,” he said slowly. “Okay. So the river feeds the build. The gathering happens when the gathering is easy — the fish run, the nuts fall, there’s a surplus, and the surplus is the *budget*.” He was nodding now, the grid rearranging itself behind his eyes. “That solves the calories. That solves the *why-then*. You come in the season of plenty, you eat the plenty, you raise the mound, you—”

He stopped.

Because it solved the food and it did not solve the *order*. The river could put five thousand deer in the freezer for free and the river still could not tell two thousand strangers where to dump the next basket. The pantry was full. Somebody still had to set the table for a thousand. He looked up at Brossette, and he asked it straight, the only way he knew to ask anything:

“But who runs it? You’ve got the food. Fine. Who tells everyone where to go?”

And Dr. Brossette looked at him, and something moved at the back of her eyes — not a withholding exactly, more like a person deciding which of two true things to hand over — and she said, “Now *that’s* a better question than your deer.”

That was all. She did not answer it. She turned the question back into his hands like a stone she'd let him hold for a while and now wanted back, and Theo understood, in the specific itching way he understood unsolved equations, that she knew something. That she could have said more. That the more was hers, and that he had not earned it, and might not, and that this was correct.

The light changed while she was deciding.

It came off the west all at once, the way it does on the flat country where there's nothing to hide the weather coming — the sun went out like a thumb over a lens, and the green of the ridges turned that bruised electric green, and out past the bayou the sky stacked itself up black and tall over the treeline, the first far mutter of thunder rolling in under the wind. The grass on Mound A laid down flat and silver. Cole's camera came up — Theo saw it come up, the old reflex, the thing the man did before the man knew he was doing it — and then come halfway down again, the photographer's hand uncertain, because some part of Cole was always asking now whether the picture was worth the taking.

"There she comes," Brossette said, mild, and bent to gather her clipboard, unbothered, a woman who had watched ten thousand of these roll through.

But Theo, looking at the mound — at twenty-two meters of basket-load that had stood since before the Trojan War, that had outlasted the wheel's arrival and Rome's whole run and the founding of every country he could name — Theo watched the first fat drops come slanting in off the bayou and hit the bare grass of the slope, and for the length of one breath the great old hill looked exactly like what it was: a pile of dirt. A pile of dirt in the rain, in a floodplain, by a river that took back everything it was lent.

It had stood three thousand years. It looked, in that light, like it might not last the hour.

"Trucks," Naila said, already moving, sweeping her phone off the tailgate. "Theo. *Theo*. The whiteboard."

He grabbed the campaign sign two-handed. The rain came across the plaza in a gray wall, swallowing the post rings, the ridges, the long arc of the work of all those nameless agreeing hands, and as he

ran for the cab with his bad arithmetic held over his head like a roof, the water already streaming the deer and the gallons and the *who-tells-everyone-where-to-go* down the plastic in long blue runs, Theo thought: *they built it to shed this. They mixed the soil so the rain would run off and the mound would stand.* They had thought about the storm. Three thousand years ago, in the season of plenty, with no king and a river full of fish, somebody had thought about exactly this rain, and built against it, and won.

He just couldn't, for the life of him, do the math on who.

Chapter 8 — Lines in the Earth

The magnetometer was an awkward thing to love, but Theo loved it. He carried the sensor pole out in front of him like a man wading a river he couldn't see, slow steps, eyes on the tablet strapped to his chest, walking lanes the field assistant had flagged with pink ribbon every metre. He'd been at it since the light was grey. Now the sun was up and the plaza steamed.

I shot him from the lip of the inner ridge because that was the only place the whole shape held in one frame: the great open bowl of the plaza, flat as a poured floor, and Theo a small bright figure dragging his invisible plumb-line back and forth across it. I'd photographed minesweepers once. Same patience, same prayer in the shoulders. The difference was nobody here would lose a leg to a wrong step. Only a missed reading.

"He's been over that same square four times," said Maddox beside me. She had her phone out, not for the view. She was reading the consortium's revised proposal again, the one that had landed at six that morning with a new line item in it she didn't like. The crease between her eyes was its own language. I'd learned to read it the way I read light. "They added a parking structure."

"Where."

"That's the thing. They won't say where. 'Sited to optimise visitor flow.'" She locked the phone. "You optimise visitor flow toward whatever you've already decided the visitors should see."

I kept the camera up. Through the long lens the plaza was a held

breath. You have to understand the official story to feel why everyone stood so carefully on it. Three thousand years ago people came here in numbers nobody can fully account for and flattened this place by hand — scraped it level, brought in fill, made a stage out of swamp. No farms feeding them. No king ordering it. Just the want, whatever the want was, and enough hands. They left the bowl. They left the six ridges curling around it like ripples frozen mid-spread. Then they walked off the edge of the record and didn't come back to finish anything, because there was nothing to finish.

"There," Theo said. Not loud. He said it the way other people exhale.

Dr. Lemoine came down off the mound trail with two coffees and gave one to Maddox without asking, which told me they'd reached some understanding I'd missed. She was Poverty Point's site archaeologist and she was from here — her people's stories ran back along these bayous further than the parish lines did — and she walked the ground like it owed her nothing and she owed it everything. She did not hurry for the magnetometer. She'd seen the magnetometer find things before.

"Show me," she said to Theo, and he turned the tablet.

I came down to shoot it over their shoulders. On the screen the plaza was no longer flat. The instrument doesn't see dirt; it sees where the dirt has been disturbed, the faint magnetic ghost of digging long filled in. Soil remembers being moved. And there, in greyscale, swimming up out of the noise, was a ring. A clean circle of dark spots, evenly spaced, the diameter of a tennis court.

"Post ring," Lemoine said. "We've got several. This is one of the bigger ones." She traced the curve with a fingernail just off the glass. "Each dark dot is a posthole. Big timbers, set upright, then pulled or rotted out. The fill that went back in reads different from the ground around it. That's all the machine's catching. Holes where wood used to stand."

"How many posts," Theo asked.

"In that one, depends how you count the gaps. We don't excavate them all. We don't have to dig a thing to know it's there now, which is the whole point of the survey." She glanced at Maddox when she

said it. *We don't have to dig. A small flag planted. We don't have to disturb a single grain to prove this place is full.*

Maddox caught it. She catches everything; it's the wiring, the always-watching, the reflex of someone who learned young that the room would turn on you if you stopped tracking it. "And the consortium's borehole survey?"

"Would put a drill rig in the plaza," Lemoine said evenly. "To assess soil for footings. For the centre."

Nobody said anything. The fish — I'd started calling the heckle in my own head *the fish*, the thing that surfaces in your skull and won't sit still — the fish said: *footings. They want to sink modern footings into a place whose miracle is that people three thousand years ago sank wooden ones, on purpose, in a pattern, for a reason they took with them.*

Lemoine walked us out into it. That was the gift of the morning, and I knew it for a gift even while it was happening, which doesn't always come to me anymore. She didn't lecture. She walked the lines.

"Stand here." She put me on a flagged point with my back to Mound A, the bird-shaped mound, the twenty-two metres of engineered earth that has not slumped in three millennia. "Now look toward the ridge gap. The break in the embankment, there."

I looked. There was a notch in the inner C-ridge, a deliberate gap, and through it the land fell away toward the bayou.

"People have measured that gap against the sky for fifty years," she said. "Sunrise alignments. Solstice. There's a paper that says the long axis lines up to the setting sun on a particular day. There's another paper that picks a different centre point for the whole site and gets a different answer." She let that sit. "Haag thought one thing. Purrington thought another. They were both careful men. They both stood about where you're standing and they did not agree on where the middle of this place is."

"That's —" Theo started, and stopped, because the literal-minded part of him had hit a wall it respected. If you can't agree where the centre is, you can't agree what the lines point at. "That's not solved."

“That’s not solved,” Lemoine agreed. No apology in it. “I’ll tell you what I’m sure of and what I’m not, and I’d thank you to keep the line between them on your camera, because people who come after you won’t.” She looked at me when she said it. I lowered the camera an inch. Old reflex, that — the war taught me to hide behind it, and good people keep asking me to come out from behind it, and Lemoine asked without asking. I kept shooting. But slower.

“Sure,” she said, and started counting on her fingers, “is that the post rings are real. Sure is they’re circular, and they’re big, and somebody set those timbers with care — even spacing, true curves. You don’t get a true circle that size by accident. Sure is that this plaza was kept flat on purpose; the soil tells us that. Sure is the whole thing is *aligned to itself*. The ridges relate to the mound. The rings relate to the plaza. There’s geometry in here, internal, consistent.” She closed those fingers. “Not sure,” and she opened the other hand, “is whether any of it points at the sky. The sun, the moon, a star. Maybe. The arguments are honest and they don’t close. I won’t tell a film crew it’s an observatory. I won’t tell you it isn’t.”

Wesh, our archivist, had drifted up while she talked, the way he does, footnote-quiet. He’d been reading in the field station all morning and he had that look of a man holding three citations behind his teeth. “Purrrington selected the site centre based on the ridge geometry,” he said, careful, offering not correcting. “Haag used a different feature. The disagreement is the diameter of —”

“About a hundred metres,” Lemoine said. “Yes. And a hundred metres is the difference between solstice and nothing.” She almost smiled. “You read the footnotes.”

“I read the footnotes,” Wesh agreed, pleased the way he gets, which is barely.

We tried the potato in the afternoon, because Maddox wanted it on film and because I think Theo would have died if we hadn’t let him.

The idea was simple and the doing of it was not, which is the whole of this place in one sentence. Set a post. Just one. Lemoine gave us a spot at the plaza margin where the survey was already done and a post hole would damage nothing, and a length of cypress, and a

shovel, and her permission, which mattered more than the shovel.

Theo dug. The gumbo clay came up in slabs that weighed like wet brick and stuck to the steel and had to be kicked off and came back the next stroke. Twenty minutes for a hole knee-deep. He set the cypress upright and we stood it true with a level, and then we tried to make it *plumb to something* — to line it, by eye, with the second flagged point thirty metres off, so that two posts would make a sight-line.

They didn't. By eye, across thirty metres of shimmering steamed-up plaza, the two posts argued. A hand's width off. Then we corrected, and overcorrected, and the fish in my head was laughing now: *thirty metres. Two posts. And you can't make a straight line you'd stake your life on. They made circles sixty metres wide with no instruments you've found, and the circles are true.*

"Now do it a hundred and fifty times," Maddox said quietly, "in a ring, evenly, by hand, and have it close back on itself perfect when you get around the bend." She wasn't taunting Theo. She was reading the proposal still, half of her, and the other half was here in the heat looking at one crooked cypress pole and the immaculate grey circle on the tablet, and I could see her doing the arithmetic that's her whole gift — not the math of stone and dirt, the math of *who pays for what*. "Somebody fed everyone who set those posts," she said. "No farm. You feed a crowd this size off the land, off the river, you're running a logistics operation a modern army would respect. And there's no boss in the ground. No big house. No granary with a lock on it." She looked up. "I keep waiting to find the skim. Every operation this size, there's a skim, somebody taking off the top. I can't find it. It's the only build I've ever read where I can't find who got rich."

That landed on me harder than the post. I've photographed a hundred sites where the question *who got rich* answered everything. Here it just hung there with no hook to hang on.

Toward evening the light went long and gold and the magnetometer data came up clean on the big screen in the field station, all the morning's lanes stitched together into one map, and that's when we saw the thing none of us had words for.

Theo stitched the rings together. There were several — Lemoine had said as much — and on the assembled map they sat across the plaza not at random. There was relation in it. One ring's centre and another's. A spacing that repeated. And running off the edge of the surveyed block, faint, the suggestion of more, the pattern continuing into ground nobody had walked the sensor over yet.

We crowded the screen. Even Lemoine leaned in, and she'd seen this map before, but I don't think she'd seen all of us seeing it at once, and that's a different thing, that changes a room.

"It carries on," Theo said. His finger hovered at the edge of the data, where the rings marched off into the unsurveyed dark. "The spacing's regular. Whatever it is, it doesn't stop at our block. It keeps going."

"It keeps going," Lemoine said.

"Into where they want the footings," Maddox said. Not a question.

Lemoine didn't answer that one. She was looking at the pattern. I had the camera up and I kept it up, but soft, the way she'd taught me without teaching, and I watched her face do the thing I'd come all this way to catch and would never use, because some frames you take only so you've truly seen them.

"I know it's a pattern," she said at last. "I know it's not an accident — you don't make rings inside rings, spaced like that, by chance, three thousand years running. There's an order in the ground. Somebody held the whole of it in their head while they set every post, and they got it right, and they didn't write down one word of why." She straightened. The gold light was in the window behind her and the plaza beyond it going to blue. "I can show you the order. I'll walk you every line we've found and I'll tell you which ones I trust. But what it's *for* —"

She stopped. The fish in my head had gone quiet. Maybe out of respect. Maybe because it knew, the way I knew, that she had the next word and the right to keep it.

"That's a longer conversation," she said. "And it's mine to start. Not the consortium's. Not yours either, though you've been decent about it." She nodded at my lowered camera. "Come back tomorrow. Early. I want to walk you out to where the lines run off the map, and I'll tell you what my grandmother's grandmother's people said about why

anybody would draw a thing that big in the earth and then leave it for us to find.”

She killed the screen. The rings went dark, but I could still see them, the way you see a window after you’ve looked away — printed pale on everything, a shape made on purpose by hands that knew exactly what they were doing and never once felt the need to say.

Chapter 9 — Erosion and Endurance

The rain had come and gone in the night the way it does here, a thunderhead that walked across the parish on legs of lightning and then lay down somewhere east, and Devon was on the flank of Mound A by seven with a soil knife and a notebook already going soft at the corners.

He had not slept much. He rarely did when a thing wouldn't sit still in his head. The thing, this time, was a number — 238,000 cubic meters — and the way it refused to behave. He had run it forty different ways on the drive down from the field house, basket by basket, thirty pounds a load, then fifty, then a generous sixty if the carrier was young and stupid and trying to impress somebody. The number kept producing other numbers, and the other numbers kept producing a shape, and the shape was always wrong. The shape was always a soft slumping pile, a thing that should have melted back into the floodplain in a single bad century.

And here was the mound. Twenty-two meters of it. Not melted.

“You’re going to wear a path,” said Marguerite Boutté, coming up the slope behind him with two paper cups of coffee and the unhurried gait of a woman who had walked this hill in every kind of weather there was. She was the state archaeologist for the site, and she had been born nineteen miles from where they stood, and she handed him one of the cups without being asked, which is a thing people do for you when they have already decided what you are.

“I keep doing the math,” Devon said.

"I know. I watched you do it at dinner. You stopped eating."

"The math says this shouldn't be here."

"And yet." She sipped. She looked at the mound the way you look at a relative.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it deserves to be told straight before anybody starts winking.

Three thousand years ago, give or take, people who grew no crops and obeyed no king came to this bend in the floodplain and moved a great deal of earth with their hands. They had no wheel. They had no draft animals — no oxen, no horses, nothing to lean a yoke on. They had no metal. What they had was baskets, and backs, and each other, and they carried the dirt up out of the borrow pits one woven load at a time, and the microstratigraphy — the thin sandwiched record of how the fill went down, layer on layer — says the women and children carried it too, says the loads came in different colors because different people dug from different places, says nobody stopped.

That last part is the part Devon could not get past. *Nobody stopped.*

Kidder's work on Mound A had gone looking for the thing you always find between building seasons — a weathered surface, a rain-washed crust, a skin of disturbance where a half-built mound sat through a wet winter and the world had its way with it. He had not found one. Not one. The 238,000 cubic meters of fill read like a single held breath. Months, the paper said. Possibly thirty to ninety days.

A hill the height of a six-story building, raised in a season, by people with no boss.

"You want the easy version," Marguerite said, "or you want to come look at where it didn't work?"

She took him down the back of Mound A and out across the wet grass toward the lower mounds, the ones the visitor map treats as footnotes, and Devon followed because she had said the words *where it didn't work* and those were the only words in the English language that could have pried him off the big mound that morning.

Asha caught up to them halfway across the plaza — the archivist, moving the way she moved, eyes already down in some footnote that lived behind her eyes. She had a transcript of a 1980s core log folded into a paperback. “The Lower Jackson Mound,” she said, to nobody, the way she narrated. “Predates the rest. Older than the ridges. Possibly older than the whole gathering.”

“It does,” Marguerite said. “We think they built toward it. Sighted on it.”

“Built toward an *older* thing,” Devon said.

“People do.” Marguerite didn’t slow. “You build your house facing your grandfather’s grave, more often than you’d think.”

They came to a place where the ground sagged. You wouldn’t have called it a mound unless someone told you. It was a tired swelling in the field, gone gentle and low, its edges argued away by three thousand wet springs.

“Here’s one that wasn’t engineered,” Marguerite said. “Or wasn’t engineered the same way. Plain fill. They built it, and then time ate it, the way time is supposed to eat things.” She crouched, and pressed two fingers into the slope, and the wet clay took the prints. “This is what the floodplain does to dirt you pile up and walk away from. It rounds it. It washes it. In a thousand years it’s a rumor. In three thousand it’s almost a field again.”

She stood and looked back the way they’d come, up the long arm of the plaza to the great mound on its bird-shaped feet.

“Now go look at *that* one again,” she said. “And tell me what’s different.”

Devon went back. Of course he went back. He took the soil knife and Marguerite’s blessing and a kit he wasn’t strictly licensed to use, and he opened a clean little window in a place she pointed him to, an old erosion scar near the base where the inside of the mound showed itself.

The official story says the soil was engineered. Devon had read the sentence a dozen times. *Soils deliberately mixed to control shrink-swell and resist erosion.* Words on a page. Now he had his nose

six inches from the thing the words were about, and the words rearranged themselves into something with weight.

It was layered. Not random fill — *recipe*. A band of grayish silty clay, then a band of sandier stuff, then the gray again, the two materials alternating like the strata in a good pie crust, and Devon understood with his hands what the paper had only let him understand with his eyes.

Clay swells when it's wet and shrinks when it's dry. A mound of pure clay would heave and crack and shoulder itself apart, a slow suicide by weather. Pure sand wouldn't hold a slope at all; it would run like sugar. But layer them — sand against clay, the wet-swelling stuff caged between the stuff that drains — and you get something that breathes without breaking. You get a wall that argues with the rain and wins.

"Roman concrete," he heard himself say, which was a thing he'd read and not believed until this second.

"Kidder says rammed earth too," Asha offered, drifting close, paperback against her chest. "Chinese hangtu. The Great Wall foundations. Same idea, opposite end of the planet." She tilted her head. "Nobody taught anybody. Both crowds figured out the same trick."

Down the slope, Kit had set up the long lens on its tripod and was not, for once, shooting. He was just standing behind it with his hands at his sides, looking at the mound through the glass without pressing anything, which was the thing the rest of them had quietly stopped mentioning. The camera he kept being asked, by everyone and no one, to lower. He had it pointed at the unweathered face Marguerite had shown them, the clean sandwich of recipe-dirt, and he wasn't shooting it. Some things you don't want to flatten into a picture. Some things you want to let stay big.

"Here's where it gets good," Marguerite said, "and where you'll want it to be a lie."

She walked them along the base. She showed them the rounded mound that hadn't held, and then the great mound that had, and the difference between them was the whole sermon nobody in the crew was allowed to preach.

The little mound: dumb fill, eaten by time.

The big mound: a recipe, holding its shape across three millennia with — and Devon checked this twice, in the literature, on his own knees — *minimal erosion*. Not no erosion. The honest word is minimal. But the floodplain that had turned a lower mound into a rumor in the same span of years had barely touched the big one. Same rain. Same river. Same three thousand springs. The difference was in the dirt.

Somebody had known the dirt.

“That’s the part I can’t make sit still,” Devon said. “It’s not that they moved it fast. Fast I can almost believe — get enough people, give them a reason, you can move mountains, people have moved mountains. It’s that they moved the *right* dirt. In the right order. While moving it fast.”

“Mm,” said Marguerite, which was a sound he was learning meant *keep going, you’re not there yet*.

“You can’t do both,” Devon said. “That’s the thing. That’s the — when you rush a job you cut the corners that take thought. Mixing the soil right, sourcing it from the right borrow pits, layering it deliberately — that’s slow work. That’s careful work. That’s a guy with a clipboard checking your basket. But the stratigraphy says nobody stopped. No pause. No off-season to think it over. They were going *fast* and they were going *right* at the same time, and there’s no clipboard, no boss, no king at the top with a plan in his head.”

He realized he’d raised his voice. He lowered it.

“So either thousands of people independently knew how to build for forever,” he said, “or somebody did, and somehow everybody listened, without anybody having to make them.”

The fish, here, would like a word.

The fish wants you to know that none of this requires aliens, lost continents, or a vanished super-race, and the fish is correct, and the fish is also, frankly, a little smug about it. *You think it’s hard for humans to build a hill?* the fish says, blowing a bubble. *Humans built the pyramids with copper saws and lunch breaks. Humans are*

extremely good at moving dirt when they're motivated and bored and showing off for the person carrying the next basket. The fish has read the consensus. The fish endorses the consensus. The achievement is extraordinary and entirely human, and the people who inflate it into magic are doing the actual builders a disservice, the fish says, because the builders were better than magic. They were *competent*, which is rarer.

And then the fish gets quiet, because the fish, too, has done Devon's math, and the fish, too, has put its nose to the sandwich of clay and sand, and the fish knows the difference between *humans can move a hill* and *humans can move the right hill, the right way, in the right order, in ninety days, with no one in charge.*

The first is easy.

The second is the hole.

The consortium man came across the plaza at noon. Reyes. He was easy to like; that was his whole instrument. He had a tablet under his arm and good shoes for the mud, which told you he'd thought about the mud, which told you everything.

"It's incredible, isn't it," he said, pulling up beside Devon, looking at the mound with what looked exactly like reverence and might even have been some. "You know what people don't grasp? The *resilience*. This thing has outlasted empires. We could build the interpretive center to last fifty years if we're lucky." He laughed, charmingly, at himself. "They built this to last forever. There's a story in that. People will pay to feel that."

"Pay to feel what," Devon said.

"Permanence." Reyes said it like a man laying down a winning card. "In an age of disposable everything. That's the brand. That's the funding case." He tapped the tablet. "Engineered to endure. We lead with the soil science. It tests *beautifully* with focus groups."

Roan had come up behind them — quiet, the way the money-reader was always quiet right before the room changed shape. Roan didn't say anything to Reyes. Roan looked at the tablet, and at the good shoes, and at the mound, and you could see the arithmetic running,

a different arithmetic than Devon's, an arithmetic of who-gets-the-gate-fee and whose-grandmother's-ground-this-is.

"Engineered to endure," Roan repeated, mild. "You'll want that trademarked before someone else gets it."

Reyes missed it entirely, or chose to. "Exactly," he said, delighted. "Exactly the thinking."

Marguerite said nothing at all, which from her was the loudest thing in the field.

That evening Devon sat on the slope of the great mound with Marguerite while the light went long and copper over the plaza and the post-ring ghosts slept under the grass where the magnetometry had found them, circles of vanished wood from twenty-five to sixty-three meters across, the bones of buildings nobody alive had ever seen standing.

"You keep saying *forever*," Marguerite said. "That word."

"It's the word that fits."

"It's the word that *sells*," she said, and let that sit between them a second, and it landed harder than Reyes had landed all day. "But you're not wrong that they built it. The recipe's real. The endurance is real. I'm not going to pretend it isn't, just because a man in good shoes wants to put it on a coffee cup."

She picked up a pinch of the slope and rubbed it between her fingers and let it go.

"So here's what I'll give you," she said, "and here's what I'll keep. I'll give you the *how*. The how is in the ground, it's published, it's yours and his and anybody's. Sand against clay. Sourced and layered. Built to take the river's worst and shrug. That's knowledge, and knowledge wants to be free, my grandmother would've said so."

"And what you'll keep?"

She looked at him, and there was no unkindness in it, only the long patience of someone who had been asked this question by smarter and worse people than him, and had outlasted all of them the way the mound outlasted the rain.

"You want to know who knew," she said. "You've got the whole afternoon stuck on it. *Who knew how to build for forever*. Like there's a name. Like there's an engineer. A guy with a plan who told everybody where to put the clay." She shook her head slow. "That's your wiring talking. You see a system, you go looking for the person who designed it. And there's no design document, baby. There's no king. There's no architect. There's no clipboard."

"Then how—"

"That's the thing I keep." She stood, and brushed her hands, and the sun went behind the tree line and the mound went from copper to blue. "Not because I'm hiding it. Because I don't have it either. Nobody does. We know *how* they built for forever. We don't know who knew it first, or how the knowing got into thousands of hands all at once, or why those hands all agreed to use it, in one season, for no king, and then put their baskets down and walked home and never did it again."

She started down the slope. Then she stopped, and turned, and the question she handed back to him was not an answer. It was the door.

"You're asking the wrong shape of question," she said. "You keep asking *who*. Ask it the other way. If nobody was in charge — if nobody made them — then it wasn't one person who knew how to build for forever."

She let the dark finish the sentence for her.

"It was all of them. And nobody can tell me how a crowd that big, with no one at the top, knows the same hard thing at the same time — unless something taught them. So. You tell me, since you do the math." She was already walking. "What teaches a thousand people, all at once, to build for forever?"

The mound held its shape in the dark behind her, as it had held it through three thousand storms, and did not answer, and that — Devon was beginning to understand — was the most honest thing in the parish.

Chapter 10 — Trade and Distance

The drawer stuck on its runners, swelled with August, and when Demetria worked it loose it came with the small thunder of stone on metal — a tray of grey points and blades and broken bits, each in its own cell of foam, each with a number in pencil so faint it had to be read at an angle to the light.

“Don’t lift them out,” she said. “Read them where they lie.”

Sol — the archivist, who lived for exactly this kind of permission — leaned over the tray with both hands behind his back like a man at a museum case, which, he supposed, was what this was. The field station’s collections room smelled of the river that wasn’t far off and of the particular mustiness of card catalogs that have outlived the people who filled them. A box fan turned its head from side to side and refused to commit.

“These two,” Sol said. “Grey, but — wrong grey. Cooler.”

“Burlington chert.” Demetria didn’t look up from the logbook she was squaring against the table edge. “Mississippi Valley. Up by where Missouri and Illinois shake hands.”

“And these are darker.”

“Dover. Tennessee.” She turned a page. “That blue-grey by your thumb is Fort Payne. Also Tennessee, but a different shelf of it.” A pause, the kind she used like punctuation. “And the orange one your engineer’s about to touch with his nose is Edwards Plateau. Central Texas.”

Eli — the engineer — had in fact lowered his face to within a few inches of the orange blade and now froze, hands clasped, nose re-treating. “I wasn’t going to,” he said.

“Everybody was going to.”

Sol felt the shape of it land before he had the words. He pulled the parish map from the wall in his head — the river, the bluff, the gumbo flat — and then he started pulling threads off it, north and east and west, the way you pull lengths off a spool. Missouri. Tennessee. Texas. He had read the inventories on the flight in; reading a number on a page was one thing. Reading the stone in the drawer, with the river audible through the wall, was another.

“How far,” he said. It wasn’t really a question.

“Burlington’s eight hundred kilometres if a crow flies it, and the crow doesn’t flat-pack.” Demetria finally looked up. She had a way of meeting your eye that made you check your own posture. “The crow also doesn’t carry forty pounds of chert. Some of these raw materials come from a thousand kilometres out. Stone, not finished tools. They brought in the rock and made the blades here, on the ridges, and the debris tells us so — the flakes, the cores. You don’t haul a thousand kilometres of debris. You haul the good stuff.”

Veronique — the lens — had been quiet by the window, which was where she went when a room was telling on itself. Now she lifted the camera, not to her eye, just to her chest, the gesture of a woman deciding. “May I.”

“The drawer, yes. Not the labels.”

The shutter, when it came, was almost apologetic.

Here is the official story, and it is a good one, and it ought to be told with the lights up.

Three thousand years before the present, on a low rise above Bayou Macon, people who farmed nothing and crowned no one ran a continent’s worth of trade through their front door. Stone came from the upper Mississippi, from the Ouachitas, from the Tennessee hills, from the far Texas plateau. Soapstone vessels came up from Georgia and Alabama. Galena — lead ore, for its bright weight and its shine —

came from the river country to the north. And copper came, the soft red metal hammered cold into beads and ornaments, copper that for a long time everyone said came from the Great Lakes, a thousand miles and a continent's spine away.

No carts. No pack animals. No road in the sense you'd put a milepost on. A man, a woman, a basket, a canoe, a river, a season. Down the Mississippi, you could ride the current most of the way. Coming back up, you paid for every mile with your shoulders.

The skeptic's correction is healthy here, and you should hear it from her own mouth, because the skeptic is right: nobody needs a king to want a pretty blade. Trade doesn't require an empire; it requires desire and a route. People have always passed things hand to hand and hand to hand again, each exchange a small local fairness, the object travelling further than any single trader ever did. You don't need to imagine a man from Texas walking to Louisiana with a sack of rock. You need to imagine a hundred handshakes, each one short, the stone moving while the people mostly stay home.

That's the elegant answer, and it is probably most of the truth, and it deserves its applause.

Sol gave it the applause. Then he stood in the collections room with eight hundred kilometres of Burlington chert in a foam cell and felt the elegant answer leave a little water on the floor.

"Show me the down-tools," Eli said, which was not English but was the way he asked the question that mattered. *Show me where the easy story has to do the actual work.*

So they took it outside, because Eli could not think with his hands empty, and the field station had a sandbox of sorts — a tarp, river sand, a few of the replica baskets the education program used for school groups. He filled a basket to what Demetria allowed was a fair load. Thirty-five pounds. He hefted it.

"Hand to hand," he said. "Fine. So the stone moves in short hops. But the short hops still add up to a thousand kilometres of total carrying, just spread across people. Somebody hauled every kilometre. The kilometres don't get cheaper because you split them up. They get *survivable*."

“That’s the whole trick of it,” Demetria said. She had come out to watch, arms folded, and watching was a thing she did with the full weight of her attention, which was how you knew she was the one who’d out-read you on whatever came next. “Survivable isn’t free. You move galena north to south. The Mississippi helps you. Now bring the copper the other way — upstream, or overland through people who may or may not feel like trading today. The river’s not your friend going up. The river’s the bill.”

Eli set the basket down and looked at the tarp like it had insulted him. “I keep trying to make the network *cheap*,” he said. “It won’t go cheap. It’ll go *possible*. Those aren’t the same number.”

“No,” said Demetria. “They are not.”

The fish, if it had been there, would have said: *funny how ‘possible’ keeps showing up exactly where you wanted ‘easy.’* The fish was not there. But Sol heard it anyway, which was its own kind of haunting.

Inside, Sol had found the copper.

A single bead, in its own cell, dark with the patina of three millennia, no bigger than a knuckle. He read its number, found the number in the logbook, found in the logbook a citation in someone’s tidy hand, and felt the floor tilt very gently the way it does when a fact you were sure of turns out to have grown a footnote while you weren’t looking.

“This is sourced,” he said. “Somebody ran the chemistry.”

“Somebody ran the chemistry on a lot of it.” Demetria came to stand beside him, and for the first time her voice carried something other than instruction — a kind of dry pleasure, the pleasure of a person watching an outsider arrive at the place where the easy version breaks. “For years the story was Great Lakes copper. It’s a good story. It’s a long line on the map, Lake Superior to Louisiana, and it makes the network look as big as it actually is.”

“And?”

“And then people did the isotopes and the trace elements, on this material and material like it, and some of what everyone called Great Lakes copper turned out to be southern Appalachian. Closer. Different source. The line on the map didn’t vanish — it moved.” She let

that settle. “The network’s still continental. It’s still astonishing. But the details — *which* copper, from *where*, by *which* hands — those are argued over in print, right now, by people who are not done arguing. You want to be careful which line you draw bold.”

Sol looked at the bead. Eight hundred kilometres of chert he could trust. The copper had taught him caution in a single sentence.

“So the distance is real,” he said slowly. “But the *route* is debated. The achievement’s not in question. The map is.”

“The map is *drafts*,” Demetria said. “It’s always drafts. People write me letters wanting a single clean diagram with arrows. I tell them: I can give you the stone, and I can give you the chemistry, and I can give you the argument. I can’t give you the arrows. The arrows are where the honest people disagree.”

She closed the drawer. It stuck, and she let it stick.

Veronique had drifted to the far wall, where someone had pinned a continental map with pins and thread — the education version, the one with the bold arrows, the one Demetria had just disowned. She photographed it anyway. Then she stepped back and photographed the empty middle of the room, the box fan, Demetria’s hands flat on the closed drawer.

“You don’t trust the arrows either,” Sol said to her, quietly, because she’d taught him to read a thing by what she didn’t shoot.

“I trust the stone,” Veronique said. “I trust her hands on the drawer.” She lowered the camera. The light caught the old burn-scar of the war in her, the thing the series kept asking her to put down. “Arrows are the part somebody added to make it a story. The drawer’s the part that’s true.” A beat. “Doesn’t mean the story’s a lie. Means somebody wanted it to land harder than it earns.”

Eli, coming back in with sand on his shins, said the thing none of them had said. “Wait. If the network’s that big — Texas, Tennessee, Mississippi Valley, Appalachia, Georgia soapstone — then the gathering and the trade are the *same question*.”

The room went still in the way a room goes still when the literal-minded one says the load-bearing thing.

“Say it again,” Sol said.

“To raise the mound you need thousands of people in one season,” Eli said, talking with his hands now, plotting it in the air. “To run a continental trade network you need contact across the whole eastern half of the country. What if those aren’t two facts. What if the people who came to build also came to *trade* — or came to trade and *then* built — and the gathering is the thing that makes both possible. You don’t need a king to move the stone *or* the dirt. You need a reason for everyone to be in one place at one time. The reason is the same reason.”

Demetria looked at him for a long moment. It was not the look of correction. It was the look of someone deciding how much of the floor to give away, and to whom.

“That,” she said, “is a question I’m allowed to enjoy and not answer.” She tapped the closed drawer once. “We have the stone. We have the distances. We have the chemistry, with its fights. What we do not have — what I do not have, what Kidder does not have, what nobody pinning arrows to my wall has — is the invitation. We don’t have the thing that said *come*. We have everybody arriving. We don’t have the word that called them.”

“And the going,” Sol said. “You don’t have the word that ended it either.”

“No,” said Demetria. “I don’t have that one at all.”

She did not reach past it. That was the thing Sol kept returning to, later — how she stood exactly at the edge of what the ground would tell her and did not lean over. The stone was hers to read and she read it cold. The *why* she held in an open hand, and the open hand was a decision, not an absence.

The turn came, as it always did, by phone.

Sol was the money-reader, the fixer, the one whose wiring had been built in rooms where you learned to hear the grift under the courtesy or you didn’t eat. So when his phone lit with the link someone in the parish had forwarded — the consortium’s new slide deck, leaked the way these things leak, eager — he read it the way Demetria read

chert. By the cool grey of the wrong word.

The slide was beautiful. A continental map, the very one Demetria had just disowned, arrows and all, rendered in gold. Across the top, in a font that cost money:

POVERTY POINT: AMERICA'S FIRST GLOBAL HUB.

And below, in the body, the phrases that made Sol's stomach do the slow drop it did when a true thing was about to be sold:

A 3,000-year-old network spanning a continent. A heritage of connection. In partnership with regional and international stakeholders, the Heritage Development Consortium will unlock Poverty Point's global story — and its global value.

He read it twice. He handed the phone to Demetria without a word, because it was hers before it was his.

She read it once. Her face didn't change, which was worse than if it had.

"They took the arrows," she said.

"They took the arrows," Sol agreed. "The ones you won't draw. They drew them in gold and put a fence around them."

"Global," Demetria said, and set the word down on the table like a chert blade with a label she didn't trust. "The network's continental. It's real. It's argued over by honest people. And they've turned the argument into a *brochure*." She slid the phone back. "You know the cruelest part?"

Through the wall, the river kept paying its bill, the way it had for three thousand years, the way it would whether or not anyone bought the slide.

"It's not even a lie," she said. "It's worse. It's the true thing, with the open question sanded off and a price tag glued where the question used to be."

Outside, the box fan turned its head, considered the room, and declined to commit.

Chapter 11 — Negotiations

The diner in Epps had a laminated map of the parish under the glass on every table, and somebody had spilled coffee on West Carroll a long time ago, so the whole northeast corner of the county wore a brown stain shaped vaguely like a question mark. I kept finding my thumb on it.

Caldwell — that was the consortium’s man, Heritage Development, the name embroidered on his polo in a green so soft it was practically an apology — had taken the corner booth and ordered for the table before any of us sat down. Sweet tea, fried catfish, hush puppies. “You have to,” he said, smiling, when I raised an eyebrow at the plates already coming. “It’s the best in the parish. I’d be doing you a disservice.”

He wasn’t wrong about the catfish. That was the thing about Caldwell I clocked in the first ninety seconds, the thing I’d been hired by nobody to clock but couldn’t stop clocking anyway: he was never wrong about the small stuff. The small stuff was where you built trust. He knew the waitress’s kids’ names. He knew the high school had lost three teachers to budget last year. He knew, to the dollar, what the state’s interpretive budget for Poverty Point had been cut to, and he said the number out loud with the specific grief of a man who’d memorized it because it made his pitch.

I do this for a living, more or less. Not the fixing — the reading. You spend enough years being the kid who couldn’t stop watching the room because the room kept changing the rules on you, and you stop being able to turn it off. Everybody at this table was performing. The trick was knowing what each of them was performing *for*.

Caldwell was performing *plausibility*. That was his whole product.

“Here’s the shape of it,” he said, and laid a folder on the coffee-stained map, square to the table edge, the way people do when they want you to feel that the thing inside is already settled. “Forty million over six years. A new visitor center — and I mean a real one, climate control, a theater, a café. Trained interpretive staff. Marketing reach we can actually measure. Right now this place gets, what.” He looked at Dr. Ardoin. “Forty thousand visitors a year?”

“About that,” she said.

“We can get you two hundred thousand.”

The young engineer, who’d been silent and folding his straw wrapper into smaller and smaller squares, said, “Two hundred thousand people on those ridges.”

“On managed paths,” Caldwell said, smooth. “Boardwalk. You protect the resource *by* channeling the traffic. That’s preservation, not despite the visitors — *because* of them.”

It was a good line. I watched Dr. Ardoin not react to it, which is its own kind of reaction.

She was the state-site archaeologist, and she’d grown up forty minutes from here, and she had the stillness of somebody who had heard a great many people explain her own place to her and had decided, long ago, to let them finish. Her family had been in this parish since before it was a parish. When she walked the ridges she didn’t walk them like a guide; she walked them like a kitchen, the way you move through a room you don’t have to look at to cross.

The Lens hadn’t lifted the camera. That was something. She had it on the table, lens cap on, and she was watching Caldwell’s hands the way I was, except she was watching them for the frame and I was watching them for the tell. His hands were clean. Genuinely. That’s what I want you to understand about him, because it’s what made him dangerous: there was no villain in those clean hands. He believed every word.

“Let me say the part nobody likes to say,” Caldwell said, leaning in. “This is one of the great wonders of the ancient Americas, and almost nobody on earth knows it exists. You’ve got six C-shaped ridges out there, a kilometer and a quarter across the outer one. You’ve got

Mound A — twenty-two meters, two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of earth, and the kicker, the *kicker*—” he pointed at the engineer like he’d already guessed which of us would care most, and he’d guessed right — “is that they think it went up in *months*. Maybe ninety days. Built by people with no kings, no farms, no writing. No metal. No wheel. No animals to pull a thing. Hands and baskets. That’s it.”

“That’s it,” the engineer agreed, very quietly, and I knew that tone. That was the tone of a man who’d tried to move dirt last week and had feelings about it.

We had, in fact, tried. Out behind the field station, with a marked plot and good shovels and a borrowed split-oak basket the curator swore was the right size, and a stopwatch. We moved earth from a borrow pit to a mound footprint, thirty-to-fifty-pound loads, the way the microstratigraphy says they did it — men, women, and the children too, you can read the kids in the soil, the small uneven dumps. We did it for four hours in real Louisiana June, and the gumbo clay grabbed the shovel like it had opinions, and the basket strap cut a stripe across your shoulder that you felt for two days, and at the end of four hours the engineer ran the numbers and his face did a thing.

Because the numbers don’t go the easy way. That’s the potato. Everyone wants the math to be friendly — big crowd, lots of hands, of course you can raise a hill. But you start multiplying. Two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic meters. A loaded basket is maybe an eighth of a cubic meter, generous. You’re walking it up a growing slope in heat that makes the air shimmer over the cane. You need the dirt *dug*, and you need it *carried*, and you need the carriers *fed*, and the feeding of a few thousand foragers who grow nothing is its own mountain, an invisible one, built out of fish and nuts and whatever the river gave that season. We did the back-of-the-napkin and the napkin said: you’d need thousands of people, all of them, every daylight hour, for the whole of those ninety days, and not one of them deciding on day forty that they’d rather be fishing.

“And nobody made them,” the archivist said. She’d been reading the menu like it was a footnote. “That’s the part the brochure won’t fit. No chief. The leadership’s read as situational — somebody organizes the build and then it dissolves. There’s no palace in the ground. There’s no throne. There’s no big house where the big man lived.” She set

the menu down. “There’s a kingdom’s worth of *work* and no king to point at.”

Caldwell loved this. You could see him loving it. “Right! And that’s the *story*. That’s what sells. ‘They built it together, no bosses, no kings—’” he spread his hands, framing an invisible banner — “‘the first democracy in the Americas.’ People eat that up.”

“Did it,” I said.

“Did it what?”

“Did it dissolve, or did they just walk away.” I tapped the coffee stain. “Microstratigraphy says no weathering surfaces between the fill layers. No rain-wash, no pause. They didn’t build it over generations and let the slopes settle and come back. They went *bang*, all at once, no breaks, and then—” I shrugged. “Three thousand years of nobody on the hill, and it’s barely eroded, because they mixed the soils on purpose so it’d hold. They engineered it to *last*. And then they didn’t stay to use it.”

Dr. Ardoin looked at me for the first time like I’d said something she’d let me have.

“Kidder compares it to Roman concrete,” she said. “Chinese rammed earth. Deliberate. They controlled the shrink-swell so it wouldn’t crack itself apart. Three thousand years and Mound A’s still got its shape.” A beat. “We know *how*. Down to the basket. We can read the kids’ loads in the dirt.”

“And what it’s for?” Caldwell asked, and he asked it lightly, the way you ask a question you’ve already decided is rhetorical, the way you ask it because you intend to be the one to answer it on the brochure.

Dr. Ardoin sipped her tea.

“That’s a long conversation,” she said.

That was all. *That’s a long conversation*. And it landed in the booth like a flat stone going into still water, no splash, just the going-under and the rings.

Caldwell took it for deflection. I took it for a door she’d decided not to open in front of him. There’s a difference, and you learn it

by watching who *doesn't* talk and clocking what their hands do while they don't. Her hands stayed around the tea glass. Steady.

He pivoted to the folder. This was the part I'd been waiting for, because in my experience the strings always come about eleven minutes after the number.

"The center would carry the interpretation," Caldwell said. "Unified narrative. You've got — and I say this with respect, Doctor — you've got *eleven* different stories out there right now. The solstice people, the trade-route people, the 'we don't know' people. From a *visitor* standpoint that's chaos. You give somebody a clean line they can take home. 'A gathering. A wonder. Built together.' We'd want approval on the materials, obviously, brand consistency—"

"Approval," the archivist repeated, gently, to her water glass.

"Editorial alignment," Caldwell said. "And on the access side — there'd be premium experiences. Sunrise tours of Mound A. We'd cap general admission on event days. That's *conservation*. And a profit share back to the parish, real money, not somebody's grant cycle that gets killed in committee." He said *killed in committee* with a small flinch, like a man recalling a funeral.

I added it up while he talked, the way I always add it up. They'd fund the place and own the sentence. They'd protect the ridges by deciding who got to stand on them. They'd give the parish a cut of a story about people who took no cut from each other.

And here's the thing I won't pretend: it wasn't a bad deal. That's what kept getting me. The center would be real. The boardwalk would save the ridges from a thousand careless feet. Forty thousand visitors a year is a slow death by indifference. Caldwell wasn't selling poison. He was selling a *frame*, glass and climate-controlled, and the price of the frame was the picture.

"The solstice alignment," the engineer said abruptly. "You'd put that in the theater?"

"Centerpiece," Caldwell said. "People love an astronomy hook."

"It's contested," the engineer said. "Haag and Purrington don't even agree where the center of the site *is*. You move the center, you move every sightline. There's no consensus the aisles point at anything."

He frowned at his shredded straw wrapper. “If you put it on a screen with no asterisk, you’ve decided a thing the field hasn’t.”

Dr. Ardoin’s mouth moved, the smallest amount. Not a smile. The cousin of one.

“That,” she said to the engineer, “is exactly the problem with a clean line.”

And there it was — the gap between them, the consortium and the keeper, laid out plain over the catfish. Caldwell needed a sentence that would fit on a wall. Dr. Ardoin had spent her life inside the part that won’t fit on a wall: the *we don’t know*, held not as a failure but as a thing you protect, the way you’d protect a spring. He thought the mystery was a marketing problem. She knew it was the asset.

She wasn’t going to say that to him. She was going to let him keep believing he was being generous.

“I’ll take this to the council,” she said, touching the folder but not taking it. “And to the elders. It’s not mine to sign. It’s not the state’s, either, not really.” A look around the booth, including us, excluding nobody, which is its own kind of authority. “People here have to live with whatever the place becomes. So they decide.”

“Of course,” Caldwell said. “Of course. That’s exactly the partnership we—”

“It’ll divide them,” she said.

She said it not to him. She said it to the window, where you could see, past the gas station, the low green line of the floodplain going on toward the river.

“Some of them’ve watched this parish lose everything that ever brought a paycheck,” she said. “School, the mill, the young people. Forty million is forty million. There’s families’d take that money and not blink, and I won’t say they’re wrong to want it. And there’s others—” she paused, and I watched her choose the word, and the word she chose was small — “others remember when the highway came through, and what it cost, and what the brochure said it’d give us that it never gave.”

The booth was quiet. Even Caldwell, who I’d have bet money was incapable of three consecutive silent seconds, let it sit.

The Lens lifted her camera. Slow. She didn't shoot Caldwell, and she didn't shoot the folder. She shot Dr. Ardoin's hands around the sweating glass, and through the window behind her the green line of the bottomland, and I knew without seeing the frame that it would say more than anything the four of us had said all afternoon — a woman holding still while other people decided how loud to make her home.

"Take your time, Doctor," Caldwell said, finally, and he meant it warmly, and that was the worst part. "There's no rush. The offer holds."

But there was a rush, and we all knew it. Offers like that hold exactly as long as the man who made them needs them to.

She walked out ahead of us into the heat. The cicadas were going like a downed power line. She stopped in the gravel lot and looked east, where you couldn't see the ridges from here but you could *feel* them, the way you feel a held breath in a room.

"You want to know what it's for," she said. Not a question. She'd clocked me clocking, the whole lunch. She'd out-read me reading her, and let me think I was the one with the eyes. "Everybody who comes wants that. The aliens people. The democracy people. Now the forty-million people."

"I want to know," I said, "what happens to *you* if they get the sentence."

She looked at me a moment longer than was comfortable, which I've found is the look people give you when you've surprised them by aiming at the right thing.

"Come back Thursday," she said. "Council meets at the church. You can sit at the back."

She got in her truck. The door had a dent in it the exact shape of nothing in particular, just years.

Behind me, through the diner glass, Caldwell was paying the check and learning the busboy's name.

Chapter 12 — The Impossible Season

The whiteboard had come from the state office, wheeled out on protesting casters into the field station's back room, and Tobias had been waiting for it the way other people wait for a meal. He wiped it down twice though it was already clean. He uncapped a marker, sniffed it, capped it. He had been carrying the timeline in his head since the levee, and his head, when it carried a thing too long, started to ache with the wanting to put it down.

“Okay,” he said. “Okay. So.”

“He’s been like this since the diner,” said Mara, the fixer, from the doorway, arms folded, watching him the way she watched everyone — for the tell, the seam. She found his soothing rather than alarming. His tells were honest. “Let him build it.”

Dr. Lemoine sat in a folding chair near the window with a cup of coffee gone cold an hour ago. She was the reason they were all here and not at a hotel bar — the state-site archaeologist, born forty miles south, with a grandmother who had picked cotton within sight of these ridges and a doctorate that said in dry institutional language what the grandmother had said plainer: *this is ours, and you are guests*. She had agreed to watch Tobias do his thing. Agreeing to watch was not the same as agreeing.

Tobias wrote a number at the top of the board. **238,000.**

“Cubic meters,” he said. “That’s Mound A. Just the bird mound. Not the ridges, not the smaller mounds, just the one. Twenty-two meters tall.” He drew a lopsided shape that was meant to be a bird and was,

in fact, a potato with intentions. Nobody corrected him. “Kidder’s number. WashU. It’s the published figure.”

“It’s the published figure,” Lemoine agreed. Her voice gave nothing.

“So.” He drew a line. Under it: **basket = 30 to 50 lb.** Under that: **call it 40.** “A basket load. That’s what they carried. No wheel — no draft animals — no shovels even, not metal ones. You scoop the dirt, you fill the basket, you carry it on your back or your hip or your head, you dump it, you walk back. That’s the whole machine. That’s the entire technology.”

“That’s the entire technology,” said the archivist, Wen, from the corner where she had three books open and a fourth balanced on her knee. “Kidder’s wording is that it was moved ‘basket by basket.’ The microstratigraphy shows the loads. You can see them. Individual dumps. Men, women, children — the load sizes vary, the smaller ones are kids.”

“Children,” Lemoine said, and now there was something in it, a small weight. “People forget the children. They picture a labor gang. It was families.”

Tobias paused, marker hovering. He liked it when a fact had a person inside it. He didn’t always know what to *do* with the person, but he liked knowing they were there. He wrote **kids too** in the corner, smaller, and felt better.

“So here’s the math,” he said, and the room settled, because this was the part he was good at and everyone knew it. The numbers steadied him the way water steadies a level. “238,000 cubic meters. Fill weighs — call it loess and clay, mixed, wet, because it’s Louisiana and it’s always wet — call it 1,600 kilos a cubic meter. That’s two-fifty, two-sixty million kilos of dirt. Round it. Quarter of a billion kilos. Moved by hand.”

The LENS — Cole, who had not lifted his camera in twenty minutes, which for him was a long fast — let out a low sound that wasn’t quite a laugh.

“Forty pounds a basket is eighteen kilos,” Tobias went on. “So you need —” he wrote, the marker squeaking — “fourteen million basket loads. Give or take. To make the one mound.”

“Fourteen million,” Mara repeated. She was doing her own math, the kind that didn’t go on boards. Fourteen million of anything was a logistics problem, and logistics problems were where the money lived, where the grift lived, where she lived. “And the timeline.”

This was the part Tobias had been holding longest, and his hand actually trembled a little setting it down.

“Ninety days,” he said. “That’s the outside. Kidder says months — thirty to ninety days for the main build of Mound A. Because of the dirt.” He turned to Lemoine, almost pleading, wanting her to confirm the beautiful terrible thing. “Because there’s no weathering between the layers. Right? That’s the whole point. If you stop building — if you walk away for a wet season, even for a few weeks of Louisiana rain — the top of your dirt pile gets a *skin*. It rains, it washes, it dries, little gullies, a crust, leaves blow in and rot. You’d see it in the stratigraphy. A rain-wash surface. A pause-line.”

“You’d see it,” Lemoine said.

“And it’s not there.” He said it like a confession. “Twenty-two meters of fill and there’s no pause-line. None. The dirt went up wet-on-wet, fast, continuous. You can’t *fake* not-raining in northeast Louisiana for the time it takes to do this slow. So it wasn’t slow. The ground itself is the clock, and the clock says one push. One season. They started, and they did not stop, and then the mountain was there.”

Silence in the back room. Outside, thunder shouldered along the horizon, theatrical, on cue, and Cole’s hand twitched toward the camera and didn’t go.

Wen turned a page. “Kidder compares the soil engineering to Roman concrete,” she said quietly. “Chinese rammed earth. They mixed the fills on purpose — different soils, to control shrink and swell. So it wouldn’t crack itself apart when it dried, wouldn’t slump in the wet. Three thousand years and it’s barely eroded. That’s not a pile. That’s a designed material.”

“They knew their dirt,” Lemoine said.

Here is where the chapter ought to tell you it can’t be done, and walk away satisfied. The crew had assumed the same. So they had tried.

Tobias flipped the whiteboard to its second face, where, two days before, he had recorded the experiment they were all still sore from. They had marked off a small bank by the cane on the back forty, gotten permission, gotten baskets — real woven ones, sized right, weighed — and the four of them plus two grad students and Jakobus had spent a morning being a society without kings.

“We moved,” Tobias read off the board, in the flat voice he used for results he didn’t like, “in three and a half hours, with healthy backs and bottled water and a wheelbarrow we agreed not to use — about nine cubic meters. Six people.”

“Felt like more,” Cole said.

“Felt like a great deal more,” said Mara, who had blisters under her rings.

“Nine cubic meters,” Tobias said. “Six people. Three and a half hours. Scale it.” He didn’t even write it; he’d done it in his head at two in the morning and not slept after. “To do 238,000 cubic meters at our rate, six people work for — call it ten thousand days. Twenty-seven years. So you don’t use six people.”

“You use the crowd,” Mara said. The official story’s whole load-bearing wall. *You don’t need a king. You need a big-enough crowd and a reason.*

“You use thousands,” Tobias agreed. “Say two thousand workers, swapping out, eight hours a day, ninety days. Now the per-person number is — sane. It’s hard but it’s sane. A few hundred basket-loads a day each. People have done harder for a wage.” He set the marker down. His relief was visible, a release in the shoulders. The math *closed*. It actually closed. The skeptics were right: no magic needed. Just bodies.

And then, because he was the kind of mind that could not leave a closed door without checking it was really a door, he picked the marker back up.

“Except,” he said.

Lemoine’s eyes came up from her cold coffee.

“Two thousand people,” Tobias said slowly, “in one place, in the Louisiana summer, for ninety days. With no farms.” He looked at

Wen. "There's no agriculture. Right? Tell me I have that right."

"No agriculture," Wen said. "No maize, no field crops, no granaries. Hunter-fisher-gatherers. That's not contested. That's the load-bearing strangeness of the whole site — it's monumental and it's *forager*. The two things aren't supposed to go together. Monuments are supposed to wait for farms and kings."

"So nobody's storing grain to feed the build," Tobias said. He was speaking faster now, the pattern lighting up across his vision the way it did, the wrongness of it, the gap where a gear should mesh and didn't. "You can't bank calories without farms. So you're feeding two thousand people *out of the swamp*, in real time, for ninety days, while they're too busy hauling dirt to hunt and fish full time. That's — that's not a building problem anymore. That's a *supply* problem. That's the part the dirt-math hides. Moving the earth is the easy part once you have the crowd. Getting the crowd *there*. Holding them. Feeding them. Out of nothing but what the land gives, and the land doesn't give two thousand people's dinner for a season, not without — without—"

He ran out of words and stood there with his hand against the board.

"Without somebody making them," Mara finished, soft, and her face had the look it got when she found the seam in someone's pitch — not triumph, something colder, more careful. "That's the move every consortium makes, by the way. When you see a big coordinated thing, you assume a boss. You assume extraction, a man at the top taking his cut of the labor. Because that's the only way we know how to get two thousand people to do something hard for ninety days." She nodded at the board, at the absent king. "It's how the Heritage people read this place, too. They look at Mound A and they see a CEO. They see a project they could have managed. They want to find the boardroom."

"And there isn't one," Lemoine said.

"There isn't one," Mara agreed.

They had laid it all on the board now. The quarter-billion kilos. The fourteen million baskets. The pause-line that wasn't there. The dirt that outlasted Rome. The crowd the math demanded. The food

the land couldn't bank. And nowhere — nowhere in the post rings the magnetometer had found ringing the plaza, sixty-three meters across, nowhere in the cooking-ball middens, nowhere in three thousand years of held-together engineered soil — a palace. A throne. A storehouse. A scribe's mark. A name.

Tobias turned from the board to Lemoine, and his face was open in the way that made strangers underestimate him and friends protect him.

"So the data says yes," he said. "It's real. Ninety days. The ground proves it can't have been slow, and the math proves a crowd that size can do it, and the soil proves they knew exactly what they were doing. I came here thinking I'd find the hole in the *can*. And there isn't one. They could. They did. I believe it now, completely." He swallowed. "I just don't understand the *why*. Two thousand people walk in from — everywhere, the stone's coming from a thousand kilometers, this is a continental thing — they walk in, they raise a mountain in a summer without a king to make them or a god's-honest harvest to feed them, and then —"

"And then they walk away," Lemoine said.

"And then they walk away," Tobias echoed. "No one inherits it. No dynasty builds on it. It just — it gets *finished*, and then everyone goes home, wherever home was, and it sits there for three thousand years holding its shape in the rain because they engineered it to, holding a shape nobody's living in." He spread his hands. "I can tell you how. I can tell you how to the cubic meter. I cannot tell you the *reason*, and the reason is the only thing that makes any of the rest of it move."

He had laid the whole engine on the table, every part labeled, every measurement cited, and the engine had no ignition.

Lemoine set her cold coffee down on the windowsill. She stood, and she walked to the board, and she looked at it the way you'd look at a child's drawing of your own house — fond, and aware of everything it left out. She picked up the eraser. She did not use it. She held it a moment, then set it back in the tray.

"You did good work," she said, and she meant it; it wasn't a dismissal. "Better than the consortium's people, who never once asked about

the rain-wash. They went straight to the visitor's center floor plan." A dry beat. "Numbers don't scare you. That's rare. Most folks who come through here, the numbers are the thing they want to be scared of. They *want* the impossible. It feels better than the truth, which is harder."

"Which is what?" Mara asked.

Lemoine looked out the window, where the thunder had moved on without spending and the light was going long and gold across the outermost ridge, the one a kilometer and a quarter from edge to edge, soft as a sleeping animal under the grass.

"That they could," she said. "That ordinary people, with baskets and their own backs and their children working beside them, decided to, and did, and the deciding is the part I can't hand you off a white-board." She turned. Her eyes went over each of them, and rested longest, oddly, on Cole, on the lowered camera. "We know *how* they built it. To the basket. The how is on the board, and you got most of it right." A pause she let sit. "What called them here, and why they stopped — that's not in the dirt. The dirt is honest about how. The dirt has nothing to say about why."

Tobias looked at the board. At the closed math. At the open thing the closed math sat inside, like a perfect engine bolted to no road.

"So I had it backwards," he said slowly. "I thought the ninety days was the impossible part."

"The ninety days is the easy part," Lemoine said. "The ninety days is just arithmetic and willing arms." She picked her coffee back up, found it cold, made a face, kept it anyway. "The impossible part is what was worth ninety days to two thousand people who didn't have to come, weren't made to come, and never came again."

Outside, the gold deepened and the cane went to shadow. Cole's hand found the camera at last and did not lift it. Nobody told him to.

Chapter 13 — No Kings, No Heirs

The archivist had spread the photocopies across the field-station table the way some people lay out tarot, which is to say carefully, and with a private system nobody else was invited into. Site reports. A dissertation chapter. A printout of the UNESCO listing with three sentences highlighted in a yellow gone pale from a marker that had ridden too long in a hot bag. The window unit rattled. Outside, the cane along the levee road bent all one direction under a wind that smelled like rain four counties off.

She was looking for a grave.

Not a person's grave — though that too. She was looking for the thing every other monument on earth coughs up if you shake it hard enough: the box at the center. The big house under the small houses. The body laid down with the good obsidian and the copper and somebody's daughters arranged around it like punctuation. Find the rich dead, and you've found the why, or at least the who-said-so. Egypt has it. Cahokia has it — Mound 72, the beaded burial, the retainers. Ur has it so hard the excavators got squeamish. You dig into a mound, you brace for a king.

She had been bracing for two days. The brace kept not paying off.

"Anything," the engineer said. He'd been reading over her shoulder for twenty minutes, which from him was either deep interest or the early stage of him deciding the table was organized wrong. "There's gotta be a guy. There's always a guy."

"Define guy."

“Big house. Big grave. Special pot. The one whose dirt is different from everybody else’s dirt.” He tapped the Mound A cross-section, Kidder’s figure, the one with the fill episodes stacked like a layer cake somebody had photographed mid-bite. “I keep waiting for the part where it gets organized from the top. You can’t move that much earth without a guy.”

“That,” said the archivist, “is the whole chapter you keep almost reading.”

Let the official story stand up straight, because it earns the room.

Three thousand years ago and change, people who did not farm and did not crown anybody raised a city out of the floodplain. Six ridges, nested like the rings inside a felled tree, the outermost arc better than a kilometer across. A bird-shaped mound twenty-two meters tall. Call it a quarter-million cubic meters of fill if you like round numbers; the careful number is two hundred thirty-eight thousand, give or take the way all real numbers give or take. Moved by hand. In baskets. Thirty to fifty pounds a trip, by the microstratigraphy, by the small footprints and the smaller ones mixed in with the large — men, women, and the children who were apparently not exempt, sorry, kids.

No wheel. No ox. No horse. No iron, no bronze, not so much as a copper trowel. No writing to tell anyone afterward whose idea it had been.

And here is the part that ought to keep a person up: no chief. No palace floor packed harder than the rest. No throne mound, no granary worth seizing because there was no granary, because there were no grain crops to put in one. No ranked dead. You walk the whole UNESCO citation and the closest it comes to authority is the word *situational* — leadership that flickered up when it was needed and went out again when the work was done, the way a campfire is in charge of a campsite for exactly as long as it’s lit.

The skeptics — and the archivist loved the skeptics, kept their papers in the same folder as the wonder, because the skeptics were the ones doing the actual arithmetic — the skeptics say good, fine, you don’t *need* a king. You need a crowd and a reason. People will move mountains for a wedding or a funeral or a god or just because everyone

they have ever loved is going to be in one place for one season and the thing has to be finished before they scatter. Hierarchy is one way to organize labor. It is not the only way, and the assumption that it is says more about the people doing the assuming than about the people doing the carrying.

That's the official story. It's clean. It's beautiful. It is also, the archivist thought, a door with no doorknob, because every other monument she had ever read about had handed her the answer in the form of a tomb, and this one was handing her an absence and asking her to find that satisfying.

"Show me your guy," the local said.

She'd come in out of the heat with two coffees she had not been asked to bring and set one down by the engineer without comment, which was its own kind of authority. The state archaeologist. Forty years on this gumbo, give or take; people in the descendant community three generations deep, give or take. She read the table the way the archivist read footnotes — fast, then slow, then she stopped reading and just watched the people doing the reading.

"There isn't one," the archivist said. "That's what I keep — I keep turning the page expecting the burial and there's no burial."

"And that bothers you."

"It bothers him." The archivist nodded at the engineer. "It's starting to bother me, which is worse, because I should know better."

The local pulled a chair around backward and sat. "Tell me why it bothers you. The real reason. Not the methodology reason."

The archivist set down her pen, which for her was the equivalent of someone else standing up. "Because if there's no king, there's no story I know how to tell. Every monument I've ever catalogued, the story is the same story. Somebody powerful wants to be remembered, or wants to be feared, or wants the gods on his side, so he spends other people's bodies to pile up earth or stone, and the pile is a sentence and the sentence is *I was here and you were not me*. That's the whole genre. That's pyramids, that's Versailles, that's every skyline in every city we've driven through." She touched the cross-section.

"This doesn't say *I*. I can't find the *I*. And I don't have a grammar for a monument that isn't bragging."

The fish on the wall — there is always a fish; a lacquered largemouth somebody had won or caught or both, mounted over the door with its mouth open in permanent objection — said nothing, but it said it loudly.

The local smiled like the archivist had passed a test she hadn't known she was taking.

"You're looking for the speaker," she said. "I keep telling y'all to look for the verb."

The LENS was in the doorway then, camera down at his hip, not raised. He'd been out on the ridges since the light got good, and he had the particular stillness on him that the crew had learned not to crowd. He'd been photographing the absence too, in his way — the long curved nothing of the ridge tops, grass and sky and the suggestion underfoot of where ten thousand people had once decided to live in arcs. You cannot photograph a thing that isn't there. He kept trying anyway. That was the whole problem with him and also the whole point.

"There's a story," the local said, to the room now, in the cadence of someone who has told it before and will tell it again and is choosing, deliberately, to tell this part and not the other part. "Not a king story. People want the king story so bad they'll hang it on a hill that doesn't have one. The stories that come down — the ones I'll say out loud — they're gathering stories. People came. From a long way. You can see how far in the rock, because we don't have rock here, not really, and the rock's here anyway — gray flint from up north, soapstone from the east, things that walked or paddled a thousand kilometers to get to a place with no stone." She turned the printout so the trade map faced her. "Though I'll tell you what I tell everybody, before your engineer gets excited — the *thousand kilometers* is real but the *Great Lakes copper* part got walked back. Some of it's Appalachian. The network's continental. The exact wires are still being argued. Don't oversell me."

"I wasn't going to," the engineer said, who absolutely had been.

“They came,” she went on, “and they ate. We’ve got the cooking balls — you’ve held them, the little baked clay loaves, you drop them hot in a pit and they hold the heat, that’s how you feed a crowd with no pottery to spare. We’ve got the ovens. We’ve got the post rings out under the plaza, big rings, sixty-some meters across some of them, found by the magnetometer because the wood’s long gone but the dirt remembers where the wood stood. Something happened in those rings. People stood in circles around something, or someone, or some time of year.” She let that sit. “And then everyone picked up baskets.”

“And built it in a season,” the engineer said. “The mound. The no-weathering thing. Kidder.”

“The no-weathering thing,” she agreed. “No rain-wash surfaces between the layers. No crust where a layer sat out in the weather waiting on the next one. You leave fill exposed through a Louisiana spring, it crusts, it rills, the rain writes all over it. There’s none of that writing. Which means they didn’t stop. Layer, layer, layer, no pause long enough for the sky to leave a mark. A matter of months. Thirty days, ninety days, the careful people won’t pin it tighter than that, and the careful people are right not to.”

The archivist had stopped looking for the grave. She was looking at the post rings now.

“A king takes years,” she said slowly. “A king takes years on purpose. The years are the point — the labor’s the tax, the slowness is the threat. *Look how long I can make you carry.* You don’t build fast under a king. Fast is what you build when everybody wants the same thing at the same time and knows it won’t last.”

“There she goes,” said the local, quiet, to the LENS, who had finally and very slowly raised the camera, and then — watching the archivist’s face — lowered it again without firing. Some things you don’t take. He’d learned that the hard way in places he didn’t talk about.

Here is the potato, and it is the same potato it has always been on this site, the one the crew had failed at personally with their own backs in the wet two days prior: the math does not want to be fast.

Do the arithmetic the engineer had done, twice, because he couldn’t

not. Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters. Call the basket a quarter cubic meter, generously, and forty pounds, which is a real load, a load you feel in the morning. That's near a million basket-loads for the big mound alone, never mind the ridges. Spread it over ninety days. Spread it over a workforce — and here's where the crew's reconstruction had gone sideways in the gumbo, because a basket of saturated clay weighs more than a basket of plan, and a slope you've climbed forty times is steeper than a slope you've climbed once, and people are not a spreadsheet, people get tired and hungry and bitten and they quit at noon when the heat sits down on the floodplain like a wet animal. The crew had moved, between four of them, in one long miserable morning, something on the order of a rounding error.

And these people raised a mountain before the rain could sign its name on it.

You don't get there with a guy. That's the thing the engineer kept circling and the thing he couldn't say because it ruined his model. One guy with a whip gets you a slow mound and a lot of resentment. You get a fast mound exactly one way: everyone, at once, with reason enough to break their own backs without being asked twice. The speed isn't evidence of power. The speed is evidence of *want*. That's harder to model than a king. You can't put want in the spreadsheet.

"It holds, too," the local added, almost as an afterthought, which was how the crew had learned she dropped the heavy ones. "Three thousand years. Most earth that age is a smear. This isn't. They mixed the soils on purpose — fine with coarse, this clay against that clay, to beat the shrink and swell, to keep the rain from carrying it off. Kidder puts it next to Roman concrete. Next to rammed earth in China. Engineers, the both of them, working a problem." She tapped the table once. "People who can do *that* with their hands and their heads didn't need a man on a throne to tell them how. They knew. They all knew. That's not a peasant skill you beat into a workforce. That's a thing a whole people carries in its body and brings to the gathering already knowing."

The archivist sat back. The window unit shuddered and caught and ran on.

"So there's no heir," she said. It came out flat, not a question. "That's

the part. Not just no king — no *next* king. Nobody inherits this. Nobody points at the mound and says *my father, my line*. You build a thing this size to outlast you, normally, so your name rides it. There's no name to ride it. They didn't even leave us writing to *not* write a name in."

"They left us the mound," the local said. "That's the writing. You're just mad it's not in a language that flatters anybody."

The fish kept its opinion.

The LENS, by the door, finally lifted the camera and this time he did fire it — not at any of them, but at the table, at the scatter of paper and the two coffees and the cross-section with its silent layered cake, the absence laid out flat where the king should have been. The shutter was very loud in the small room.

"You want me to tell you what it was for," the local said, gathering herself to leave the way she'd come, unbidden. "And I might. Not today. Today I'm just going to fix the verb for you and let you sit in it." She stood, turned the chair back the right way, set her empty cup in the engineer's hand because his was the nearest. "Y'all keep hunting for who made them do it. Nobody made them. That's the whole thing your spreadsheet can't hold and your skeptics get and your kings-and-pyramids people never will. There was no man at the top. There was no man at the bottom either, no slave, no tax, no whip we can find. There was just a season and a reason and ten thousand pairs of hands that all agreed at once."

She put her hat on at the door.

"It was all hands," she said. "Or none."

Chapter 14 — The Walk-Away

The light at the end of a Louisiana day did something to the ridges that no daylight could. It came in low and yellow off the cane, and the six nested arcs that Mara had spent two weeks failing to see — flat, gentle, near-invisible swells that the brochures kept calling *monumental* — caught the rake of it and stood up out of the ground like a thing remembered rather than a thing measured.

She had the camera up before she'd decided to. That was the old reflex, the one the series kept asking her to lower. Some part of her had spent a war learning that the moment you most wanted to look away was the moment worth the frame. She didn't trust the reflex anymore. She trusted it completely. Both were true and she had stopped trying to choose.

Through the viewfinder the ridges held their curve. C after C after C, six of them, opening toward the bayou like cupped hands, the outermost a kilometer and change from horn to horn. You could stand on one and not know you stood on anything. You had to get the sun this low, this kind, to feel the swell of it under your boots — three thousand years of dirt that the river had spent every wet season since trying to take back, and the dirt just sat there. Held its line. Refused.

Darnell Boudreaux walked ahead of them along the crest of Ridge 3 with his hands in his jacket pockets and the unhurried gait of a man on ground he'd been walking his whole life. He was the state archaeologist here, which was the smallest true thing you could say about him. His grandmother's people had fished this water. He'd read more of this place than anyone alive and he wore it like he wore

the jacket, easy and without ceremony.

“You’re chasing the gold light,” he said, not turning around. “Everybody does. The geophysics boys, the drone people. Always at sun-down.”

“It’s the only time the place lets you see it,” Mara said.

“It’s the only time you let yourself.”

She let that sit, because it was probably correct.

Behind her, Tomás — the engineer, young, head down, walking the ridge crest the way he walked everything, like the ground owed him an answer — was counting his own footsteps under his breath and converting. He’d been doing the math for days. He couldn’t stop doing the math. It was how he loved a thing.

“Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters,” he said, to nobody. “Just Mound A. The ridges on top of that. Thirty to fifty pounds a basket.” He stopped. Started again. “If you put a thousand people on it — a thousand, all day, every day —”

“You can’t put a thousand foragers on it every day,” said Petra. The archivist had a paperback going soft at the spine in one hand, her thumb in it, marking a place. “Foragers don’t have a granary. There’s no storehouse. No silo of corn to feed the work crew through the dry season because there’s no corn. There’s no corn anywhere on this site, in any layer, for the whole run of it.” She looked up. “That’s the part nobody films.”

That was the part nobody filmed. Mara knew it cold now, two weeks in. The official story was the marvel and the marvel was honest: people who hunted and fished and gathered, who planted nothing, ruled no one, were ruled by no one — and they raised this. They moved a quarter of a million cubic meters of earth in baskets carried on the hip, basket by basket, no wheel to roll it, no ox to pull it, no bronze to dig it, the dirt going up the slope on the backs of men and women and — the microstratigraphy was clear on this, the small loads tucked between the large ones — children. A whole society’s worth of children carrying their thirty pounds up a hill that became a mountain.

And then the skeptic’s good clean answer, which Mara had come to respect the way you respect a thing that won’t let you off the hook:

you don't need a king for that. You don't need kings or crops. You need a crowd big enough and a reason good enough. No mystery. Just people, deciding together, and following the deciding all the way up.

She'd believed it. She still believed it. The trouble was the dirt.

—

They came off Ridge 3 and crossed the plaza, and here the fish in Mara's head — the one that heckled, the one that had kept her alive in places that wanted her dead by refusing to let any official anything go down whole — the fish surfaced and said: *flattest haunted nothing you ever saw, isn't it.*

It was. The plaza was a grass field. A man could mow it. And under it, the magnetometry had found rings — circles of postholes, big ones, twenty-five meters across, sixty-three meters across, timber set in arcs by people who then pulled the timber up or let it rot, leaving only the dark stain in the dirt for a machine to read three millennia later. Nobody knew what the rings did. Petra had read the papers. The papers said: rings.

"You stand here at the right time of year," Tomás said, turning slow, sighting down the gaps in the ridges like a man lining up a shot, "and the sun's supposed to come up through the —"

"Supposed to," said Petra, before he could finish. "Haag put the center one place. Purrington put it somewhere else. Move the center, you move the alignment. They don't agree on where the middle of this thing is, so they can't agree on what it points at." She found her thumb-marked page without looking. "There's no consensus on the sky here. There's people who want one very badly."

Tomás lowered his arm. He didn't sulk. He just filed it, the way he filed everything, into the place where the answers weren't yet. Mara loved him for the lack of sulk.

Darnell had stopped in the middle of the grass and turned to watch them argue, and there was something in his face — not amusement exactly. The patience of a man who'd heard the sun-through-the-gap theory from forty earnest visitors and would hear it from forty more and would not take it from any of them, because the not-knowing was his to keep too.

“Y’all want to know what it points at,” he said.

“I want to know why they left,” Mara said.

It came out of her before she’d weighed it. The light was going. The cane had gone from gold to the color of a held breath. She lowered the camera.

—

Because that was the hole. Not the moving of the dirt — the dirt was a marvel and the marvel was answerable, even if the answering was hard. The hole was after.

Kidder’s work on Mound A was the thing she couldn’t put down. Twenty-two meters of fill, and when they cut into it and read the layers the way you’d read tree rings or ice cores, they found — nothing. No nothing. No weathering surfaces between the loads. No rain-wash. No silt skin that says *here the work stopped and a wet season came and the exposed dirt sat and took the weather before the next load went on*. There was none of that. Layer met layer with no time between them. Which meant the mountain went up without a pause. Without a winter. Without a *we’ll come back next year and finish*.

A matter of months. Thirty to ninety days. A whole hill in a season, all hands, all at once, no breath taken — and Kidder reaching for the only comparisons big enough to hold it, Roman concrete, Chinese rammed earth, the deliberate engineered mixing of soils so the thing would shed water and hold its shape for three thousand years. Which it had. Which it was doing right now, under her boots, in the dark coming on.

And then they walked away.

That was the part that stood the hair up on Mara’s arms in a way the war hadn’t managed in years. You gather thousands. You feed them — somehow, with no farm, no store, the river and the woods and the nut harvest stretched over a crowd that should have stripped this floodplain bare in a week. You raise a mountain in ninety days. And then there is no king to crown, no palace to build around, no heir to hand it to, no granary to defend. The leadership that ran the build — and something ran it, you don’t move 238,000 cubic meters by accident — the leadership just *dissolves*. Goes back to being people.

And the crowd scatters back into the woods and the water, and the rings rot, and the mound holds its line through three thousand years of seasons while the society that raised it does not hold together past the season that raised it.

Built to last, the fish said. By people who didn't.

Mara turned that over and didn't like how clean it sat. She distrusted clean.

—

They walked out toward the western edge as the last of it went. Darnell led, and they followed in a loose line along the dike, the bayou somewhere to the left making the small sounds water makes when it's deciding whether to rise.

"My grandmother," Darnell said, "would bring us out here when we were small. Not to teach. We didn't do teaching. She'd just walk us along the ridge and not say much." He stopped at the edge where the engineered ground gave way to the river's claim. "People come and ask me why they left like it's a thing went wrong. Like a building burned down. Like there's a body to find."

Mara had the camera at her hip. She did not raise it. The series kept asking her to lower it and here, now, she lowered it.

"They feed thousands with no farm," Tomás said. He'd stopped doing the math out loud. "They raise a mountain in ninety days. And there's no —" He stopped, hunting the word with that literal precision of his, refusing any word but the right one. "There's no *more*. After. No bigger thing they were building toward. They just — stop. At the top."

"That's the part your machines can't read," Darnell said. Not unkind.

"Kidder read the layers," Petra offered, quiet. "He can show you there was no pause. He can't show you why there was no second one."

"No." Darnell looked out at the water. "He can't."

Mara watched him in the failing light — the man who out-read every one of them on this ground, who knew which papers were sound and which were somebody's wishing, who could have told them the soil recipe and the basket count and the trade routes that brought stone here from a thousand kilometers off, debated in the detail but

continental in the fact of it, gray flint and steatite and copper moving across a third of a continent into this one bend of one Louisiana river. He knew all of it. And she could see him deciding, the way she'd seen men decide things in worse places, what he would hand them and what was not theirs.

"You want me to tell you why they walked away," he said.

"I want to know if you know," Mara said. Which was the honest thing, and she watched it land.

He was quiet a long time. The bayou talked to itself. Up behind them in the dark the ridges held their six soft curves and Mound A held its twenty-two meters and the whole engineered field of it held the line it had been built to hold, water shedding off the mixed soils the way it had shed for three thousand summers, the dirt refusing the river one more night.

"I think," Darnell said slowly, "that they didn't build it to keep."

Mara waited.

"That's the thing y'all can't get past. The consortium can't get past it either, but worse, because they need it to be a thing you keep so they can sell the keeping." He turned to face them, and his face was almost gone in the dusk, just the shape of a man on his own ground. "You came here for the why. The why's not mine to give you, because I don't have it, and the part I do have —" He stopped. Started again, choosing. "What I have is: it wasn't ours to keep. It was never the keeping. They came, they made the thing, and the making was the thing. Then they let it go back to being a place."

"And the mound?" Tomás again, soft now. "It lasted three thousand years. They engineered it to last."

"Yeah." Something moved across Darnell's face that might have been a smile. "They built it to outlive the keeping. That's not the same as building it to keep."

Mara felt the floor of the thing drop out from under her and refuse to fully open — the maybe sitting there in the dark, unanswered, the draught of it cold on her face. She did not raise the camera. There was no frame for it. That was the point. The local had handed them exactly as much as was his to hand and not one grain more, and the

not-more was the gift.

The fish, for once, said nothing.

—

They were halfway back along the dike, the site behind them gone fully to silhouette, when the phone in Mara's jacket woke up. Then Petra's. Then a third, somewhere, Tomás patting his pockets.

The same email. Mara read it walking, the screen too bright in the dark, ruining her night vision the way bright things always did.

It was from the consortium's man — the project lead, the charming one, the one Mara's whole wiring screamed *grift* at and who genuinely, she'd decided, believed every word he said, which was worse. The subject line was warm. *Excited to move forward*. The body was warmer. They'd secured the state's preliminary sign-off. The interpretive center renderings were attached — glass and reclaimed timber, very tasteful, a gift shop, a path that kept visitors to the path. The funding was real, generous, more than the site had seen in a decade of cuts. And the close, the soft close, the close that her body knew before her mind did:

We'd like to bring this to the descendant community council Thursday for a decision. We feel strongly the window for partnership is now — opportunities like this don't hold.

Three days.

Mara stopped on the dike. Ahead of her in the dark Darnell had stopped too, his own phone lit in his hand, his face turned down to it, unreadable.

The water on the left made its small deciding sound.

Window for partnership is now, the fish said quietly, reading over her shoulder the way it did. *Opportunities like this don't hold*.

No. They never did. That was always the line. That was always exactly the line — said by the man who needs you to decide before you've finished looking, the same way every man who'd ever taken a thing from people who built it had needed them to decide before they'd finished looking.

She raised the camera then. Got Darnell in the last of the light, the phone glow on his face, the dark field of three thousand years behind him that had been built to outlive its own keeping, and now had three days to find out if it would have to.

“Thursday,” Darnell said, to none of them, to the water. He put the phone away. “They want it Thursday.”

“They want it before we’ve read it,” Mara said.

“They want it before we have,” he said.

And that, she thought, lowering the camera, was the whole thing. That was always the whole thing.

Chapter 15 — Pressure and Pride

The Epps community center smelled of coffee and floor wax and the particular damp that gets into any building within a mile of the Macon Ridge. Somebody had set out folding chairs in rows, then given up on rows, and the chairs had drifted into the loose constellations that people actually sit in — families clumped, old men along the back wall standing because their knees had opinions about folding chairs, a knot of teenagers near the door with the look of being there under duress and secretly listening.

I counted heads out of habit. Eighty-one, give or take the ones cycling through the coffee urn. For a Tuesday night in West Carroll Parish, with a thunderstorm sitting fat and purple on the western horizon, that was a turnout. That was people who'd skipped supper.

I read rooms for a living. It's not a gift the way the brochures say gift. It's that I was a strange kid in a lot of strange rooms and I learned that the safest place to stand was the place where I could see who wanted what, and from whom, and how badly. You watch the hands. You watch who looks at whom before they speak. You watch the door. I have never once stopped doing it and I have stopped apologizing for it.

So I watched the consortium man set up his easel.

His name was Daniel Frace and he was, God help me, likeable. Forties, good shirt, no tie — he'd read the room before he got here too, just not as well as he thought. He'd brought a laptop and a projector and then, seeing there was no good wall, had pivoted to foam boards on an easel without a flicker of irritation. Adaptable. He knew the

county judge by first name. He'd shaken eleven hands on the way in and remembered at least four of them well enough to ask a follow-up question. *How'd the knee surgery go, Mr. Latimer.* That kind of thing.

He believed in what he was selling. That's the part the movies get wrong. The dangerous ones aren't the sneering ones. The dangerous ones love the thing they're going to eat.

"I want to start," Frace said, "by saying that I'm not here to tell you what your site is. You know what it is. You've lived next to it your whole lives." He let that sit. Good instinct. "I'm here because right now, the world is finally catching up to what you already knew. UNESCO put your backyard on the same list as the pyramids and the Grand Canyon. That's done. That happened in 2014. The question in front of this community is whether you let that recognition just — sit there. Or whether you let it work for you."

He turned the first foam board. An artist's rendering. A glass-fronted visitor center, low and tasteful, parking for two hundred. People in pastel shirts walking a boardwalk over the ridges. The bird-shape of Mound A in the background, mowed and lit and clean.

"Forty jobs to start," he said. "Local hires. A real interpretive program. School buses from three states. And — this is the part I want you to hear — restoration funding. Real money to stabilize what the rain's been taking off those ridges every spring for three thousand years."

A murmur ran the room, and it wasn't all hostile, and that was the thing I clocked. Half of these people had watched their kids leave for Monroe and Shreveport and Houston because there was no work. *Forty jobs* lands different in a parish that's been losing people since before I was born. The grief and the pride sat in the same chest. I could see it on them.

Beside me, the Lens had her camera down in her lap, both hands over it, not shooting. She does that when the room is doing something a photograph would cheapen. She'd learned that the hard way in places I don't ask about. Her thumb moved on the lens cap, on, off, on. The teenagers by the door. The old men's hands. She was reading it too, just with her eyes instead of the glass.

Our engineer leaned toward me. "He said *the rain's been taking it off the ridges,*" he whispered. Not quiet enough — he's never quiet

enough, the volume dial isn't wired to the room, it's wired to how interesting the thing is. "That's wrong. The ridges erode. Mound A barely erodes. It's the engineered fill. He's bundling them so the scary number covers the whole site."

"I know," I said.

"He's not lying exactly. He's—"

"I know. Hold it."

Because here's the potato, and Frace was standing on it without feeling it through his good shoes.

The thing about Mound A is that it should be a hill of mud by now. Twenty-two meters of dirt, two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of it, hauled up basket by basket — thirty, forty, fifty pounds a load, on the backs and hips of men and women and children, because the microstratigraphy shows the small footprints in the layers, shows whole families in the lifts — and not a wheel among them, not an ox, not a scoop of metal. You raise that much loose Louisiana loess and silt in a floodplain that gets fifty-odd inches of rain a year, and the first big storm should start carving it. The next thousand storms should finish it. The river should have it back.

It doesn't. It hasn't. Three thousand years and the thing holds its shoulders. Kidder — Tristram Kidder, Washington University, the man who put the trowel to the question — found why: they mixed the soils on purpose. Sandier fill against silt, in deliberate proportion, to fight the shrink and swell that cracks unengineered earth apart through wet seasons and dry. He's compared it, in print, to Roman concrete. To Chinese rammed earth. Foragers. No farms, no kings, no writing. Soil engineers who beat erosion for three millennia and left us no manual.

And Frace was offering to *stabilize* it. Like it needed him. Like the people who built it hadn't already solved the problem he was charging admission to fix.

That's the move. That's always the move. You find a thing that doesn't need you and you convince the people who own it that it's been waiting for you all along.

"What's the catch," said a voice from the back wall.

It was one of the standing men, arms folded. Not aggressive. Just done with the preamble.

Frace nodded like it was a great question, because to him it was — he'd practiced this one. "No catch. There's a management agreement. The Consortium handles operations, marketing, the capital build. The state retains ownership of the land. You — the community — get a seat on the advisory board, and the jobs, and the foot traffic that keeps your diner open and your gas station open."

"How many seats," I said.

I hadn't planned to speak. It came out flat, the way questions about numbers come out of me, with no music in them, and a few heads turned because the accent was wrong for the room and the question had teeth.

Frace found me, placed me, recovered. "On the advisory board? Two."

"Out of how many."

"Eleven."

"And the advisory board advises," I said. "It doesn't decide."

A beat. "It's an advisory role, yes."

"And the curriculum. The interpretive program. The school buses learn the version on the foam board." I tipped my chin at the easel. "Who writes that."

"We'd hire consultants. Subject-matter experts—"

"From here?"

He hesitated, and the hesitation was the whole answer, and the room heard it. I watched it travel. The pride and the grief, and now a third thing waking up under them, an old familiar thing in a parish like this one: the memory of being told what their own ground meant by people who'd driven in to tell them.

I didn't push it further. You don't. You set the number down where everyone can see it and you step back and let them look at it. The grift isn't a secret you reveal. It's an arithmetic you make visible. *Two out of eleven. Advise, not decide. Consultants from away.* Let it sit

on the table next to the forty jobs and let people who are smarter about their own lives than I will ever be do the sum.

That's when Dr. Reaux stood up.

She'd been sitting in the second clump from the front the whole time, a state-site archaeologist with thirty years of this ground under her nails and a grandmother who'd grown up on the Macon Ridge looking at those earthworks every morning of her life. She hadn't said a word yet. She has a way of being still that makes the stillness do work. When she stood, the room came to her without anyone shushing anyone.

"Daniel," she said — first name, because she'd done him the courtesy and the warning of it, *I know you, you don't get to be a stranger doing this* — "your boardwalk is beautiful. I mean that. Somebody talented drew it."

A small laugh. He took it gracefully.

"And I want every kid in this parish to have a job that doesn't put them on the road north." She let her eyes go around the room, to the standing men, to the teenagers, and she stayed there a second on the teenagers. "I do. I want that more than you do, because I'm going to be at their graduations and you're not."

Nobody laughed at that one.

"But I'm going to say the thing I'm here to say, and then we can argue." She put a hand flat on the back of the chair in front of her. "That ground out there does not belong to the state. The state holds the deed. That's paper. That ground belongs to the people who carried it up there, and to the people who never left, and the difference between those two is smaller than you've been told."

She didn't raise her voice. She lowered it, which is harder, and which makes a room lean in.

"We know how they built it. We do. The baskets, the lifts, the soil mixed so it'd outlast everything around it — we can show you the layers, we can count the loads, we can tell you it went up fast, faster than it has any right to, a season, maybe a single season, no rain-marks between the lifts, no pause, all hands." Her voice caught the wonder and held it without dropping it, like a thing too good to set

down. “What we don’t know is what called them. What gathered thousands of people who had no king to make them come, and no fields to keep them fed, and no writing to leave us a single word about why. We don’t know what it was for.”

She looked at Frace.

“And neither do you. So you’ll fill it. That’s what an interpretive center is, Daniel. It’s a frame around a question, and the frame says *answered*. You’ll put a film in there with a narrator and a soundtrack and it’ll tell my granddaughter’s children a tidy story about her own people, and they’ll believe it, because it’s behind glass and it cost money.”

The storm chose that moment to arrive. Rain hit the metal roof all at once, the way it does down here, no warning patter, just the sky deciding. Everyone glanced up by reflex and then back down to her, and she let the rain talk for a second and then went on under it.

“The not-knowing is not a hole in the value. The not-knowing *is* the value. It’s the part nobody can sell you, because it isn’t for sale, because we don’t have it to sell.” She straightened off the chair. “That’s all. I’m not telling anybody how to vote. I’m telling you what you’d be voting on. There’s a difference, and a man with a foam board won’t draw it for you.”

She sat down.

The Lens had the camera up. I hadn’t seen her raise it. She’d shot the sitting-down, not the standing-up — the moment after, when Reaux’s face went from public to private, when she let herself be tired for one frame. I’d argue with her about it later and she’d be right and I’d know she was right. She lowers the camera for the wrong reasons and raises it for the right ones, and I have stopped trying to predict which is which.

Frace was good. I’ll give him that to the grave. He didn’t flinch and he didn’t fight her. He nodded slowly, like she’d given him something to think about, which maybe she had. “I hear you,” he said. “I do. And I’d never want to put a story behind glass that the community didn’t bless. Which is exactly why I’d want Dr. Reaux on the advisory board.”

Advisory. He hadn’t even noticed he’d handed her his own number

back. Two out of eleven. Advise, not decide. He'd built his whole charm around hearing the room and he'd missed the one sentence that mattered, the *that ground does not belong to the state*. He thought she was negotiating. She wasn't negotiating. She was drawing the boundary on the floor and telling him which side of it he stood on.

The county judge cleared his throat and looked at the rain on the windows and then at his watch, and I knew before he opened his mouth what was coming, because I'd watched the hands all night and the hands wanted more time.

"It's coming down hard," the judge said, "and half the folks who ought to weigh in on this couldn't make it through the weather tonight. The Boudreaux family's not here. The church group's not here." He spread his palms. "I don't think we vote tonight on something this size with half the parish home from the rain. We table it. We set another meeting, two weeks, and we send the proposal around in writing so people can read it cold, at their kitchen tables, without—" a glance at the foam board, not unkind "—without the picture in front of them. All in favor of tabling?"

Hands went up. A lot of them. Frace's didn't, but he didn't fight it either, and that was the tell I'd been waiting for all night and didn't want.

Because two weeks is nothing to a man with a foam board and a per diem. Two weeks is a long time to a parish that has to find a quorum in the rain. And in two weeks, Frace gets to go kitchen table to kitchen table, the way he'd gone handshake to handshake on the way in — alone, charming, the picture in his bag, *how'd the knee surgery go* — and Reaux gets to do her actual job, which is to be one woman with a trowel against a budget line.

The motion carried. People stood, shrugged into jackets, eyed the parking lot through the streaming glass.

Reaux caught my eye across the emptying room. She didn't smile. She gave me a small nod, the kind that isn't thanks and isn't warmth, the kind that says *you saw it too, and seeing it isn't the same as stopping it*.

"We didn't win that," our engineer said, pulling on his hood. "We

didn't lose it either. It's just — open."

"Yeah," I said.

Frace was folding his easel, careful with the foam boards, sliding each one into a padded sleeve. He'd be back. He had two weeks and a story that fit behind glass, and we had a question nobody was allowed to answer, sitting out there in the dark and the rain, holding its shoulders the way it had held them for three thousand years, waiting on a vote that hadn't happened yet.

The Lens lowered the camera. For once I didn't tell her to raise it.

Chapter 16 — The Hole

The whiteboard had been a kitchen door once. Somebody — the diner owner, probably — had pried it off its hinges, sanded it, and screwed it to the back wall of the field station's break room so the archaeologists would stop writing on the actual walls. Theo liked it. It had a brass knob still on it, low and useless, and a long scar where a latch had been, and he found that if he stood at the right angle the dry-erase markers caught in the old grain and skipped, which meant he had to write slower, which he hated and which was also, he suspected, good for him.

He wrote: **238,000 m³.**

Under it: **Mound A.**

Under that, because the number was too clean and clean numbers lied: **22 m tall. 30-90 days. No pause.**

"You've drawn that arrow four times," Mara said. She had the consortium's revised offer open on her tablet, the one with the heritage-experience language and the parking study, and she was reading it the way she read everything — fast, then again slow, the second pass looking for the sentence that did the actual work. "Each time the arrow gets angrier."

"The arrow's fine." Theo capped the marker. "The arrow is the problem. Watch."

He'd been at this since the failed earth-move, since the afternoon their model hill had grown to a sad knee-high lump and the math had come out wrong in the direction math always came out wrong — slower, muddier, more people, more days, more food. He'd run the basket loads again that morning with Naomi's correction (children

carried too; the microstratigraphy was clear, small loads in the mix, a whole population in the dirt), and the number had gotten better and worse at the same time. Better because more hands. Worse because — and this was the arrow — more hands is more mouths.

“Okay,” he said. “Forget the dirt for a second.”

“The fish would like to note,” said the fish, “that you have never once forgotten the dirt.”

The fish was a singing bass mounted on a plaque over the coffee machine, the kind that flopped and yodeled when you pressed its button, and at some point in the second week somebody — Theo would not say who, it had been him — had decided it was load-bearing to the crew’s mental health to give it a voice. It was off now. It was always, technically, off.

“Forget the dirt,” Theo said again. “Say the dirt is solved. Say I believe Kidder, which I do, I believe the soil, I believe no rain-wash surfaces, I believe they went up and up and didn’t stop. Fine. The dirt is the *answer* to a question. What’s the question?”

Lou looked up from the window. He’d been photographing the same line of cane for twenty minutes, the way the afternoon light came off it green-then-silver when the wind turned it, and he had the stillness on him he got when the camera was working as a place to put his hands. “How,” he said.

“No. How is the dirt. How is baskets, how is loess, how is a mile-wide C with the open end to the river. How we mostly *get*.” Theo turned to the door-board and wrote, under the angry arrow, a single word, and the marker skipped in the grain so the word came out broken, **W—HO.**

He stared at it. Started to fix it.

“Leave it,” said Naomi, quiet, from the corner where she had three open books and a fourth held flat with a coffee mug. “It’s right.”

“It says *who*.”

“It says both.”

He left it.

Here was the thing the official story handled beautifully, and Theo wanted to be fair to it, because the official story was not stupid and the people who'd built it were not stupid and the skeptics who defended it were, on this point, almost certainly *right*. You don't need kings. That was the elegant part, the part that had made him fall a little in love with the place before he'd ever stood on a ridge. You don't need a pharaoh with a whip. You need a crowd big enough and a reason good enough, and crowds organize themselves all the time without a man on a throne — a barn-raising, a flood-fight, a festival, a funeral. People show up. People carry. People know where to put the basket because the person ahead of them put theirs there. The build is the leader. The work tells you what to do.

He believed that. He'd watched it happen on his own pathetic model hill — for about nine minutes, until somebody had to decide whose dirt went where and the nine minutes ended.

"So picture it," Theo said. He'd started walking, which Mara had learned not to interrupt. "Late Archaic. Sixteen hundred BCE, give or take. You're a forager. You're good at it — these were not desperate people, the trade goods alone tell you they had time and reach, stone from a thousand kilometers, the network's real even where the details are a fight. You've got your band. Forty people, sixty. You range, you fish, you gather, you make your cooking balls and your earth ovens, you're *fine*."

"And then," Mara said, because she could hear where the arrow pointed.

"And then somehow, in one season, you and a few thousand people you are mostly not related to and have no boss in common with decide to be in the same square mile of floodplain at the same time, and stay, and carry dirt until a mountain exists." He stopped. "Mara. You do funding. You move money and people for a living. How many can-do-it-themselves adults can you get to do a hard physical thing in the same place at the same time, fed, for one season, with no payroll and no boss?"

Mara set the tablet down. This was, he could see, a real question to her, not a rhetorical one, and she gave it the respect of going quiet first.

"For free? With no king?" She tilted her head. "A wedding. A funeral.

A war. A flood.” A beat. “And every one of those has somebody who *makes the calls* in the moment, even if there’s no crown. The aunt who runs the funeral. The guy who’s done three floods. It dissolves after. But it’s there *during*. That’s not hierarchy, that’s —”

“Situational authority,” Naomi said, from the books, not looking up. “That’s the literature’s word. Leadership that exists for the event and dissolves when the event ends. It’s the consensus reading. No chief, no permanent rank — but somebody’s deciding the basket goes *here*.”

“Right.” Theo pointed at her with the marker. “So that solves it.”

“Does it,” said the fish.

Nobody had pressed the fish. Lou had. Lou put the camera down, looking faintly betrayed by his own hand.

“Sorry,” Lou said.

“No, he’s right,” Theo said. “It *solves it* the way the dirt solves it. It names the thing. *Situational authority*. Beautiful. But run it.” He went back to the board, wiped the broken WHO with the side of his fist, and started a column. “Three thousand people. Conservative. Some say more. Three thousand people in the floodplain in summer, which is — Lou, what’s it doing right now outside?”

“Building,” Lou said. The thunder had been stacking on the western horizon all afternoon, the way it did here every single day, the air thick enough to lean on.

“Building. So three thousand people, in this, for ninety days, carrying loess. What do they eat?”

Naomi had the answer ready, because Naomi always had the answer ready and the gift of her was that she gave it like a gift and not a correction. “Fish. Deer. Nuts — hickory, pecan, acorn, the loess is fertile and the river’s right there. Aquatic resources especially; the faunal record’s heavy on fish and there’s the cooking balls, the earth-oven technology, you can feed a crowd off an oven. No agriculture. No granary. No stored surplus we’ve found.” She finally looked up. “Which is the part nobody wants to sit with.”

“Say it anyway.”

"A farming state feeds a build off the granary. You've got grain, you've got storage, you've got a year's surplus in a pit, you call up the labor and you spend the surplus. That's how every other monument on Earth roughly works — there's a *bank*. Egypt has a bank. Cahokia, later, has a bank, corn." She turned a page she didn't need to turn. "Poverty Point has no bank. They're foraging the floodplain *while* they build the mountain. Hand to mouth, three thousand mouths, no storage, no pause — Kidder's microstratigraphy says no pause, no weathering surface, they did not stop to go home for the winter and come back. They went *up*."

The break room was quiet under the not-quite-rain.

"So that's the hole," Mara said slowly. She'd gone to the window with Lou. "Not the dirt."

"Not the dirt." Theo felt the relief of it, the clean cold click of the real gap separating from all the fake ones. "The dirt is hard and the dirt is solved. Smart foragers, lots of baskets, good soil sense, situational authority, up they go. I'll sign it. The *gathering* is the hole. You have to get three thousand self-sufficient people — people who do not *need* you, who have no debt to you, who can walk into the cane and feed their family without you forever — to converge, all at once, and feed themselves off a wild floodplain in a Louisiana summer, and carry dirt every day for three months, and *not leave*. And nobody made them. And then —"

He stopped.

"And then they leave," Lou said, to the window.

"And then they leave," Theo said. "It ends around eleven hundred BCE. No conquest layer we've found. No collapse story. No bodies in the plaza. The mountain's done, more or less, and the crowd that did the impossible thing — disperses. Goes back to being bands in the cane. And the mountain just — stands there. For three thousand years. Holding its shape because somebody understood shrink-swell soil well enough that Kidder compares the engineering to Roman concrete and we're standing in the parking lot of it."

"The fish," said the fish, because Lou had drifted close to the coffee machine again, "wishes to ask whether you have considered that they simply *wanted to*."

“That’s not an answer.”

“It’s not,” the fish agreed, in Lou’s flat war-photographer voice, and then Lou took his hand off the button and the room was only weather again.

Dr. Reese Boudreaux came in out of the front of the storm, shaking water off a state-issue rain jacket, and read the door-board the way you’d read a stranger’s open mail — one glance, complete, before she’d decided whether she had the right.

She had the right. It was her board. It was her break room, her field station, her site, her people three thousand years back and her people right now down the road in the parish she’d grown up in, and the crew had spent two weeks earning the chair she pulled out and they all of them knew the chair was lent.

“You found it,” she said. Not a question. She’d seen the column. She’d seen *what do they eat* and *no bank* and the bottom line where Theo had written, and not erased: **how do you summon & feed & hold 3,000 free people for a mountain — & then let them go?**

“We think it’s the real one,” Theo said. “Not the dirt.”

“It’s the real one.” Reese hung the jacket on the brass knob of the old door, which Theo found, obscurely, perfect. “Y’all are about the fortieth crew to get there. Most stop at the dirt because the dirt’s got a number and the number’s sexy. This one’s got no number.” She sat. She looked tired in the specific way of a person who has answered the same question for thirty years and watched people leave dissatisfied because the answer was *we don’t know*, which is the truest answer and the one nobody wants to film. “So. Ask me.”

Mara, who read rooms for money, didn’t ask. Mara waited.

Theo didn’t wait, because waiting was not a thing his wiring did well, and because he genuinely had to know. “Why’d they come? What was the reason good enough to pull a crowd that size off the land that fed them, with no king to make them?”

Reese looked at him a long moment. Outside the rain finally let down, all at once, the way it did, drumming the metal roof so they all had to lean in.

"I'm not going to tell you," she said.

It wasn't unkind. That was the thing Theo would turn over later, on the levee, alone — it had no edge on it at all. She wasn't withholding to win. She wasn't being cute.

"I could give you four reasons," she went on, into the rain. "I've read all of them. Trade fair. Ceremony. A pilgrimage to a sacred spot on the river. A funeral so big it built a hill. There's good people behind every one and good evidence under every one and not one of them closes it, because the closing thing — the writing, the king, the granary, the *deed of sale* —" a glance, dry, at Mara's tablet, "— isn't in the ground. It was never in the ground. These weren't people who left a king to explain themselves. So when I tell you which one I *believe*, I'm not telling you what it was for. I'm telling you what I'd put my money on. And then it's on film, in your nice show, in my voice, the state archaeologist, and it stops being a question." She folded her hands on the door-board's old grain. "And it's not mine to close. It's not even my ancestors' alone — it's three thousand people's, and they didn't agree to a caption."

"But you have a guess," Theo said. He couldn't help it.

"I have a guess." She smiled, and there was real affection in it, for him, for the question, for the whole impossible relentless human fact of it. "And I'm going to keep it."

The consortium's tablet sat between them, glowing, full of interpretive narratives and unlocked value and a single curated story that would play on a loop in a building with good parking, and Mara, watching Reese decline to fill the hole, looked at the tablet like she'd just seen what it was actually for.

"How'd you find the post rings?" Naomi asked, into the quiet — a different door, a gentle one. "The magnetometry, in the plaza."

"That," Reese said, standing, taking her wet jacket off the brass knob, "I'll show you. Tomorrow. When it dries." She paused at the doorway, the storm easing behind her into the long blue light. "The how I'll give you all day. Ground's full of how. The why —" she shrugged into the jacket. "The why's still out there. That's not me being precious. That's just the truth of the place. Y'all came a long way to find a hole. It's a good one. Sit in it a while before you try to fill it."

The door swung shut. The brass knob, screwed to the wall, caught the last of the light.

Theo stood at the board with his broken word and his angry arrow and a number with no number under it, and for once did not reach for the marker.

“She out-read us,” Mara said quietly. It wasn’t a complaint. It sounded, almost, like relief.

“By a lot,” Lou said.

The fish said nothing, because no one touched it, and the rain on the roof did the only talking there was, the way it had for three thousand summers over a mountain that nobody could explain and that had not, in all that time, washed away.

Chapter 17 — The Wink

The footnote had been bothering Marisol since the diner, three pages deep in a 1996 survey report she'd photographed off the field-station shelf, and she'd carried it out to the ridge because the ridge was where the question lived.

She sat on the inner C with the report balanced on her knees and the morning coming up grey-green over the plaza. From here the six embankments fanned out behind her like the rings inside a felled tree, except a tree doesn't decide to grow in arcs, and these had decided. Somebody had decided. The grass had grown soft over the decision and the cattle of three centuries of farms had grazed it and the river had tried, a few times, to take it back, and the arcs were still arcs. You could stand in the middle of the plaza and feel the geometry waiting under your shoes, patient, like a held breath.

The footnote said: *The function of the embankments remains unresolved.*

Twenty-eight years old, that footnote, and Marisol had now read its descendants in eleven later papers, each one rephrasing it, none of them killing it. That was the thing about a good unanswered question. It propagated. It put down roots in the bibliography and you could trace it forward like a watermark, *unresolved, unresolved, the function remains*, all the way to the laminated panel at the visitor center that said, in friendly sans-serif, *We may never fully know why Poverty Point was built.*

She liked that panel. It was honest in a way that cost the state nothing and gave the visitor everything. Most places lied to you in the gift shop. This one handed you the hole and let you hold it.

"You found the post rings yet," said a voice, and Marisol didn't startle, because she'd heard the truck on the gravel four minutes ago and clocked the door, the boots, the unhurried cross of the grass.

Dr. Adeline Boudreaux came up the ridge with two coffees and the manner of someone who had walked this slope ten thousand times and would not be hurried by anybody's schedule, least of all a film crew's. She handed Marisol a cup. State-site archaeologist; her people had been in this parish since before the parish had a name in any language Marisol could read.

"The magnetometry," Marisol said. "The 1990s survey. The post circles in the plaza." She tapped the report. "Twenty-five to sixty-three meters across. Concentric. Somebody set up rings of wooden posts in the open ground and then took them down, or let them rot, and the only reason we know is the magnetic ghost in the dirt."

"Mm." Boudreaux drank her coffee. "Go on."

It was a test. Marisol knew it was a test, and she also knew that the way you passed Boudreaux's tests was not by being clever. It was by being accurate. The archivist's whole life had been learning the difference, sitting in the back of rooms where being clever got you noticed and being accurate got you ignored, and choosing the ignored thing every time because the ignored thing was true.

"Nobody knows what the posts were for," Marisol said. "There's a calendar argument — that you'd watch a sunrise come up through a gap, season to season. There's a roofed-building argument. There's a we-don't-know argument, which is most of them." She looked at the older woman. "The astronomy's contested. Haag put the center of the site one place, Purrington put it another, and once you move the center you move every alignment that hangs off it. So you can prove a solstice line if you get to pick where you're standing."

Boudreaux almost smiled. "That's the trick of it. Pick where you stand, you can prove anything. The sun comes up somewhere every morning." She gestured with the cup at the plaza, the grey light going gold at its edges. "You point a stick at it long enough, eventually it'll line up with something. Doesn't mean the people who set the stick cared about your line."

The rest of the crew came up the ridge in their own ways. Tomas first, the young engineer, walking the embankment crest heel-to-toe and counting his paces under his breath, mapping the arc into numbers because numbers were where he lived. Then the Lens, hanging back, camera down at his hip, not raised — he'd been not-raising it for two days now, which Marisol had learned to read as the deepest kind of attention. And last, easy, hands in pockets, the MONEY — they didn't like the title but it had stuck — Devi, who came up the slope already reading the parking lot behind them.

"Black Suburban at the gate," Devi said. "Not local plates. That's the consortium's man, or his lawyer, and either way they're early." A beat. "People who are early want something."

"They always want something," Boudreaux said mildly.

Tomas reached them, still counting, then stopped and looked out over the plaza with the particular hunger he got when a thing refused to resolve. "I ran the numbers again last night," he said, to nobody, to all of them. "Mound A. Two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters. If you say ninety days — Kidder's outside number, the slow one — and you say twelve hours of daylight, and a basket holds, generously, twenty kilos of wet loess —"

"Tomas," Devi said gently.

"— then you need roughly three million basket-loads. In ninety days. That's better than three hundred thousand a day. That's three hundred and fifty thousand baskets *every day for three months*, carried, dumped, packed, and nobody's basket touched the ground long enough between loads for the rain to make a crust on it. Because there is no crust." He turned to Boudreaux, and there was something almost pleading in it, the literal mind up against a wall the literal mind couldn't climb. "Kidder cut the mound open. He looked for the weather. The little wash-lines, the silt skins, the places where a rain came through and a crew knocked off and the surface sat exposed for a season. In a thing this size you'd see a dozen of them. He found none. *None*. Not a single pause."

"I know," Boudreaux said. "I've stood in that trench."

"Then how —"

"That's the wrong how." She said it kindly. "You're asking how the

labor works. The labor's the easy part, son. People move dirt. They've always moved dirt. Give me enough hands and a reason and I'll move you a mountain." She set her coffee on the grass and crouched, and pressed two fingers into the soil of the ridge, the soil they were all sitting on, three thousand years of it holding its shape. "The hard part isn't the how. The hard part you already named and walked right past."

Marisol felt it land in her chest before her mouth caught up. "The reason."

Boudreaux looked at her, and this time the smile came all the way. "There she is."

The Lens was photographing the soil now — Boudreaux's two fingers in the dirt, the press-marks, the grass. He worked close and quiet. Marisol had noticed he only raised the camera for the small true things, never the grand ones; he'd shot the cooking balls in the visitor case and the cattle-print in the levee mud and the back of Boudreaux's neck when she laughed, and he'd left the great mound alone the whole time they'd been here, as if it were a person who hadn't consented.

"Here's what I keep coming back to," Marisol said, and she heard her own voice go careful, the way it went when she was carrying something heavy across a frozen pond. "There's no king. That's the thing nobody puts on the panel right. We talk about no agriculture, no writing, no wheel, and those are real, those matter. But the one that won't let me sleep is — there's no chief."

"Go on," Boudreaux said. Again. The road she kept opening.

"To raise that mound in a season you need thousands of people in one place at one time. You need them fed. You need somebody saying *dirt goes here, not there*, day after day, three hundred thousand baskets a day. Every state we know that did anything like this had a guy. A palace, a granary, a tomb with the good grave goods. A throne the next one fought over." She spread her hands. "Here? Nothing. No palace under the ridges. No royal burial. No granary because no grain. The leadership, the papers say, was 'situational.' It came together for the thing and then it dissolved. Thousands of people

organized themselves into the largest earthwork in the hemisphere and then — went home. And nobody made themselves king off the back of it. Nobody turned the gathering into a crown.”

She stopped. The plaza was full gold now.

“So what called them,” Marisol said. “What was strong enough to pull thousands of people across a continent — because the stone’s from a thousand kilometers away, the network’s *real*, the detail’s argued but the reach isn’t — what pulled them here, and kept them here, and fed them, and bent their backs for a summer, and asked nothing of a king, and let them all walk away?”

Nobody answered. The Lens had lowered the camera entirely. Tomas had stopped counting.

“What was it *for*,” Marisol said, and the question hung over the rings like the held breath of the geometry itself.

Boudreaux stood. She brushed the dirt from her fingers, slow, and looked out at the place — her place, her people’s place, the ground that held its shape because somebody three thousand years gone had known to mix the soils so the rain couldn’t take them, had engineered a hill to outlast every empire that came after with all their writing and their wheels and their kings, the kind of knowing you didn’t get from a chief, the kind you only got from a crowd that had done it together and meant it.

“You want me to tell you,” she said.

“Yes,” said three of them at once, and Marisol heard her own voice in the chord and felt the heat of it in her face, the wanting, naked.

Boudreaux laughed. Not unkindly. The way you laugh at someone you’ve decided to like.

“You came a long way to be told a thing.” She picked her coffee back up. “Most folks do. They come and they stand in the plaza and they feel that —” she nodded at the held-breath quiet “— and it scares them a little, and they want a name for it, because a named thing can’t scare you. A calendar. A temple. A trade fair. An observatory. Pick one, write it on the panel, go home. The not-knowing’s the thing they can’t stand.”

She drank.

“My grandmother walked these ridges. Her grandmother. We’ve been telling each other about this place a long time, and you know what we don’t do?” The smile again, warm and absolute and shut as a door. “We don’t tell it to be solved. There’s things I know about why people gather and walk away with nothing in their hands but each other. And there’s things I’ll set right when your panel gets it wrong. But that question you just asked me, with your whole face — *what was it for* —”

She let it sit.

“That one’s mine to keep,” Boudreaux said. “And it’s yours to wonder. That’s not me being cagey. That’s the most honest thing in West Carroll Parish. We know *how*. God, do we know how — the dirt’s in the trench, the math’s in Kidder’s paper, the post rings are right under your feet, you can go count them. The *how* is the marvel and it’s all yours, take it, film it, tell the world organized people with no king built a mountain in a summer and meant something so much by it they didn’t even need a crown to remember it.”

She started back down the ridge. Stopped. Turned.

“The *why* I’ll let you carry home empty-handed. It’s the better thing to take.”

And there it was — the wink, except she didn’t wink, that wasn’t her register; she just looked at Marisol a half-second too long, the look that said *you already know I’m not going to tell you, and you already know that’s the gift*, and then she walked down to her truck.

The Lens raised the camera, finally, and got her back as she went — and the plaza behind her, the rings, the long gold light — one frame, the only grand thing he’d shot the whole trip, and Marisol understood he’d been waiting for exactly this: not the place answered, but the place *unanswered* and somebody walking away unbothered by it.

“Three million baskets,” Tomas said quietly, to the grass. “And we don’t get to know what for.”

“No,” Marisol said. “We don’t.” And she found, to her own surprise, that she wasn’t grieving it. The footnote had been right for twenty-

eight years. *The function remains.* It remained, and the remaining was load-bearing, the remaining held the whole thing up the way the mixed soils held the mound.

Devi's phone went off.

They watched Devi read it — watched the read travel across the fixer's face, the small recalibration, the thing Devi did where they took a number apart to see what it was hiding. Devi had read grift off a glossy proposal their first afternoon here. Devi had said *people who are early want something* an hour ago, light, almost a joke.

"It's the consortium," Devi said. The phone went face-down on the grass, the way you set down a card you didn't like. "The man at the gate. He's not negotiating anymore."

"What does that mean," said the Lens.

"It means they ran the math too." Devi looked up at the mound, at the plaza, at the held breath. "Their man at the state house, the jobs number, the interpretive-center pitch — all of that was the soft open. This is the offer." A breath. "They've put a figure on the table that the parish has never seen in its life. Enough to fund the field station for a generation. Enough to fix every road between here and Epps. Enough that the community votes yes by Friday unless somebody gives them a reason not to."

"For what," Marisol said. "What do they get for it."

Devi picked the phone back up, turned it face-up, read the last line again, and when they spoke the outsider's clarity was all the way in their voice, cold and exact, the wiring that had spent a lifetime watching every room it was barely welcome in.

"They get to be the ones who tell people what it was for."

The plaza held its breath. Down at the gate, the Suburban's engine turned over.

Chapter 18 — The Custodian's Choice

The vote was set for seven, in the parish meeting hall on the road into Epps, and Mara Boudreaux spent the last hour of daylight walking the outer ridge with no camera but mine on her.

She hadn't asked me to come. She hadn't told me not to, either, which with Mara amounted to permission. I kept the lens down, the way the work had been teaching me to keep it down, slung at my hip with the cap on, and I let the light do what it wanted with the grass.

The outermost ridge runs about a kilometer and a quarter across, a great C of low swells you'd drive past as natural relief if you didn't know. That was the first thing the consortium's man had said, the very first day, with real affection in it: *you wouldn't even know*. He'd meant it as a problem to solve. Make the invisible visible. Build the boardwalk, the light show, the gift shop with the loess cooking balls cast in resin so a child could hold one. Unlock it. He believed in unlocking the way some men believe in a clean shave — a small daily decency owed to the world.

Mara stopped where the ridge crested and put her boot heel into the turf, not hard, just resting it there the way you'd rest a hand on a horse's flank.

"You can shoot the field," she said. "Not me. Not tonight."

"I know."

"Do you." She wasn't unkind about it. She was reading me the way she read everything — the soil, the survey lines, the consortium's smiling

proposal — for what it was underneath the surface it showed. “Your hands want it. I watched you all week wanting it.”

That was true and I didn't argue. A war taught me to want the frame that hurts, and a long convalescence had only changed which hurts I reached for. Here it was the wanting itself she was warning me off. Not the picture. The taking.

We'd spent the week learning how the place was made, and the official story is a clean one, and I'd come to love it the way you love a thing that turns out to be braver than the legend.

The legend wants kings. The legend always wants kings, because a mountain needs a man to command it into being, and 238,000 cubic meters of earth — Mound A, twenty-two meters of it, bird-shaped if you trust the eye that wants a bird — feels like the kind of thing you order built. The skeptics, bless them, took the kings away and left the marvel standing. You don't need a pharaoh, they said. You need a crowd and a reason. Hunter-fisher-gatherers. No farms. No grain stores, no ranked lords, no heir waiting in the wings to inherit the throne, because there was no throne. People who fished and foraged and traded for stone that came from a thousand kilometers off, and who one season decided, all of them, to lift a hill.

Tobias — the engineer, our pattern-hunter, the one who'll hyperfocus on a basket-load equation until the sun goes round — had loved that part too much and trusted it too far. Early in the week he'd done the arithmetic on a legal pad, the way he does, talking himself through it. Thirty-to-fifty-pound loads. Call it forty. Divide the volume, multiply by the density of compacted loess, parcel it out among a workforce you generously imagine at two thousand strong working a full day.

“Doable,” he'd announced. “Tight, but doable. Ninety days.”

So we'd tried it. That's the work. You don't get to say *doable* and walk away; Jakobus won't let you. We borrowed baskets, the real woven kind, and a measured cube of ground staked off by Mara's grad students, and we moved dirt under a Louisiana July with healthy backs and a plan and full daylight.

The hill grew slow. That's the part the legal pad can't hold. The gumbo clay grabbed the spade and gave it back grudging. By the

second hour the baskets had stopped being forty pounds in your head and become forty pounds in your spine, and the geometry that's so obedient on paper turned mean — you can't all dig the same hole, you trip each other, you wait, you carry up a slope that the day before was flat and is now a slope because you made it one, and every step up costs you the step you didn't have to take yesterday. Sweat ran into Tobias's eyes and he kept the count out loud because counting is how he holds the world together, and the count fell behind the plan, and fell behind it again.

That's the potato. The official story is *they carried it in baskets*, four ordinary words, and when you put the basket on your own shoulder the four words open up into a chasm. Not impossible. The consensus is firm and I won't pretend otherwise — organized foragers, extraordinary but human, no magic in it. Doable. It's just that *doable* and *done* are separated by a season of other people's pain, and standing in that staked-off square with my shirt ruined I understood for the first time the size of the thing they'd agreed to.

And here's where Kidder comes in, and where the chasm gets its echo.

Tristram Kidder, Washington University, went into Mound A not to dig it down but to read its layers like a manuscript. Microstratigraphy. You look at the seams between fill episodes — the place where one team's baskets stopped and the next began — and you look for the small betrayals of time. A rain-washed surface. A crust where a layer sat exposed and weathered. A root, a worm-churn, the signature of a pause.

He didn't find them.

No weathering surfaces. No rain-wash. No crust of an abandoned summer, no scar of a winter waited out. Layer on layer with nothing between them but the next layer, which means the thing was raised in one breath. A matter of months. Possibly thirty to ninety days. The whole twenty-two meters, all that basket-borne loess, lifted in a single relentless push with no pause long enough for the sky to leave a mark on it.

So sit with the two facts at once, the way the work asks you to. Move

the dirt yourself and learn how slow it goes. Then read Kidder and learn it didn't go slow at all. The crowd they needed was enormous and the reason had to be enough to hold that crowd, fed — with no granary — and working, with no overseer's whip in the record, no palace where the planning happened, no name carved anywhere to say *I made them do it*.

You feel the draught come off that gap. A society with no chiefs, no crops, and no writing summoned thousands, fed them, raised a mountain in a summer.

And then walked away.

The archivist — quiet, footnote-haunted, the one who reads what everyone else skips — had found me on the ridge two evenings before, holding a printout the way you'd hold something warm.

"The soil," she said. "It's not just dirt they piled up. They mixed it."

That's the engineering, and it's the part that ought to be on every postcard. The builders chose their fills and blended them — deliberately — to manage the shrink and swell that wrecks ordinary earthworks, to shed water, to resist the erosion that should have melted this place back into the floodplain three thousand years ago. Kidder reaches for Roman concrete to describe it. Chinese rammed earth. A hill engineered to *stay*. And it has stayed; the river that's always at the door, the rain that takes everything in this country eventually, and Mound A has held its form across three millennia with hardly a wrinkle.

"They built it to last," the archivist said, and her voice did something I'd not heard it do. "They built it to last and then they left it."

The fish in me wanted to heckle — *who engineers a monument they're about to abandon?* — and I let the fish have its line and then I let it go, because that's the deal. You find the one hole. You wink at it. You don't reach past it toward little grey men or lost Atlantises; the consensus floor is solid and the residue is honest enough on its own. The residue is just this: the care. You don't take that care with soil you mean to walk away from. Unless walking away was always the point.

The hall filled early. Folding chairs, a coffee urn, the consortium's man in a good shirt with the sleeves rolled to show he was one of us, which he wasn't, but he believed he was, and that belief was the most dangerous thing in the room. Naomi — our money, our fixer, the one whose wiring never lets her stop watching the room — had clocked him on day one and never unlocked him. She sat near the back where she could see the doors and the donors both. She'd read the proposal the way Kidder read the mound, layer by layer, looking for the seam.

"It's a good offer," she'd told me, flat, in the diner. "That's the trap. It's a genuinely good offer. Funding when the state's cutting funding. Jobs in a parish that needs them. He's not lying about any of it." She'd turned her water glass a quarter turn, the way she does when the shape of a thing is bothering her. "The strings aren't in the money. They're in the telling. *Interpretive center*. That means somebody picks the story. *Curated access*. That means somebody picks who walks the ridge. He buys the dirt cheap. The thing he's actually taking is the right to say what it's for."

That was the consortium's whole tender, stripped: pay for the ground, own the meaning. Cast the cooking balls in resin and sell the wonder back across the counter.

Jakobus stood by the wall, off his home ground as he always is, hat in his two hands. He'd spent the week with his palms on the engineered soil, telling us in that gravel voice how a made thing tells you its purpose if you'll shut up and feel it. *This was built to stay*, he'd said, and then — because he never takes the lead, never holds more of the moment than the people who own it — he'd handed it straight to Mara. *What it stayed for, that's hers*. He nodded to her now across the hall and said nothing, which from Jakobus is a whole sentence.

Mara went to the front. No notes.

She talked about the build first, the official story, dead straight, and she gave the skeptics their full due and the builders their full love. No kings. No crops. A crowd and a reason. The baskets, the mixed soil, the hill in a season. She laid out Kidder's layers, the missing weather, the single breath. She is the one who out-reads all of us; she grew up walking this ground and her people walked it before the survey lines, and when she spoke the marvel it had weight under it that none of

our printouts could give.

Then someone — a man near the front, kind-faced, genuinely curious — asked the question everyone wanted, the one the consortium would have paid good money to put on a plaque.

“So what *was* it for? What called them all here?”

The room leaned in. I felt my own hands tighten on the capped lens at my hip and made them ease.

Mara let the silence sit. She has a way of letting silence sit that isn't a pause for effect — it's her deciding, in real time, in front of you, how much of a thing is hers to give.

“We know how they built it,” she said. “We can show you the baskets and the math and the soil they chose on purpose so the rain couldn't have it. We know they came from a long way. We know they fed themselves without a single field, and they raised that mound in a summer, and that nobody's name is on it.” She looked at the man, and then past him, at all of us, the consortium's good shirt included. “What called them here — and why they stopped — I'm not going to stand up and sell you an answer to that. Because I don't have one. And because the not-having is part of what we've been keeping.”

She didn't soften it. The consortium's man started to nod, the agreeable nod he used to absorb objections, and she watched the nod and didn't give him anything to absorb.

“Some of what we know,” she said, “we don't put on a sign. That's not a deficiency in the exhibit. That's the exhibit doing its job. The minute you can buy the answer at the counter, you've turned the question into a souvenir. And the question's the thing they left us. Not the dirt. The question.”

Naomi, at the back, went very still, which is how Naomi smiles.

The vote, when it came, wasn't loud. This isn't a country that does its deciding loud. They did it by raised hands and a count, the parish way, and the count went the way Mara's silence had pointed.

Preservation. Not the boardwalk. Not the resin cooking balls. Not the right to say what it was for, sold off with the topsoil. The ground

stays the parish's and the state's and the descendant community's, and the story stays open, which is to say it stays alive, which is to say it stays theirs to give or withhold to whoever comes next with a printout and a good shirt and a wish to unlock it.

The consortium's man took it well. That's the thing about a clean-handed adversary — he shook hands, he meant the handshake, he'll be back somewhere else next quarter believing in the next unlocking. He wasn't a cabal. He was a man who couldn't feel the difference between a question and a vacancy, and so wanted to fill it, and the parish had just told him, gently, that the vacancy was full.

Outside, the dark had come down thick and the cicadas had the field. Mara stood on the steps a moment before going to her truck. I had the lens at my hip, cap on, and she saw me see it.

"You can shoot the field now," she said. "Not me. The field."

So I did. I turned to the great low dark swell of the outermost ridge, invisible to anyone who didn't know, a kilometer and a quarter of held earth that a summer's crowd had raised and engineered and walked away from, on purpose, three thousand years ago, leaving it to stay and to ask.

I made one frame. The light was almost nothing. That was right. Some of what's there doesn't go on the sign.

Chapter 19 — Handoff

The vans were packed wrong and I knew it. The Lens always loaded by feel — heavy cases low, soft bags wedged into the gaps like he was packing a wound — and it worked, it always worked, but it offended the part of me that wants weight distributed where the numbers say. I stood in the gravel lot with my clipboard and let it go. We were leaving. You can win the loading argument or you can leave on time. Not both, not with this crew.

Dawn over West Carroll Parish comes up the color of weak tea and then, all at once, decides to mean it. The ridges threw long shadows across the mown grass — those six nested C's you can only really see from the air or from the inside of your own patience, walking them. From the lot they're just swells. Polite green undulations. A man could mow them on a riding mower and never know he was crossing three thousand years per pass.

Two hundred and thirty-eight thousand cubic meters. I'd carried that number for ninety days myself, in my own way. I'd done the spreadsheet the consortium never let me see, the one I built backward out of their proposal — projected gate receipts, the interpretive-center burn rate, the “experiential ticketing tiers.” I read money the way the Lens reads light: it's the thing I cannot not see. And the money here had wanted to wear the wonder like a borrowed coat.

It hadn't gotten the coat. The community vote had come in three days ago, and the consortium's lead — charming to the last, genuinely sad in a way I didn't doubt — had shaken every hand on his way to the rental car. *Unlocking value*, he'd called it. He believed it. That was the part that kept me up. Not villains. A pleasant man with a real conviction that a thing left open is a thing left wasted.

The fish — the little plastic one suction-cupped to the dash of the lead van, the one the engineer named Bartholomew and talks to — caught the morning and looked, as it always did, like it had an opinion. *Oh, you read money*, it seemed to say. *Tell me about the ROI on a mountain nobody charged admission to.*

Shut up, Bartholomew.

Dr. Antoine came across the lot with two coffees and a third balanced in the crook of her arm, which is a magic trick, and handed them out without asking how anyone took it. She'd been right about everyone's coffee for ninety days. It was one of the smaller ways she out-read us. The state archaeologist, rooted here four generations deep on her mother's side, who had spent two months pointing us at soil cores and post-ring magnetometry and the cooking balls that turn up in the dirt like baked-clay knuckles — and deflecting, gently, every single time the engineer asked her *but why*.

"You're leaving early," she said. "Smart. The heat today's going to be a sermon."

"We're leaving on the Lens's loading schedule," I said. "Which is to say, by feel, and approximately."

She smiled at that. She'd taken the Lens's measure on day one — clocked the way he framed the empty plaza instead of the mound, the way he photographed absence. She never once asked him to lower the camera. She just stood where he could see her and let him decide.

"Walk with me before you go," she said. "Not all of you. You."

The engineer's face did a thing. He'd wanted the *why* more than any of us, hyperfocused on it for nine weeks, building basket-load models in a spreadsheet so dense it crashed his laptop twice. He'd earned a walk. But Dr. Antoine had said *you*, to me, and that was hers to decide, and the engineer — bless his literal, pattern-shaped heart — understood that better than most people understand anything. He nodded once and went to argue with the Lens about case placement instead.

The archivist looked up from her footnotes long enough to catch my

eye. She'd found the Haag-versus-Purrington thing in week six — two serious men who couldn't even agree where the *center* of the site was, let alone what the sun did over it. She didn't say anything. She just wrote it down, the way she writes everything down, so that someday someone reaching for the truth would at least have the disagreement intact.

Dr. Antoine took me out along the outermost ridge, the one that runs three-quarters of a mile in its great broken circle. The grass was wet through the boots inside ten steps. Somewhere out past the cane a heron complained about the hour.

"You know the build now," she said. It wasn't a question. "Tell me the part that bothers you."

I'd been ready for this since the vote. I'd rehearsed it, which is a thing I do, which is a thing that makes me good at the money and bad at being surprised.

"The microstratigraphy," I said. "Kidder's cores. Mound A, twenty-two meters of fill, and between the fill episodes — nothing. No rain-wash. No weathering surface. No little crust of dirt that says *here is where we stopped for the winter*. You don't get that gap by accident. You get it by not stopping." I heard my own voice do the thing it does when the numbers are clean and terrible. "Months. Thirty to ninety days, he says. A mountain. By hand. Baskets, thirty to fifty pounds. No wheel, no animals, no metal. And the soils mixed on purpose — shrink-swell controlled, the whole thing engineered to shed water for three thousand years, and it *has*, it's barely eroded, Kidder puts it next to Roman concrete—"

"And?"

"And that's the marvel. The skeptics are right. You don't need kings. You don't need farms. You need a big enough crowd and a reason." I stopped on the ridge crest. From up there, just barely, you could feel the geometry under your feet — the deliberateness of it, the *plan*. "But here's where my spreadsheet goes sideways, Doctor. I model the crowd. Thousands of people. I've fed crowds. I've moved crowds — festivals, evacuations, the worst job I ever had was a music thing in the Free State. You cannot feed three thousand people for ninety

days on a floodplain off wild plants and fish and deer without a system. Granaries. Stores. Somebody saying *you, dig; you, cook; you, haul*. Somebody at the top of the basket chain doing the math."

"And you find that somebody where, in the ground?"

"That's the hole." I looked at her. "Nowhere. No palace. No big house. No chief's burial dripping with grave goods. No bureaucracy you can dig up. The leadership, the books say, was *situational*. *Ritual. Dissolved after the event*." I let the words sit because they're absurd and beautiful at once. "You raised a mountain in a summer with no boss, and then everybody put down their baskets and went home, and nobody wrote down how, and nobody made their kid keep doing it. No heir. No throne. The whole thing just—" I opened my hand. "—walks away."

The heron got up out of the cane, all elbows, and rowed off toward the bayou.

"That's a good telling," Dr. Antoine said. "That's the best one I've heard a visitor give in a long time. You read the absence. Most people only read the mound."

"It's what I do. I read where the money isn't." I laughed, a little, at myself. "Usually it's somebody hiding it. Here it's just — gone. Or never made. I can't tell which, and that's worse."

She was quiet long enough that I thought she was going to deflect again, the way she had for nine weeks, hand me back to the engineering and let me admire the soil. She had every right. The *why* was hers. I'd made my peace with not getting it. That's the contract you don't get to read but you sign anyway: the place is theirs, the telling is theirs, and you carry your tape and your tripod and your spreadsheet, and you leave with exactly what they choose to hand you. I'd come to take a story. The community had voted not to be taken. That should've been the whole lesson and I should've shut up and driven the van.

But she stopped walking.

"My grandmother's people are from over toward Epps," Dr. Antoine said. "And there's a thing she did, that her mother did, that I'd bet

money goes back further than anybody can prove and so I won't claim it — I'm an archaeologist, I don't get to claim things I can't core." A dry look. "When there was a death, or a marriage, or a flood that took the bottom land, the whole connection came in. Cousins you forgot you had. People drove eleven hours. And they cooked, and they argued about cooking, and they raised something — a meal that fed two hundred, or a house, or a tent revival big enough to be seen from the highway — and they did it fast and they did it together and then they *left*. And nobody was in charge. My uncle would tell you *he* was in charge. He was not in charge."

I didn't move. You don't move when somebody is deciding how much to hand you.

"You keep looking for the man at the top of the basket chain," she said. "Because in your world somebody is always at the top of the chain, and if you can't find him he's hiding. I'm telling you maybe there wasn't a chain. Maybe there was a *reason*, and the reason was enough, and people will do astonishing arithmetic when the reason is enough and nobody's making them. You've felt it. You said it yourself — the worst job you ever had, the festival." She tipped her head. "Was it the worst because of the crowd? Or because somebody was charging at the gate and the math had a man at the top?"

The fish, two hundred yards away in the van, did not need to say anything. I heard it anyway.

"I'm not going to tell you what it was for," she said, and her voice was kind and absolutely closed, a door shutting on oiled hinges. "Partly because that's ours, and partly — and you can write this down — because I don't know. We know how they built it. The cores tell us *how* and they tell us *how fast* and they will not tell us *why* and they will not tell us why everybody put their baskets down and didn't pick them back up. Kidder doesn't know. Haag and Purrington can't even agree where to stand to ask the sky about it." She almost smiled. "We don't get the why. That's not a failure. That's the *shape* of the thing. The why is the part that walked away."

"That's not an answer," I said.

"No," she agreed. "It's a function." She turned and looked back across the ridges, across the whole impossible circle of it, and I followed her eyes. "Here's the one I'll hand you, and then you load your

van. It's a place where people came together to do something larger than any one of them, and dissolved the doing when it was done, and left the *evidence that it could be done* sitting on the floodplain for three thousand years, water-proof, boss-proof, almost erosion-proof. That's not a city. That's not an observatory, whatever the alignment people want. It's a *proof*. A thing that holds its shape to tell you the shape was possible."

She handed me the empty coffee cup, like a punctuation mark.

"Your consortium man wanted to unlock the value," she said. "He kept saying it. I almost felt sorry for him. He was standing on a monument built by people who didn't lock the value up in the first place. There was nothing to unlock. They left the door open. That's the whole point. You can't sell an open door."

We walked back the way the ridges curved, and she didn't say anything else about it, and I knew better than to ask. She'd handed me what she'd decided to hand me and held what was hers to hold, and the difference between those two things was the most honest transaction I'd been part of in years.

At the vans the engineer had won the loading argument by sheer attrition and the Lens had let him, which meant the weight was wrong and the doors would close and we'd drive five hundred miles wedged against the laws of physics, and it would be fine. The archivist had her notebook open on the hood, copying something one last time — the citation for the cores, I think, getting the volume number right so that the disagreement would survive intact for whoever came reaching after us.

The Lens had his camera up. Pointed at the plaza. At nothing — at the mown empty middle of it where the buried post rings sleep under the grass, twenty-five to sixty-three meters across, circles of wood that rotted out three thousand years ago and left their shape behind like the negative of a sound. He'd been photographing the absence the whole time. I finally got it.

"You ready?" the engineer asked me.

"What was it for?" he added, because he could never not ask, and because he'd earned it.

I looked at Dr. Antoine. She looked back, and she did not blink, and the door stayed exactly as open and exactly as shut as she'd made it.

"She told me what it holds," I said. "She didn't tell me why."

"That's not an answer," the engineer said, frowning, building the model in his head and watching it not close.

"No," I said. "It's the shape of one."

I got in the van. Bartholomew the fish stared at me from the dash, smug, plastic, eternal, a thing that does not move earth and never will. I started the engine. Behind us the ridges held their three-thousand-year curve, water shedding off the engineered soil exactly the way the people who walked away had meant it to, the proof still sitting on the floodplain that the thing could be done — by anyone, together, fast, for a reason large enough, and then set down.

We pulled out onto the parish road. In the mirror the mound caught the full morning at last, twenty-two meters of it, holding its shape, holding its silence, holding the why like a stone in a closed hand.

I didn't ask again. It wasn't mine.

I drove.

Chapter 20 — The Residue of Wonder

The storm came up out of the southwest the way it always did, a bruise spreading over the cane fields, and by four o'clock the light had gone the color of weak tea. Naomi watched it from the bench outside the field station, the same bench where she'd read the consortium's first proposal three weeks back, the one with the gold-foil letterhead and the rendering of a parking lot that didn't exist yet. The proposal was gone now. Voted down in a community hall that smelled of coffee and floor wax, by people who'd lived within sight of these ridges their whole lives and had not needed a rendering to know what the place was worth.

So that part was over. The MONEY-read was settled. Naomi had spent her professional life pricing the angle of a thing, the place where the smile met the spreadsheet, and Daniel Voss — charming, sincere, genuinely heartbroken that nobody would let him save the site by selling it — had finally folded his easel and driven his rental back toward the interstate. He'd shaken her hand. He'd meant it. That was the part that always got under her skin, the meaning-it. The grift she could read in the dark. The belief was harder.

What wasn't settled was everything else.

"You're sulking," said Priya, dropping down beside her with two paper cups of the station's terrible coffee.

"I'm reflecting."

"That's the same face."

Out across the plaza the ridges ran in their long shallow arcs, six of

them nested like ripples frozen at the moment of being thrown — the outermost a kilometer and change across, the whole thing too big to see at once from the ground, a shape you had to take on faith or take from the air. The grass on them had gone silver where the wind turned it. Mound A sat off to the west, the bird-shape if you wanted the bird-shape, a green hill seventy feet up out of a floodplain that had no business holding a hill at all.

Three thousand years. Naomi kept coming back to that number the way the tongue comes back to a tooth. The river had wanted this ground back for three thousand years and hadn't gotten it.

Eli came across the grass with the magnetometer cart, towing it like a reluctant dog, and parked it by the bench because Eli parked things wherever the thought that was carrying him happened to stop.

"The post rings," he said, to no one, to all of them. "Twenty-five meters. Sixty-three meters. They sank big timbers in the plaza, circles of them, and then" — his hands made a small disappearing — "took them out. Or they rotted. Either way, no posts now. Just the holes, where the dirt remembers being disturbed."

"You've said that four times today," Priya said, not unkindly.

"It's a good fact." He sat on the grass instead of the bench. "You raise a circle of posts you can't roof. You don't live inside it. You put it up, you take it down. That's work for the work's sake, unless it's work for something you can't dig up."

The fish, if there'd been a fish, would have said: *or they liked posts*. Naomi heard it anyway. She'd been hearing it the whole three weeks, the heckle from the cheap seats, the voice that kept the wonder honest — *sure, sure, a mountain in ninety days, and I suppose nobody complained about the catering*. You needed that voice. The minute you lost it you started seeing chariots of the gods in a perfectly good pile of beautifully engineered dirt.

Because that was the thing. The dirt was the marvel, and the dirt was enough.

They had tried it themselves, in week one, before the soil cores and the citations, back when the official story still sounded like a thing you could simply *do*. No kings, the story went. No crops. No metal, no wheel, no animal bigger than a man to pull a load. Just baskets — woven baskets, thirty to fifty pounds of fill apiece — and people. A lot of people. You didn't need a pharaoh. You needed a crowd and a reason, and the crowd did the rest, hand to hand to hand.

So the crew had borrowed baskets and marked off a square and tried to move earth the honest way, by daylight, with plans and healthy backs and a cooler of Gatorade the Late Archaic had conspicuously lacked.

The hill had grown slow. That was the whole of it, and it was humbling in a way Naomi hadn't expected. You bend, you fill, you lift, you walk, you tip, you walk back. Your thirty pounds becomes thirty-five with the sweat soaked in. Eli had run the numbers that night and the numbers had gone sideways the way they always did: 238,000 cubic meters, basket by basket, even with thousands of bodies working sunup to sundown, was a quantity of human effort that did not want to fit inside the word *months*. The math kept asking for years. The dirt kept saying no.

Because the dirt was the part that didn't argue.

The custodian found them like that — Naomi reflecting, Priya pretending not to, Eli on the grass with his post rings, and Tomas a little way off with the camera at his side, not raised. The LENS had stopped raising it as fast as he used to. That was its own kind of weather report. Some days the war was loud in him and the camera lived at his eye like a shield; other days it hung from the strap and he just *looked*, which was harder and which the rest of them had quietly learned to read as good.

Dr. Marguerite Bordelon had a way of arriving that wasn't an entrance. She was state-site, she was of the descendant community here, she had answered their questions for three weeks with a generosity that had teeth in it — she gave them the engineering and held the meaning the way you hold a door half-closed, deciding.

"Y'all look like you lost something," she said.

"We won," Naomi said. "Voss is gone. The vote held."

"You won the thing you came to win." Marguerite settled against the cart, arms folded, watching the storm-light walk across her mound. "Now you're stuck with the thing nobody wins."

Eli looked up. "The construction sequence. Kidder's cores."

"Tell me, then." She said it the way a teacher says it, already knowing, wanting to hear how far the student had walked. The §3 of it — she could out-read every one of them on this ground in her sleep, and they all knew it, and the asking was a kindness, not a test.

So Eli told her. The microstratigraphy from Mound A: you cut down through the fill and you read it like a book, layer by layer, and what you look for between the layers is a *surface* — a skin of weathered dirt, a wash of rainwater silt, a band of roots, anything that says *time passed here, this lay open to the sky for a season before the next basket landed*. And in twenty-two vertical meters of hand-carried earth, Kidder and his people had found —

"Nothing," Eli said. "No weathering surfaces. No rain-wash. No pause." His hands, flat, stacked themselves with no air between. "It went up wet. Layer on layer on layer with no time for the sky to touch it. A matter of months. Maybe ninety days. Maybe less."

"And your baskets said?" Marguerite asked.

"Our baskets said it can't be done in ninety days."

"And the ground says it was."

"Yes."

She nodded slowly, like this was the right place to be standing. "There's your hole. You feel it?"

They felt it. The two true things sitting in the same field, refusing to dissolve each other. The labor-math that wanted years. The mud-record that gave months. Both checkable. Both real. Both stubborn as the river.

"It's not magic," Priya said, and she said it firmly, the archivist setting a footnote like a fence post. "I want that on the record. Roman

concrete isn't magic. Rammed earth isn't magic. Kidder says it himself — what they did to the soil, mixing it deliberate so it wouldn't shrink and swell, so it wouldn't slump in the first wet season — that's engineering. They knew dirt. They knew this dirt." She gestured at the mound, three thousand years of held shape. "It's still here because they understood materials better than half the contractors in my street."

"No argument," Marguerite said.

"So the wonder isn't *how*. We know how. Baskets, bodies, soil sense, a season."

"We know how," Marguerite agreed.

"It's everything around the how."

And there it was, laid in the grass between them with the storm coming on.

You could explain the basket. You could explain the soil chemistry, the shrink-swell, the erosion math, the way they salted one borrow-pit's clay into another's loess to make a fill that would not wash. The skeptics were right and the engineers were right and the wonder didn't shrink an inch, because the explained part only sharpened the unexplained part to a point.

A society with no chiefs. No farms. No granary to feed a standing crowd, no king to command one, no writing to send the call out across a continent — and stone in the dirt here from a thousand kilometers away, from sources scattered over half a continent, the network real even where the exact roads of it stayed argued-over in the journals. Somehow that scattered, hierarchy-less, harvest-less world had reached out across enormous distance and *gathered*. Pulled thousands of people to one wet bend of the Mississippi floodplain. Fed them — on what, on fish and nuts and the baked loess cooking balls they still turned up in the dirt by the bucketful, those little hand-pinched ovens-in-miniature. Held them together long enough, fired-up enough, all-rowing-the-same-way enough, to throw a mountain into the sky in a single fevered push.

And then.

"And then they stopped," Naomi said.

“And then they walked away,” said Marguerite.

The first thunder came, far off, more felt than heard. Tomas raised the camera then — not for the mound, but for Marguerite’s face turned up at it — and then, slowly, lowered it again without firing. She’d seen him do it. Her mouth moved, not quite a smile.

“You want me to tell you what it was for,” she said. To all of them, but mostly, Naomi thought, to the question itself.

“We want to know if *you* know,” Naomi said carefully. “Not whether you’ll tell us. Those are two different questions and we’ve been mixing them up for three weeks.”

Marguerite was quiet long enough that the cane filled the silence.

“My grandmother,” she said, “didn’t call this a mystery. White folks call it a mystery because it doesn’t have a king in it and it doesn’t have a wheat field in it and it doesn’t have a date you can put a man’s name to. No name, no king, no crop — must be a *mystery*.” The word came out dry as a husk. “It’s not a mystery to be on home ground. It’s a mystery to be a stranger to it.”

The fish was very quiet now. Nobody heckled this.

“I can tell you the engineering all day,” she went on. “Kidder can. The cores can. That’s been measured, that’s been published, you can check every number and I want you to, because the numbers are the respect. But the *why they came* and the *why they stopped* —” She unfolded one arm, palm up, and turned the hand over, and that was the whole gesture: the giving and the keeping in one motion. “Some of that we hold. Some of that I don’t have either, and the part I don’t have, I’m not going to fill with a guess to make a documentary tidy. We know how they built it. We don’t know what called them. That’s not a hole in the story. That’s the size of the story.”

She let that sit.

“You can have the maybe,” she said. “The maybe’s the gift. People want me to take it from them — give them a chief, give them a calendar, give them a sky-alignment so they can stop standing in the not-knowing. Folks have tried to find the solstice in these ridges for

fifty years and they keep picking different centers and finding different lines, and you know why? Because they want it bad enough to find it." A glance at Eli, who had been about to say something about the alignment debate and now did not. "I'm not handing you a key. I'm handing you the door. Wonder all you want. Just don't wonder over us to get to it."

The rain started for real then, fat warm drops that hissed in the grass, and they all stood and didn't run for it.

Tomas had the camera up one last time, and this time he let it fire, because the thing in front of him had stopped being a question.

The light had gone strange and high and yellow-green under the storm, the light that comes once or twice a summer and makes the whole floodplain look lit from underneath. Mound A stood up out of it, seventy feet of earth that the river had failed to take for three thousand years, dark now and slicking with rain. Beyond it the ridges ran their patient arcs, holding their shape the way they'd been engineered to hold it, by people whose names were gone and whose reasons were partly given and partly kept and partly lost forever to the simple fact that they hadn't written anything down — hadn't *needed* to, maybe, having each other and the work and the season.

Nobody owned it. That was the turn, standing there getting wet. Voss hadn't gotten it. The crew didn't get it, not the meaning, not the deed, not the right to say what it was for — they'd been let in to *tell*, and the telling had a fence around it that Marguerite had built and would keep building. The community had voted to keep the place a place and not a product. And the mound itself, streaming now in the thunderlight, answered to none of them — not the buyer, not the scholars, not the crew, not even, fully, to the people who loved it most and held its story closest.

It just stood there in the rain, unclaimed and unexplained and entirely sufficient, the way it had stood through thirty centuries of wet seasons, waiting on no one to finish the sentence.

Naomi let the rain run down her face and did not reach for a single thing.

The maybe was a gift. She'd take it.

She'd been handed the door.

She left it open.

Chapter 21 — Real / Debated / Invented: A Gazetteer

The fish — a foot of laminated bass the diner kept bolted over the register, mouth cranked open mid-heckle on a brass plaque that read *YOU SHOULD SEE THE ONE THAT GOT AWAY* — watched the archivist spread eleven pages of citations across two pushed-together tables like a hand of solitaire she had no intention of losing.

“I’m building a gazetteer,” she said, to nobody, which was how she said most things. “Real, debated, invented. Three columns. So that when somebody asks us at the next place what we *know*, we don’t lie by being vague.”

The engineer leaned in. “Where does ninety days go?”

“That’s the whole question, isn’t it.” She uncapped a green pen. Green for real. “Watch.”

Here is the gazetteer, then, the way she built it that afternoon while the rain came sideways off the levee and Jakobus sat at the counter not drinking the coffee he’d ordered, turning a Poverty Point Object over in his fingers like a man reading braille on a stone the size of a walnut.

REAL. Green pen, and a lot of it.

There is a place in West Carroll Parish, Louisiana, where the ground

was shaped on purpose three thousand years ago, and it is still there. Six C-shaped ridges, nested like the rings of a felled tree turned to face the river, the outermost arc running about 1.2 kilometers across.¹ A mound at the western edge — Mound A — twenty-two meters of raised earth, roughly two hundred thirty-eight thousand cubic meters of fill, every basketful of it carried by hand.² No wheel turned here. No ox leaned into a yoke. No bronze cut anything. The people who raised it were hunters and fishers and gatherers of wild things, and the dirt itself records that men, women, and children all carried — the microstratigraphy shows the small loads beside the large, the staggered rhythm of a crowd, not a *corvée* of identical strong backs.³

“That’s the part nobody puts on the postcard,” the archivist said. “The kids. There are baby-sized basket loads in the strata. Somebody’s three-year-old hauled their handful of dirt up a hill that’s still standing.”

The engineer wrote *kids carried* on the back of his hand. He did that when something wouldn’t let go of him.

UNESCO put it on the World Heritage list in 2014.☒ Green pen, underlined twice, because that one is paper-true, you can look it up, it has a registration number.

The soils were mixed on purpose. This is real and it is, frankly, the part that makes engineers go quiet at the counter: the builders combined fill of different textures to control shrink and swell, to bind the mound against the thing that kills earthworks, which is water finding a seam. Mound A has held its form for three thousand years with very little erosion, in a floodplain, in a climate that does its level best to dissolve everything. Kidder reaches for Roman concrete and Chinese rammed earth as comparisons — not as flattery, as category.☒

“Roman concrete,” the engineer said. “We *teach* Roman concrete. There are conferences.”

“There are conferences,” the archivist agreed.

Green pen: the cooking balls. Baked loess, shaped by hand, dropped hot into earth ovens to roast food when you have no pottery to set on a fire — Poverty Point Objects, the signature artifact, thousands of them in the dirt, in patterns, in the fingerprints still pressed into the clay.☒ Jakobus had one in his hand right now. He’d asked the local if

he could hold it. He'd asked twice.

Green pen: the post rings. Magnetometry — running a sensor over the plaza to read the ghosts of decayed wood as faint magnetic shadows — found circles of buried posts in the main plaza, rings running from twenty-five to sixty-three meters across.☒ Something stood there. Something round, and large, and gone.

“Real,” the archivist said, tapping the line. “The rings are real. What stood in them is the next column.”

DEBATED. Blue pen. A thinner column, and she wrote in it more carefully, the way you walk on a dock you don't fully trust.

The trade network is real; the *map* of it is argued. Stone came to Poverty Point from far away — raw material sourced from points up to something like a thousand kilometers off, a genuinely continental reach.☒ But the famous line about Great Lakes copper has been walked back: some of what was called Great Lakes copper turned out, on better analysis, to be southern Appalachian.☒

“So it's not a thousand miles of copper road,” the engineer said, slightly crestfallen.

“It's a continental network whose *details* are disputed,” the archivist said. “Which is bigger and weirder, if you ask me. They were connected to a whole continent and we can't draw the wires clean.”

Blue pen: the sky. People have wanted Poverty Point to be an observatory for a long time, and you can see why — those ridges aim at *something*, surely. Haag proposed alignments. Purrington proposed alignments. They put the center of the site in different places to do it, which is the tell: when two careful people have to stand in two different spots to make the heavens line up, the heavens are not co-operating.¹☒ There is no consensus that Poverty Point is a calendar. There is no consensus that it is not.

“That's a clean blue,” the archivist said. “Don't let anyone sell it green.”

Blue pen, small: the extent of wild-plant management. No agriculture — that's green, that's solid, nobody's found a domesticated crop doing the work of feeding this crowd.¹¹ But how much they *tended* the

wild stand, encouraged it, came back to it — that has some give in it. Foragers are not passive. The line between gathering and gardening is a real line that gets fuzzy when you press your nose to it.

THE SPEED. She set the pens down for this one.

Tristram Kidder, Washington University, went into Mound A and read it the way you'd read a book by its binding rather than its words. If you build a mound over years, the surface between work seasons gets weathered. Rain finds it. It washes, it crusts, it grows a skin of fines, it tells you *people stopped here and the sky worked on this layer before they came back*. Kidder went looking for those skins.

He didn't find them. No weathering surfaces between the fill episodes. No rain-wash. No pause long enough for the sky to leave a mark. The mound reads as a single relentless push — a matter of months, the published estimate runs as tight as thirty to ninety days.¹²

"Ninety days," the engineer said.

The diner did its diner things. Coffee machine sighed. The fish heckled in brass.

"So which pen," he said.

The archivist looked at the speed for a while. Then she wrote it in green — because the *evidence* is green, the microstratigraphy is real, peer-reviewed, sitting in the literature with a citation you can pull — and she drew a box around the green and left the box empty inside.

"The build speed is real," she said. "How a society with no chiefs, no farms, and no writing summoned the thousands, fed them, and raised that hill in a summer — that's the box. The box stays empty. I'm not penning the box."

This is the place in the gazetteer where the loud version usually arrives. The crew had heard it in the parking lot, on the drive in, in the comments section of every video that ever pointed a drone at the ridges: that it *couldn't* have been done, that it's too much earth for

foragers, that someone — older, lost, advanced, off-world, take your pick — must have shown them how.

The archivist had a column for that too. **INVENTED.** Red pen. She wrote in it the least and crossed out the most.

Because here is the thing the loud version gets backwards, and the crew had felt it physically, out on the ridge two days ago with shovels and a survey grid and a measured cubic meter of gumbo clay they were trying to move just to *feel* the number: it was not impossible. It was worse than impossible. It was *possible*, and brutally, gloriously hard.

They had moved their cubic meter. Healthy backs, daylight, a plan drawn out the night before, water, snacks, no one shooting at them, three thousand years of leverage theory on their side. It took the four of them most of a morning, the mud gripping the baskets, the loads slumping, the engineer's careful math about loads-per-hour going sideways the instant the first basket sucked into the muck and came up forty pounds of clay and ten pounds of *opinion*. They got the cubic meter moved. They were filthy and they were quiet and the LENS had photographed all of it, low, from the dirt, so that the baskets read like the hands carrying them.

Two hundred thirty-eight thousand of those. In a season.

"That's the potato," the archivist said. "It's not that it's magic. It's that it's *labor*, real labor, an ocean of it, all aimed the same direction at the same time by people nobody made come. Cross out the aliens. They make it smaller."

Red pen, through *lost civilization*. Red pen, through *too much for foragers*. Red pen, hard, through *impossible* — and then, above it, in green, *extraordinary*.

"Extraordinary is the true word," she said. "It's the word that keeps it theirs."

Jakobus had come over at some point. He did that — you never saw him cross a room, he was just suddenly at the edge of the table, off his own ground, deferring, the cooking ball still in his hand. He set it down in the green column, on top of the citation for Poverty Point

Objects, gently, like returning a borrowed thing.

“You can read everything on this table,” he said, “and the table will still not tell you what it was for.”

It wasn’t a question. From Jakobus they rarely were. He read made things by their function — what a thing *does* tells you why it was made — and the engineer had watched him do it at four sites now, watched him pick up a stone and know it was a weight, a key, a sightline, a counterbalance, before anyone said a word.

“What’s it do,” the engineer asked him. Straight. The way you ask Jakobus.

Jakobus looked at the eleven pages. He looked, for a long moment, at the empty box around the green word *speed*.

“It holds,” he said. “Three thousand years, the river right there, and it holds. Somebody built it so it would still be here.” He tipped his head, the smallest gesture. “But holding is not *for*. A wall holds. A grave holds. A vault holds.” He picked his coffee up at last, found it cold, set it back. “I read the made thing. The thing was made to last. *Why a people who walked away wanted it to last* — that’s not in my work. That’s hers.”

And he looked at the door, because the local was coming through it, shaking rain off a state-issue jacket, and Jakobus stepped back and gave her the floor the way he always gave the local the floor — not as courtesy, as fact, because the floor was hers.

The custodian read the table upside down in about four seconds, the way she read everything on her own ground, which was faster and from a worse angle than any of them.

“Good columns,” she said. “Your blue’s honest. Most people pen the sky green.” She tapped the empty box. “And you left it empty. Smart.”

She didn’t fill it.

She put one finger on the green word — *speed* — and one finger on the red strike-through over *impossible*, and she held them both like she was completing a circuit.

“Here’s what I’ll give you for your gazetteer,” she said. “We know *how* they built it. Soil by soil, basket by basket, child by child. Kidder’s got the months, the no-weathering, all of it — that’s solid, you can carry that anywhere.” She let the *how* sit. “What we don’t know is what called them. What pulled thousands of people who answered to no king across a continent’s worth of trade to one bend in the river, made them feed each other, made them raise that mound at a dead run — and then made them, when it was done, *go*. No palace. No heir. No second act. They built the most durable thing in the valley and walked off and left it to hold.”

The rain leaned on the window.

“I could tell you what I think it was for,” she said, and the LENS, very slowly, lowered the camera — because that was the line the series always asked them to lower it on — “but I’m not going to put that in your book. Some of what this place is for is for us. Not for the page.”

She picked up the cooking ball. Turned it once. Set it back down, in the green, where it belonged.

“You can have the *how*,” she said. “The *why* you can wonder about. That’s not me being coy. That’s me leaving you the better half.”

The archivist looked at her gazetteer a long time after the local left. Three columns. Green for real. Blue for argued. Red for invented, mostly crossed out. And one box, empty, around a word that was true.

She didn’t fill the box.

She turned the page over and, on the blank back, wrote the only thing the chapter would close on — not an answer, the local had been clear, the answer was hers and partly kept — but the door:

They raised a mountain in a summer and left it to hold three thousand years. We know the how. The why walked off down the river. You’re allowed to wonder where.

The fish, over the register, heckled in brass and said nothing, which is the only thing a fish on a plaque has ever truthfully had to say.

¹ Outermost ridge ~1.2 km diameter; six nested C-shaped embankments. ² Mound A ~22 m tall, ~238,000 m³ fill, all hand-carried (30–50 lb basket loads). ³ Microstratigraphy: participation by men, women, children (Kidder, WashU). ☒ UNESCO World Heritage inscription, 2014. ☒ Deliberate soil mixing for shrink-swell/erosion control; held form ~3,000 yrs; Kidder compares to Roman concrete / Chinese rammed earth. ☒ Poverty Point Objects: baked loess “cooking balls,” earth-oven use, site signature. ☒ Magnetometry: buried wooden post rings, 25–63 m diameter, main plaza. ☒ Continental trade network; raw stone sourced up to ~1,000 km. ☒ Some “Great Lakes copper” reidentified as southern Appalachian; network continental, details disputed. ¹⁰ ☒ Astronomical alignment contested; Haag vs Purrington adopt different site centers, no consensus. ¹¹ No evidence of agriculture; extent of wild-plant management debated. ¹² Kidder microstratigraphy: no weathering/rain-wash surfaces between fill episodes ☒ no significant pauses; Mound A built in “a matter of months, possibly 30–90 days.” *Construction c. 1700–1100 BCE; majority of ridge construction 1600–1300 BCE.*



Klaus

Custos, non Conditor